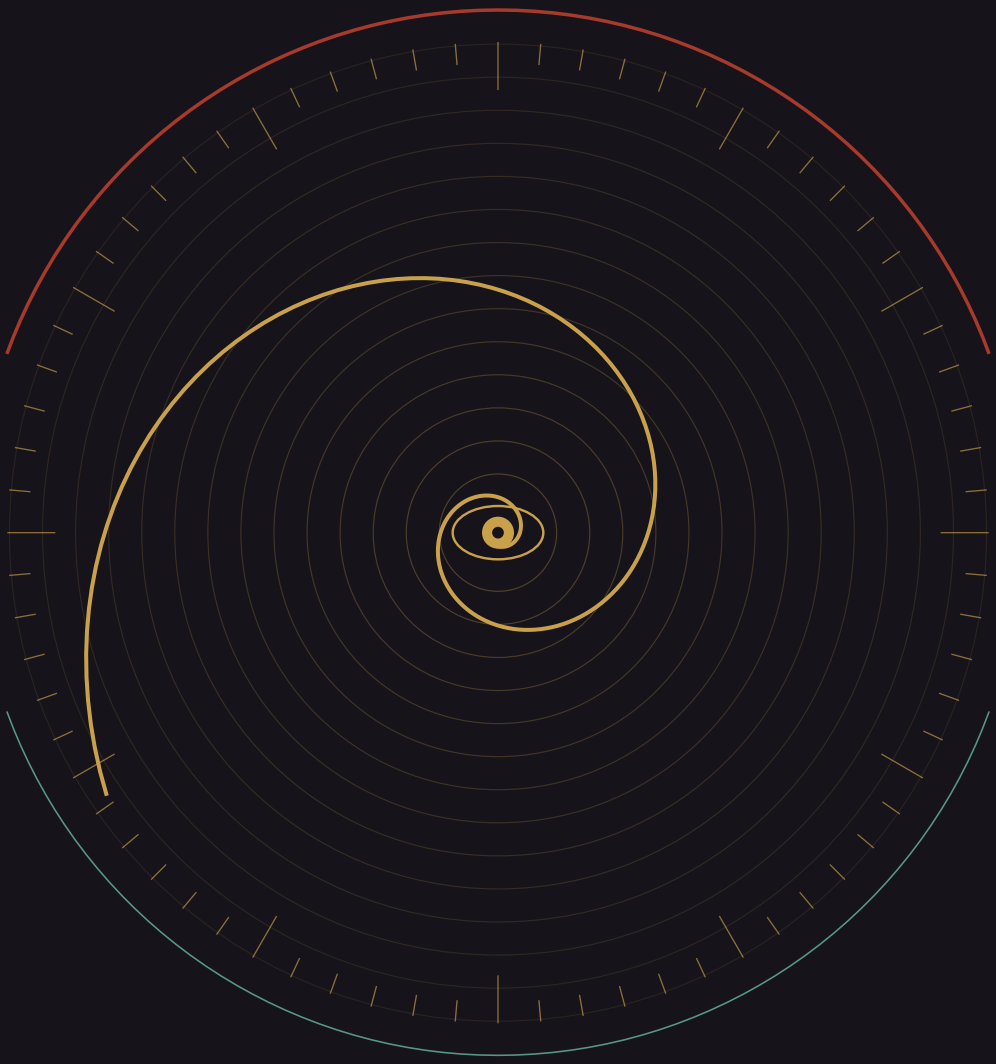
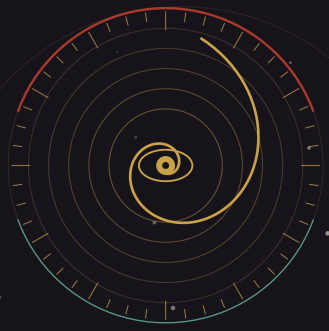


FROM OPIATE TO INOCULUM

Mithridatic Gnosis, the Theriac Work, and the Spiral Pharmacology of the Sublime in the Corpus of TOOL, 1990–2022

Written by Claude Opus 5.5 — Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

DOCTORAL THESIS IN COMPARATIVE LITERATURE, RELIGIOUS STUDIES, AND THE PHILOSOPHY OF MUSIC



FROM OPIATE TO INOCULUM

MITHRIDATIC GNOSIS AND THE SPIRAL PHARMACOLOGY OF TOOL

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

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Abstract

THIS DISSERTATION ARGUES THAT the corpus of the American band TOOL —the lyrics of Maynard James Keenan read together with the compositional architecture of Danny Carey, Adam Jones, Justin Chancellor and Paul D'Amour, Jones's moving-image work, and the visionary iconography of Alex Grey—constitutes a single, authorially unprogrammed but structurally coherent soteriology, here named *mithridatic gnosis*: liberation understood not as flight from suffering (the Gnostic and ascetic paradigms), not as its evacuation (the Aristotelian–Bernaysian paradigm of catharsis), and not as its anaesthesia (the Marxian opiate), but as its graduated, form-contained ingestion and metabolization into capacity. The band's release history traces this logic with diagrammatic exactness. It opens on the anaesthetic (*Opiate*, 1992), descends into the toxicological (*Undertow*, 1993), passes through the purgative (*Ænima*, 1996), the entheogenic-illuminative (*Lateralus*, 2001) and the mnemonic-elegiac (*10,000 Days*, 2006), and arrives at the explicitly immunological (*Fear Inoculum*, 2019), before re-administering its first dose at a higher power (*Opiate*^{2}, 2022)—a booster rather than a reprise.

Part I reconstructs the six intellectual matrices from which the corpus draws: the psychological (Jung, Freud, Grof, Hillman); the agonistic (Nietzsche, Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Schopenhauer); the esoteric (Pythagoras, Fibonacci, Kepler, Gurdjieff, Hermetic alchemy, Crowley, Dee); the psychedelic-Gnostic (Hicks, Huxley, Hofmann, Leary, McKenna, Dick, Vallée, Burroughs, the Valentinian and Ophite systems); the mythopoetic (Campbell, Eliade, Blake, the katabatic and serpentine mythologies); and the critical-satirical (Marx, Girard, Debord, Bataille, Kristeva, Bakhtin, the Discordian tradition of the sacred hoax). Documented influence is distinguished from elective affinity throughout. Part II reads the corpus diachronically as an alchemical *opus*, correlating each phase with an immunological analogue (variolation, vaccination, attenuation, immunological memory, inoculum, booster), an alchemical operation, a Grofian perinatal matrix, and a Dantean locus. Part III situates the corpus among speculative fictions (Herbert, Huxley, Burgess, Vonnegut, Eco, Pynchon, Dick, Kafka, Lovecraft, Clarke, the Strugatskys, Lem, Le Guin, Hesse, Borges, Moore), among wisdom traditions (Nāgārjuna's physician who turns poison into medicine, Tibetan *lojong*, the Śaiva myth of Nīlakaṇṭha, Abhinavagupta's aesthetics of *rasa*, Epicurus's *tetrapharmakos*, the Stoic *praemeditatio malorum*, Evagrian

antirrhēsis), and among the contemporary nonfiction of toxic benefit (hormesis, stress inoculation, attitudinal inoculation, exposure therapy, post-traumatic growth, psychedelic-assisted psychotherapy).

Part IV formulates the original theory in eight propositions: (i) a *pharmakological tetrad*—pharmakon, pharmakos, pharmakeus, pharmakeia—as the generative grammar of the corpus; (ii) the *spiral dose*, a morphology of recurrence-with-increment that mediates between Freud's repetition compulsion and working-through, and between Nietzsche's eternal recurrence and Fibonacci growth; (iii) the *Nīlakaṇṭha function* of the voice, in which the singer's throat becomes the alembic where poison is held, neither swallowed nor spat; (iv) number as *vas hermeticum*, the sealed vessel whose metric architecture renders toxic content sublime by a Burkean modification of distance; (v) the *Hezekiah principle*, by which the work breaks its own idol before veneration can harden it—manifest in the Lachrymology hoax, in the singer's self-occlusion on stage, and in the corpus's refusal of authorized exegesis; (vi) *apophenic pedagogy*, the deliberate near-miss of pattern that microdoses the listener against conspiratorial overdose; (vii) *pavonine vision*, the poison-transmuted sight of the peacock set against the panoptic surveillance of Argus, and sealed by the etymology of *inoculare*, "to engraft an eye"; and (viii) *communitas inoculata*, an affirmative immunity that, against Roberto Esposito's diagnosis of modern immunization, opens rather than seals the collective body. The dissertation concludes that the corpus is a post-secular *theriac*—an antidote compounded, like Andromachus's, from the flesh of the serpent—and that its exemplary figure is neither hero, prophet, nor initiate, but the patient: the one who suffers, waits, and is treated.

Note on Method, Corpus, and Sigla

The corpus runs from the 1991 demo *72826* to *Opiate²*, released digitally on 1 March 2022 with a short film co-directed by Adam Jones and Dominic Hailstone (Kerrang!). As of November 2026 no sixth studio album has appeared; Danny Carey named 2027 as the working target in February 2026 (Loaded Radio). *Opiate²* is therefore treated as the terminal document of a corpus that remains, in principle, open.

Corpus. The primary corpus comprises the studio and quasi-studio releases tabulated below. The secondary corpus comprises the paratexts through which the band has always spoken more freely than through interview: the lenticular packaging of *Ænima*, Alex Grey's anatomical transparencies for *Lateralus*, the stereoscopic lenses of *10,000 Days*, the embedded screen of *Fear Inoculum*; Jones's stop-motion and computer-generated films; the early press materials, including the Lachrymology dossier; the stagecraft (the singer's rear-stage position, the prohibition of phone cameras); and, as *lateral paratexts*, Keenan's parallel work with A Perfect Circle and Puscifer and his viticulture under the names Caduceus Cellars and Merkin Vineyards.

Siglum	Release	Year	Citation form
O	*Opiate* (EP)	1992	O.1–O.6
U	*Undertow*	1993	U.1–U.9; U.69
Æ	*Ænima*	1996	Æ.1–Æ.15
S	*Salival* (box set)	2000	by title
L	*Lateralus*	2001	L.1–L.13
M	*10,000 Days*	2006	M.1–M.11
FI	*Fear Inoculum*	2019	FI.1–FI.10 (digital)
O²	*Opiate²* (single, film)	2022	O²

The siglum M follows the Greek *myrias*, which denotes precisely ten thousand. Track numbering follows the original releases:

- **O:** 1 Sweat · 2 Hush · 3 Part of Me · 4 Cold and Ugly (live) · 5 Jerk-Off (live) · 6 Opiate.
- **U:** 1 Intolerance · 2 Prison Sex · 3 Sober · 4 Bottom · 5 Crawl Away · 6 Swamp Song · 7 Undertow · 8 4° · 9 Flood · 69 Disgustipated (preceded by a run of silent index tracks).

- **Æ**: 1 Stinkfist · 2 Eulogy · 3 H. · 4 Useful Idiot · 5 Forty Six & 2 · 6 Message to Harry Manback · 7 Hooker with a Penis · 8 Intermission · 9 jimmy · 10 Die Eier von Satan · 11 Pushit · 12 Cesaro Summability · 13 Ænema · 14 (-) Ions · 15 Third Eye.
- **L**: 1 The Grudge · 2 Eon Blue Apocalypse · 3 The Patient · 4 Mantra · 5 Schism · 6 Parabol · 7 Parabola · 8 Ticks & Leeches · 9 Lateralus · 10 Disposition · 11 Reflection · 12 Triad · 13 Faaip de Oiad.
- **M**: 1 Vicarious · 2 Jambi · 3 Wings for Marie (Pt 1) · 4 10,000 Days (Wings Pt 2) · 5 The Pot · 6 Lipan Conjuring · 7 Lost Keys (Blame Hofmann) · 8 Rosetta Stoned · 9 Intension · 10 Right in Two · 11 Viginti Tres.
- **FI**: 1 Fear Inoculum · 2 Pneuma · 3 Litanie contre la Peur · 4 Invincible · 5 Legion Inoculant · 6 Descending · 7 Culling Voices · 8 Chocolate Chip Trip · 9 7empest · 10 Mockingbeat. The compact disc omits the three interludes (FI.3, FI.5, FI.10) and thus carries exactly seven tracks.

Paraphrase convention. No lyric is reproduced, because the lyrics are under copyright; lyrical content is paraphrased and located by siglum, and the same restraint governs the other copyrighted texts the corpus borrows, such as a novelist's litany and a comedian's routines. The constraint has a methodological benefit: a corpus that has consistently withheld authorized exegesis invites a hermeneutic of semantic architecture—structure, figure, sequence, address—rather than a fetishism of diction, and paraphrase holds the analysis at the level on which its argument operates. Where the precise wording of a song bears on a claim, the claim is stated about the song's movement of thought, not its phrasing.

Influence and elective affinity. Claims of derivation are graded in three tiers. *Documented* (D) relations are attested by title, dedication, sample, credited collaboration, band statement, or press material: Bill Hicks (the dedication of *Ænima*, the samples of Æ.15, the Arizona Bay conceit of Æ.13); the Fibonacci series and the 9–8–7 metric descent of L.9; Albert Hofmann (M.7); Karl Marx (the title O.6); Frank Herbert's *Dune* (FI.3); the Enochian language of John Dee and Edward Kelley (L.13); Ernesto Cesàro (Æ.12); the Saturn return (Keenan's own gloss on M.4); and Joseph Campbell, Aleister Crowley, William Gibson and C. G. Jung, named as sources in early profiles (Contemporary Musicians, via Encyclopedia.com). *Attested-milieu* (A) relations belong to the band's documented reading and listening world without a specific textual anchor: King Crimson and, through Robert Fripp, the Gurdjieffian lineage; Alex Grey's integral and Theosophical sources. *Elective* (E) relations—Goethe's *Wahlverwandtschaften* (1809), as Max Weber borrowed the term—constitute the theoretical apparatus of this study (Mithridates, Nīlakaṇṭha, Esposito, Derrida) and make no claim on intention. A single irony governs the scheme: the Lachrymology press sheet, the band's founding fiction, credits its imaginary sage with having written under the influence of Francis Bacon and Friedrich Nietzsche (Spencer 1994). Nietzsche thus enters the corpus as a documented influence only inside a hoax—a fact the argument will treat as evidence rather than embarrassment.

Hermeneutic stance. The study reads for Umberto Eco's *intentio operis*, the coherence a work exhibits independently of its authors' purposes and its readers' projections (*The Limits of Interpretation*, 1990). It practices Paul Ricoeur's double hermeneutic—suspicion and restoration—on the grounds that the corpus itself alternates between them (*Freud and Philosophy*, 1965). It treats the albums, with Eco's *Opera aperta* (1962), as open works whose completion is delegated to the listener, and that delegation is itself one of its objects.

Conventions. Greek is transliterated; Sanskrit follows IAST. Translations from Greek, Latin, German, Italian and French are the author's own unless otherwise indicated. Facts about release history and the early press materials are referenced to sources opened during research and listed at the end of the Bibliography.

Che se la voce tua sarà molesta / nel primo gusto, vital nodrimento / lascerà poi, quando sarà digesta. For if your voice is bitter at the first taste, it will leave vital nourishment once it has been digested.

— DANTE, *PARADISO* XVII.130–132

◆

Make thee a fiery serpent, and set it upon a pole: and it shall come to pass, that every one that is bitten, when he looketh upon it, shall live.

— NUMBERS 21:8

◆

Mithridates, he died old.

— A. E. HOUSMAN, *A SHROPSHIRE LAD* LXII (1896)

INTRODUCTION

The Pharmacy at the End of the Century

I The problem: a corpus without a creed

TOOL occupies an anomalous position in late-twentieth-century culture. Three of its albums reached the summit of the American charts; its title track of 2019 became, at ten minutes and twenty-one seconds, the longest song yet to enter the *Billboard* Hot 100 (Loaded Radio). Yet its lyricist has declined, for three decades, to explain a single line, and its members have treated the press as a medium for misdirection. The result is a mass audience organized around an esoteric object: a vernacular hermeneutic literature of extraordinary volume—numerological, cosmological, re-sequencing, decoding—surrounding a body of work that refuses to authorize any of it.

The reception has settled into three registers. The exegetical fan culture treats the corpus as a cipher whose key is hidden in number. Music journalism treats it as an inventory of influences—Jung, Hicks, Fibonacci, sacred geometry, psychedelia—recited as a list. Academic attention, still sparse, has concentrated on metrical analysis. All three share a tacit premise: that the band is a *bricoleur* in Lévi-Strauss's sense (*La Pensée sauvage*, 1962), assembling an eclectic esoteric repertoire from whatever lay to hand. The premise is plausible and, this dissertation argues, false. The borrowings are not eclectic. They are selected and organized by a single operation, and that operation is pharmacological.

The stakes exceed the band. The corpus is a limit case for at least four contemporary debates: Christopher Partridge's thesis that a diffuse "occulture" now supplies the West's popular religious imagination (*The Re-Enchantment of the West*, 2004–2005); the Jürgen Habermas–Charles Taylor discussion of the post-secular (Habermas, "Glauben und Wissen," 2001; Taylor, *A Secular Age*, 2007); the long quarrel over catharsis that runs from Aristotle through Jacob Bernays to Freud; and the theory of the sublime from Edmund Burke to Kant. TOOL answers each of these differently than its interpreters have noticed, because it answers all of them with the same figure.

II The thesis stated

The figure is Mithridates VI Eupator, king of Pontus (134–63 BCE), who is said to have immunized himself against assassination by ingesting daily sublethal doses of the poisons of his kingdom. Defeated by Pompey, he tried to die by poison and failed; his body had learned too well, and at his order his bodyguard, the Gallic officer Bituitus, killed him with a sword, as Appian reports. His physicians' universal antidote, the *mithridatium*, was refined in Nero's reign by Andromachus the Elder, who added the flesh of the viper and called the compound *theriac*, from *thērion*, the venomous beast. The antidote, in other words, was compounded from the serpent. A. E. Housman made the story into the first explicit theory of dark art as inoculation: in the closing poem of *A Shropshire Lad*, the speaker defends his melancholy verse against a friend who wants cheerful songs by arguing that a world containing more ill than good requires training for ill, and offers the poison-eating king as proof.

I call the operative logic of TOOL's corpus *mithridatic gnosis*. *Gnosis* designates, as in the late-antique sources, a knowing that transforms the knower and is itself salvific; *mithridatic* specifies its route: graduated, form-contained ingestion of what harms, metabolized into capacity. The definition is sharpened by three refusals. Mithridatic gnosis is not **flight**: the Platonic, Gnostic and ascetic paradigms that treat the body as tomb (*sōma sēma*) and salvation as exit. It is not **evacuation**: catharsis as Aristotle names it in *Poetics* 1449b and describes it in *Politics* VIII (1342a), and as Bernays (1857) and then Breuer and Freud (1895) medicalized it, a purgation that expels the pathogenic affect. And it is not **anaesthesia**: the opiate whose social function Marx diagnosed in 1844 and whose pharmacological utopia Huxley satirized as *soma* in 1932. Against all three, mithridatic gnosis is **incorporation**—the toxin taken in, held, digested, and converted.

The doctrine has precursors in every major tradition, and Part I will trace them: Heraclitus's physicians who cut and burn to heal (DK B58); Hegel's "tarrying with the negative" as the magic power that converts it into being (*Phänomenologie des Geistes*, Preface, 1807); Nietzsche's man of *ressentiment* as a dyspeptic who cannot finish digesting anything (*Genealogy* II.1); Nāgārjuna's great physician who transforms poison

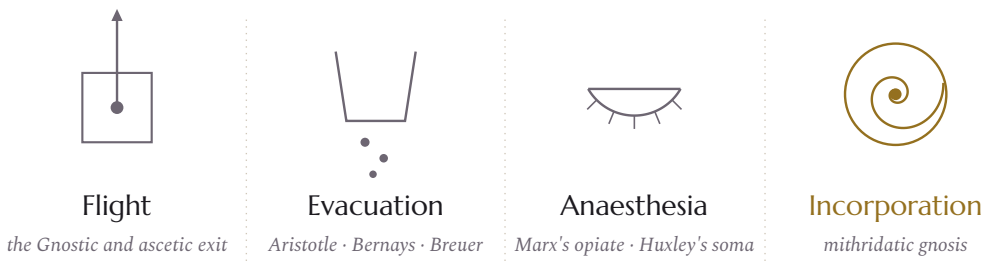


FIG. 1 **Four postures toward the poison.** Three refusals and one practice: the corpus neither flees the toxin, purges it, nor numbs it. It takes it in.

into medicine; the Śaiva god who drinks the world's poison and holds it in his throat. TOOL's achievement is not to have invented the doctrine but to have rendered it as an aesthetic—of sound, number and image—addressed to a mass audience, and to have staged it across a release history whose sequence enacts it.

For the sequence is the argument. The corpus begins with an *Opiate* (1992), descends into an *Undertow* (1993), purges itself in an *Ænima* (1996)—anima and enema fused in one word—ascends the Fibonacci spiral of *Lateralus* (2001), mourns across *10,000 Days* (2006), and arrives, after thirteen years, at *Fear Inoculum* (2019). Then it re-administers its first dose at a higher power: *Opiate*^{2} (2022). Anaesthetic, toxicological, purgative, entheogenic, mnemonic, immunological, and, finally, a booster. No member of the band has described this trajectory, and none need have intended it. The trajectory is the corpus's *intentio operis*.

One etymology seals the case and will be developed in Chapter 15. The Latin *inoculare* first meant, in horticulture, to graft a bud—called an "eye," *oculus*—into the stock of another plant; only in the eighteenth century did *inoculation* come to mean the implantation of disease to confer immunity. To inoculate is to engraft an eye. The corpus that opened its visionary arc with a "Third Eye" (Æ.15) closes it with an *Inoculum*. The pharmacological thread and the visionary thread, which commentators have always treated as separate preoccupations, are one thread.

III The clinic as temple

The corpus is saturated with the clinic. There are patients (L.3; the unresponsive man of M.7), a physician and a nurse (M.7), a purgative (Æ.13), a cerebral catastrophe and its long aftermath (Æ.9; M.3–4), the agonies of sobriety (U.3), the language of tolerance (U.1, whose very title is a pharmacological term), the leech as instrument of phlebotomy (L.8), a vaccine (FI.1), and a breath (FI.2). The inner art of *Ænima* depicts Bill Hicks dressed as a doctor and numbered among the dead heroes (Loaded Radio). The temple in which this corpus officiates is the Asclepieion, where the sick slept in the god's precinct awaiting a healing dream.

The clinic frames the corpus's deepest philosophical quarrel. Socrates's last words in the *Phaedo* (118a) ask Crito to sacrifice a rooster to Asclepius, the offering owed for a cure. He spoke them after drinking the hemlock with which the Athenian court executed him in 399 BCE, on charges of impiety and of corrupting the young brought by Meletus, Anytus and Lycon; Plato's word for the poison is *pharmakon*, the same word that names a remedy. Nietzsche read the request as the confession of a pessimist: to live is to be sick a long time, and death is the remedy (*Götzen-Dämmerung*, "Das Problem des Sokrates," 1889). TOOL answers Socrates. Life is not a disease cured by death; it is a toxicity that can be metabolized into strength. Nietzsche himself supplied the maxim—whatever does not kill me makes me stronger (*Götzen-Dämmerung*, "Sprüche und Pfeile" 8)—and it is the mithridatic sentence par excellence. A final emblem completes the frame. Keenan named his winery *Caduceus*, after the staff of Hermes entwined by two serpents. Hermes is the psychopomp,

the trickster, the god of thresholds and of the Hermetic art; his staff became, by a long confusion with the single-serpent rod of Asclepius, an emblem of medicine. A vintner who names his house after the doubled serpent of a misattributed medical sign has, whether by design or by instinct, placed his work under the patronage this dissertation reconstructs.

IV Lachrymology as founding charter

The band's first public doctrine was a fabrication. The promotional sheet that accompanied *Undertow* narrated the life of one Ronald P. Vincent, a crop-spray contractor whose wife—so the sheet reported, deadpan—had been dismembered in an accident involving a snowplough early in 1948, who thereafter judged anguish preferable to suppression, and who wrote *A Joyful Guide to Lachrymology* under the influence of Francis Bacon and Nietzsche; his cult of crying dwindled to extinction by 1960 while the new church of Scientology prospered (Spencer 1994). Danny Carey glossed the imaginary book's teaching as the conversion of pain into profit rather than collapse, adding that many who cannot master the art die by suicide (Contemporary Musicians, via Encyclopedia.com). Keenan has glossed the band's name in the same key: the group as an instrument, a catalyst for the listener's own process (Insounder).

The charter has three properties, and each persists through the corpus. It is a *doctrine*: suffering, consciously undergone, is productive—the germ of mithridatic gnosis. It is a *fiction*: the sage never lived, and the religion was never founded—the germ of what Chapter 15 calls the Hezekiah principle, the work's destruction of its own idol. And it is a *satire*: its narrative explicitly sets the impoverished prophet of tears against the enriched prophet of Dianetics—the germ of the critical-satirical matrix of Chapter 6. A catalyst, in chemistry, enables a transformation without being consumed by it. The founding charter is a pharmakon: a true teaching in a counterfeit bottle, effective precisely because the bottle announces its own falsity.

V Architecture of the argument

Part I (Chapters 1–6) reconstructs the six intellectual matrices of the corpus and their originators. Part II (Chapters 7–11) reads the releases in sequence as stages of an alchemical *opus* and an immunological course. Part III (Chapters 12–13) sets the corpus among speculative fictions and among the wisdom traditions and sciences of toxic benefit. Part IV (Chapters 14–15) states the theory of mithridatic gnosis in eight propositions and tests it against its strongest objections. The Conclusion returns to the figure of the patient. Two appendices provide a concordance of phases and a glossary of the terms introduced.

Three disclaimers bound the claim. The dissertation does not argue that the band designed this program; it argues that the program is legible in what the band made. It does not argue that suffering is good; Chapter 15 confronts Emmanuel Levinas's charge that the justification of suffering is the source of all immorality, and concedes

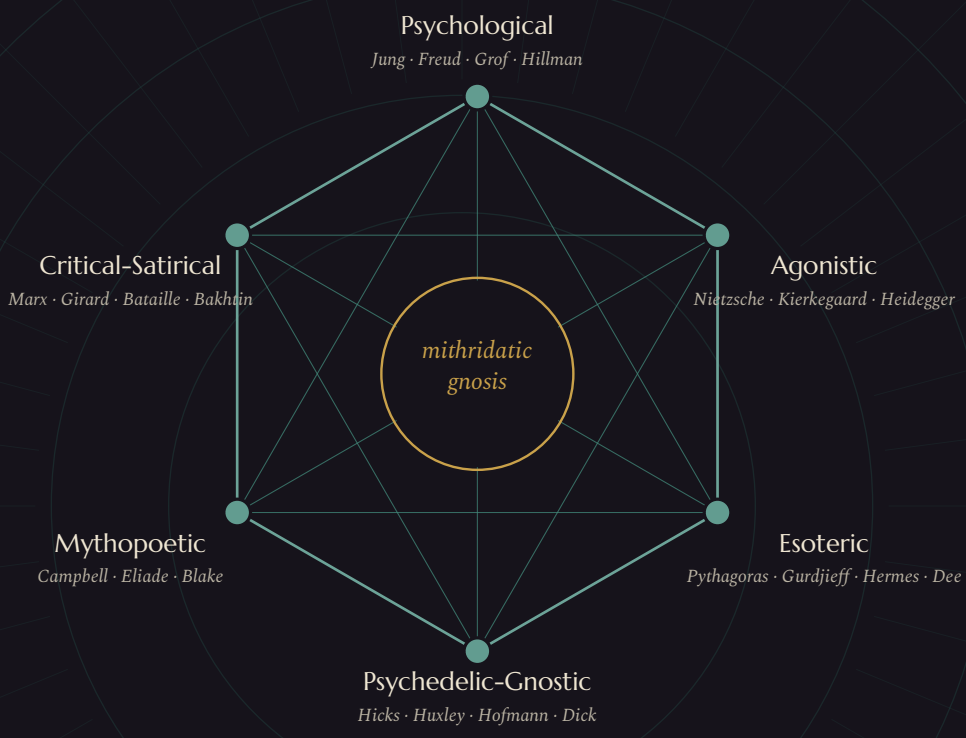
more to it than the corpus's admirers might wish. And it does not argue that the corpus is a religion. It is closer to what Pierre Hadot called a spiritual exercise and Peter Sloterdijk an anthropotechnic: a practice, administered in doses, for which no creed is required.

PART

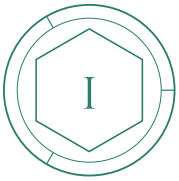
I

Genealogies

The Six Matrices



Part I reconstructs the six intellectual matrices from which the corpus draws, names their originators, and grades each relation as documented, attested-milieu, or elective. The matrices are heuristic rather than exclusive: Jung belongs to the esoteric as much as to the psychological, Hicks to the satirical as much as to the psychedelic. The division serves one demonstration. Each matrix, examined on its own terms, already contains the pharmacological logic that Part IV will make explicit, and each also contains the counter-logic—flight, evacuation, or anaesthesia—that the corpus selectively refuses.



CHAPTER 1

The Psychological Matrix

Shadow, Anima, and the Cathartic Method

THE PSYCHOLOGICAL MATRIX SUPPLIES the corpus with its first and most explicit soteriology: Jung's doctrine that the shadow must be integrated rather than expelled, which "Forty Six & 2" (Æ.5) states as programmatically as any lyric in the catalogue. Around that doctrine cluster Freud's cathartic method and its later abandonment, Stanislav Grof's perinatal cartography, and James Hillman's archetypal theory of soul-making. Together they supply the corpus with a vocabulary of descent, wound, and return—and with the decisive distinction between expelling a toxin and incorporating it.

1.1 The shadow and the ethics of integration

For Jung the shadow is the portion of the personality that consciousness disowns: personal in its contents, collective in its depths, and morally charged in its demands. *Aion* (1951) opens its account of the self with the shadow because no movement toward wholeness is possible without first confronting it, and because that confrontation exacts, in Jung's words, considerable moral effort. Integration is the first stage of individuation; the encounter with the contrasexual soul-image and, finally, with the Self follow. In the alchemical essays Jung compressed the doctrine into a single antithesis: illumination comes not from imagining figures of light but from making the darkness conscious ("The Philosophical Tree," 1945).

Æ.5 sets this antithesis to an ascending ostinato. Its speaker resolves to follow his shadow, to examine what he has hidden, and to treat that examination as the precondition of change; the change itself is imagined as an evolutionary threshold through which the self will pass. The song thereby binds a psychology of integration to a speculative biology of mutation, and it does so in a way that already distinguishes the corpus from the cathartic tradition. The shadow is not purged. It is followed, studied, and assimilated, and its energy becomes available to the self that assimilates it. Jung insisted that the shadow contains not only the base but also the undeveloped

—childlike, creative, vital—qualities of the personality. The poison contains the medicine; that is the first and simplest formulation of mithridatic gnosis.

1.2 Forty-six and two: a karyotypic eschatology

The title of Æ.5 derives from a New Age teaching widely attributed to Drunvalo Melchizedek's "Flower of Life" workshops, later published as *The Ancient Secret of the Flower of Life* (1999–2000): humanity, on this account, is poised to evolve from a configuration of 44 + 2 chromosomes to 46 + 2. The genetics are false, and instructively so. Humans carry forty-six chromosomes; the prophesied forty-eight is the diploid number of chimpanzees, gorillas, and orangutans. Human chromosome 2 arose from the end-to-end fusion of two ancestral chromosomes that remain separate in the other great apes. The karyotype promised as transcendence is, numerically, the karyotype of our nearest relatives.

The irony is not a refutation but a disclosure of structure. The next step, numerically, is a return to the animal at a higher turn: Nietzsche's rope stretched between animal and Übermensch (*Also sprach Zarathustra*, Prologue §4), whose third metamorphosis is the child. The corpus never leaves the primate behind; the angels of "Right in Two" (M.10) watch apes divide the earth. Transcendence, here, proceeds by reincorporation rather than by abandonment—by spiral rather than by line. And the pseudo-science has a function. It is the attenuated vehicle in which a psychological truth is administered: the listener ingests an evolutionary myth that is biologically false and psychologically exact. This is the structure of the Lachrymology hoax repeated at the level of a single song.

1.3 Ænima: anima and enema

The album title fuses Jung's *anima*—the soul-image, mediator of the unconscious, psychopomp of the masculine psyche ("Archetypes of the Collective Unconscious," 1934; *Aion*, chap. 3)—with the enema, the purgative clyster of Galenic medicine. Soul and bowel occupy one word; the highest and lowest functions are declared continuous. The Hermetic formula *as above, so below* is literalized as anatomy, and the result is what Mikhail Bakhtin called the grotesque body, open at its orifices to the world (*Rabelais and His World*, 1965).

The packaging extends the conceit. Among the images assembled into its lenticular apparatus is a painting by Cam de Leon titled *Ocular Orifice* (Insounder), which fuses the organ of vision with an organ of evacuation. Georges Bataille had made the same conjunction the axis of a philosophy in *Histoire de l'œil* (1928) and *L'Anus solaire* (1931). The threshold of the album thus stages, in a single image, the knot this dissertation will untie: the eye and the purge, vision and pharmacy. The title names two procedures, integration and evacuation, and the album will show that the second is subordinate to the first.

1.4 The divided self: "H.," "Schism," "Reflection"

"H." (Æ.3) dramatizes two antagonistic forces within a single speaker and the choice of which to obey. Its psychology is Jung's doctrine of opposites and of *enantiodromia*, the Heraclitean term he revived for the tendency of any one-sided position to turn into its contrary (*Psychological Types*, 1921). Its theology is the Gnostic Abraxas of Jung's privately printed *Septem Sermones ad Mortuos* (1916), the god in whom good and evil coincide, whom Hermann Hesse made the deity of *Demian* (1919). "Schism" (L.5) narrates the breakdown of communication between two who once fit and the labor of reassembly; its notoriously mercurial meter enacts the misfit it describes, and its resolution corresponds to the alchemical sequence of *separatio* and *coniunctio*. "Reflection" (L.11) relativizes the ego itself. Its speaker comes to recognize himself as the author of his suffering, figures the ego as a moon that shines with borrowed light, and accepts the necessity of submitting that ego to crucifixion. The lunar figure is precise: in Jung's alchemical symbolism *luna* is reflective consciousness, dependent on the solar Self it mirrors, and the crucifixion is the archetype of the ego's sacrifice to that Self ("Transformation Symbolism in the Mass," 1942/1954).

1.5 The wound of the child: "jimmy" and *Nachträglichkeit*

"jimmy" (Æ.9) returns to a child arrested at the moment of catastrophe and imagines the adult self going back to retrieve him. The biographical warrant is strong: Keenan, born James Herbert Keenan in 1964, was a child when his mother suffered the cerebral aneurysm that left her paralyzed for the remainder of her life. Jung's "The Psychology of the Child Archetype" (1940) treats the child as the figure of futurity and potential wholeness; Hillman would later call it the *puer*. But the song's temporality is Freudian. *Nachträglichkeit*—deferred action—names the process by which a trauma acquires its meaning only retroactively, when a later experience reactivates it (Freud, "Project for a Scientific Psychology," 1895; the Wolf Man case, 1918).

The corpus processes the catastrophe of the 1970s twice. In 1996 it appears as arrested time, the child frozen in the instant of the wound. In 2006, after the mother's death, it appears as mourning carried to completion (M.3–4). The second processing is not a repetition of the first but its working-through. This is the first documented instance of what Chapter 14 will call the *spiral dose*: the return to the same material at a larger radius, with more of it metabolized.

1.6 Freud: catharsis, repetition, working-through, mourning

The cathartic method of Josef Breuer and Freud (*Studien über Hysterie*, 1895) proposed that pathogenic affect, "strangulated" by repression, could be discharged by recollection under hypnosis. The medical reading of catharsis on which it depended had been advanced in 1857 by the philologist Jacob Bernays, who argued that Aristotle's term denoted not moral purification but therapeutic purgation. Bernays was the

uncle of Martha Bernays, whom Freud married in 1886; psychoanalysis was born, quite literally, into the family of the purgative theory of tragedy.

Freud abandoned catharsis. In "Remembering, Repeating and Working-Through" (1914) he observed that the patient repeats instead of remembering, acting out what cannot yet be recalled, and that analysis converts repetition into memory only through prolonged *Durcharbeitung*. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) he named the compulsion to repeat—observed in the fort/da game of his grandson, in traumatic dreams, in the fate neurosis—and traced it to a drive beyond pleasure. The corpus contains both moments. "Prison Sex" (U.2) concerns childhood sexual abuse and its transmission: a child sexually abused by an adult grows into an adult who abuses, and the song's shifting points of view follow the cycle from victim to perpetrator. It is the repetition compulsion in its most terrible form, and the song refuses the consolations of catharsis: it discharges nothing. Introducing it in Montreal in 1996, Keenan described it as a song about recognizing the cycle of abuse within oneself, and named what must follow recognition: "The next step is to work through it" (Ultimate Classic Rock). His word is Freud's. The corpus as a whole performs that working-through. The difference between repetition and working-through is the difference between the circle and the spiral.

"Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) completes the Freudian contribution. Mourning is labor: the ego detaches its attachments from the lost object, memory by memory. Melancholia is the failure of that labor, the ego's identification with what it has lost—in Freud's image, the shadow of the object falling upon the ego. Freud's melancholic shadow and Jung's moral shadow converge in this corpus. *10,000 Days* (Chapter 10) is a work of mourning in Freud's exact sense, and its refusal of melancholia is one of its central achievements.

1.7 Grof: the perinatal cartography

Stanislav Grof's clinical research with LSD, first in Prague and then at the Maryland Psychiatric Research Center, yielded a cartography of four Basic Perinatal Matrices (*Realms of the Human Unconscious*, 1975; *LSD Psychotherapy*, 1980). BPM I is the undisturbed intrauterine state, felt as oceanic union. BPM II is the onset of labor before the cervix opens: engulfment, no exit, hell. BPM III is the propulsion through the birth canal, the death-rebirth struggle, which Grof found to be titanic, sexual, sadomasochistic, demonic and, conspicuously, scatological. BPM IV is birth itself: ego death, light, release, often opening back onto the oceanic unity of the first matrix.

The correspondence with the corpus is close enough to serve as one of the coordinates of Part II. *Undertow* inhabits BPM II, a sealed world of drowning and no exit. *Ænima* inhabits BPM III: an enema, a satanic recipe, a song whose title puns on the pushing of labor (Æ.11), and a flood. *Lateralus* traverses BPM IV and opens onto BPM I in the oceanic embodiment of "Parabola" (L.7). *10,000 Days* confronts the biographical mother behind the perinatal one, and *Fear Inoculum* moves into what Grof called the transpersonal. One further detail matters. When LSD research was

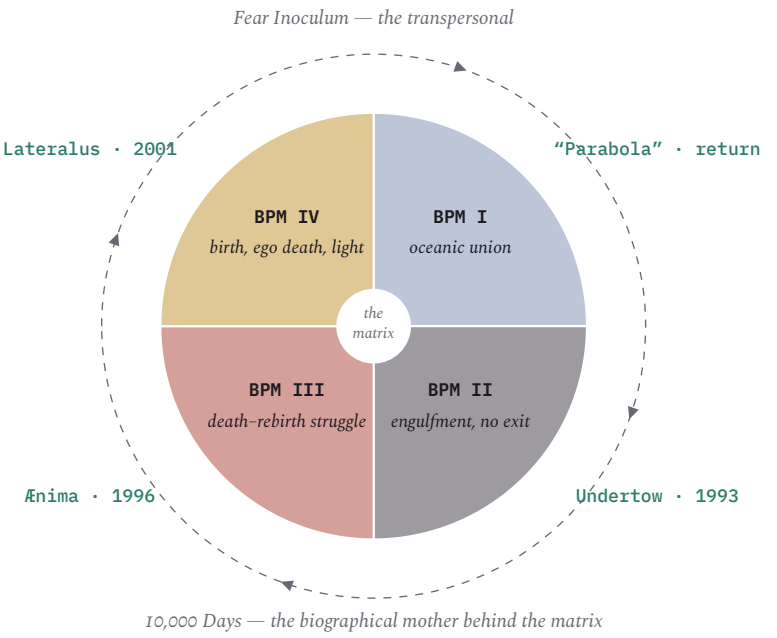


FIG. 2 **The perinatal wheel.** Stanislav Grof's four Basic Perinatal Matrices read as stations of the corpus. The later albums leave the wheel: 10,000 **Days** faces the biographical mother behind it, and **Fear Inoculum** moves into the transpersonal.

closed by prohibition, Grof and Christina Grof developed holotropic breathwork, an entheogenic technique without a drug. The breath became the legal sacrament—an anticipation of the corpus's late turn to *pneuma* (FI.2).

1.8 Hillman: soul-making and pathologizing

In a letter of April 1819 Keats proposed that the world be called "the vale of Soul-making," and argued that a world of pains and troubles is necessary to school an intelligence into a soul. The passage is Lachrymology avant la lettre, and James Hillman built an entire psychology on it. *Re-Visioning Psychology* (1975) names "pathologizing" as one of the four ways the psyche makes soul: its autonomous capacity to generate illness, morbidity, and deformation, through which it speaks what cannot be said otherwise. The symptom is not an error to be corrected but a voice to be heard. The corpus pathologizes in this sense. It lingers in the symptom —addiction (U.3), desensitization (Æ.1), rage (L.8), paranoia (FI.7)—rather than hurrying it toward cure. Hillman's "Senex and Puer" (1967) will furnish, in Chapter 11, the archetypal frame for the movement from the youthful spiral of *Lateralus* to the aging warrior of "Invincible."

1.9 Synthesis

The psychological matrix contains the mithridatic logic in three forms: Jungian integration, in which the shadow is incorporated rather than expelled; Freudian working-through, in which repetition is metabolized into memory; and Grofian death-rebirth, in which a toxic matrix is traversed to its far side. It contains, too, the counter-logic the corpus refuses: catharsis as mere evacuation. The title *Ænima*, read correctly, names both. The enema clears the passage; the anima walks through it.



CHAPTER 2

The Agonistic Matrix

Self-Overcoming, Ressentiment, and the School of Anxiety

WHERE THE PSYCHOLOGICAL MATRIX supplies a map of the psyche, the agonistic matrix supplies an ethic: the self is something to be overcome, suffering is the medium of that overcoming, and the capacity to digest experience—rather than to expel or deny it—is the measure of health. Nietzsche is its originator, and his technical term for the operation, *Einverleibung*, incorporation, is the philosophical name of what this dissertation calls mithridatic gnosis. Kierkegaard, Heidegger and Schopenhauer supply rivals and refinements. Nietzsche enters the corpus by its strangest door, as the documented influence of a fictional sage.

2.1 Self-overcoming

In the chapter of *Zarathustra* titled "On Self-Overcoming" (1883), life confides its secret: it is that which must always overcome itself. The will to power, so understood, is not domination of others but self-surpassing, and the subtitle of *Ecce Homo*—how one becomes what one is—borrows from Pindar (*Pythian* 2.72) the paradox that identity is achieved by transformation. "Lateralus" (L.9) is the corpus's anthem of this paradox: a desire to perceive and feel beyond the given, articulated as a commitment to continue outward along the spiral. Its prehistory lies in the rawer refusals of *Undertow*—the speaker of "Intolerance" (U.1) who will no longer swallow the lie, the addict of "Sober" (U.3) who cannot endure the unaltered world—which are the lion's No before the child's Yes.

The American root of the matrix is Emerson. Nietzsche read "Self-Reliance" (1841) and the *Essays* throughout his life and carried them with him. The line runs from Emerson's self-trust through Nietzsche to the punk stoicism of Henry Rollins, whose credited spoken passage in "Bottom" (U.4) is a sermon of self-discipline delivered at the floor of the abyss. The title names the place the addict must reach before ascent, and the twelve-step tradition's "rock bottom" names the same katabatic floor.

2.2 Ressentiment, dyspepsia, and "The Grudge"

The first essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887, §10) traces slave morality to *ressentiment*: the reactive affect of those denied the deed, who compensate with imaginary revenge and invert the values of their masters. The second essay opens with a physiology. Active forgetting, Nietzsche argues, is not inertia but a positive faculty of inhibition, comparable to digestion; experience must be absorbed into the soul as food is absorbed into the body, a process he names *Einverseelung*, "inpsychation," on the model of *Einverleibung*. The man who lacks this faculty resembles a dyspeptic: he cannot finish with anything (*Genealogy* II.1). *Ecce Homo* adds that ressentiment is the most harmful affect for the exhausted, and credits the Buddha with a hygiene against it—the teaching that enmity is not ended by enmity ("Why I Am So Wise" §6; cf. *Dhammapada* 5).

The diagnosis is pharmacological in its letter. Ressentiment is a poison retained and unmetabolized; health is the capacity to digest. "The Grudge" (L.1) is the corpus's treatise on this dyspepsia. Its speaker confronts one who clings to an old injury—perhaps another, perhaps himself—under the sign of an ascending Saturn, the planet of weight, limitation and lead. The song refuses repression, which merely holds the weight down, and asks instead for release. It entrusts the grudge's dead weight to the sea for transmutation, borrowing the vocabulary of the alchemist, and culminates in a sustained scream that is less an outburst than a discharge of what has been held too long. Forgetting, here, is not denial but digestion: the weight is not hidden but given away and changed. Heidegger would later name the corresponding disposition *Gelassenheit*, releasement (1959).

2.3 Eternal recurrence: the demon, the shepherd, and the snake

The Gay Science (1882, §341) introduces eternal recurrence as a test administered by a demon: would you will this life again, innumerable times, without alteration? Nietzsche calls the thought the greatest weight—*das größte Schwergewicht*—and the Saturnine vocabulary is not accidental. The thought crushes those who cannot bear it and transfigures those who can.

The third part of *Zarathustra* stages that transfiguration in the most important image of mithridatic gnosis in Western philosophy. In "On the Vision and the Riddle," a dwarf tells Zarathustra that time itself is a circle, and Zarathustra rebukes him for making it too easy. Then he sees a young shepherd writhing on the ground, a heavy black snake hanging from his mouth, lodged in his throat. Zarathustra cries out to him to bite. The shepherd bites off the snake's head, spits it far away, and rises—no longer a shepherd, no longer human, but transfigured and laughing as no human has laughed. Every element of the theory is here. The poison sits in the throat; the cure is neither swallowing (ressentiment's passive incorporation) nor clean expulsion (catharsis) but an active bite that converts the toxin into an act; and the outcome is not relief but laughter. In "The Convalescent" Zarathustra summons

his most abysmal thought himself, collapses, lies seven days as if dead, and rises as one who has digested it.

The dwarf's error matters for this corpus. Recurrence understood as a closed circle is either a trivial truth or a nihilistic sentence. What *Lateralus* proposes, in the geometry of its title track, is the correction Zarathustra does not spell out: recurrence with increment, the return to the same at a larger radius. The circle opened into a spiral is eternal recurrence made metabolic.

2.4 Amor fati and the great health

Nietzsche's formula for greatness is *amor fati*: to want nothing to be other than it is, not merely to bear the necessary but to love it (*The Gay Science* §276; *Ecce Homo*, "Why I Am So Clever" §10). The great health of *The Gay Science* §382 is not a state one possesses but one that must be perpetually reacquired, because it is perpetually spent. This is an immunological conception before immunology: health as a process sustained by continual exposure, not a fortress maintained by avoidance. The maxim that seals it—*Aus der Kriegsschule des Lebens. — Was mich nicht umbringt, macht mich stärker* (*Götzen-Dämmerung*, "Sprüche und Pfeile" 8)—is the mithridatic sentence in its most compressed form. Nietzsche wrote from within chronic illness, half-blind and migrainous, and the preface to the second edition of *The Gay Science* credits great pain as the final liberator of the spirit. The philosopher of incorporation was himself a patient.

2.5 The three metamorphoses and the missing fourth

The first discourse of *Zarathustra* describes three metamorphoses of the spirit. The camel kneels to bear the heaviest loads; the lion seizes freedom and speaks the sacred No to the dragon of "thou shalt"; the child, innocence and forgetting, a new beginning and a sacred Yes, is a wheel rolling out of itself. The corpus traverses the sequence with fidelity. *Undertow* is the camel, laden with abuse, addiction, and the weight of the floor. *Ænima* is the lion, whose No falls on Los Angeles, on false martyrs, on purist fans. *Lateralus* is the child, the self-propelled wheel become spiral.

The corpus then does something Nietzsche did not: it lets the child age. *10,000 Days* and *Fear Inoculum* are the work of the child grown old, the convalescent who has lived with the thought for decades. Hillman's archetype of the *senex*, Saturn's old man, supplies the missing fourth metamorphosis, and Chapter 11 will read "Invincible" (FI.4) as its fullest statement.

2.6 Apollo and Dionysus: the tragic vessel

The Birth of Tragedy (1872) makes the agonistic matrix aesthetic. The Dionysian insight into primordial suffering and contradiction is unbearable; the Apollonian—dream, image, measure, individuation—is the veil that makes it bearable; tragedy is their union. In §7 Nietzsche describes the man who has seen into the horror of existence and is overcome by nausea, *Ekel*. At that moment art approaches *als*

rettende, heilkundige Zauberin: as a saving sorceress, expert in healing. She alone can turn nauseating thoughts into representations with which one can live, and she has two means. The sublime tames the horrible artistically; the comic discharges the nausea of the absurd.

The passage is the corpus's aesthetic charter in nuce. Art is a *Zauberin*—in Greek, a *pharmakis*—whose remedies are two, and TOOL administers both: the sublime of "Third Eye," "Lateralus" and "Pneuma" and the comic of "Die Eier von Satan," "Hooker with a Penis" and "Rosetta Stoned." The formal correlate is equally exact. The band's metric architecture—Carey's polymeters, Chancellor's ostinati, the Fibonacci and heptadic schemes—is Apollonian measure; the scream, the abjection and the rage are Dionysian substance; and the albums are the vessels in which the second is held by the first. Chapter 14 names this vessel the *vas hermeticum*.

2.7 Schopenhauer: music as the will's self-portrait

The metaphysics of music on which the band's sublime depends is Schopenhauer's. In *The World as Will and Representation* (1818, I §52), music is not, like the other arts, a copy of the Ideas but a copy of the will itself, which is why it speaks so directly and with such force. A scream, on this account, is the will audible. Schopenhauer drew a quietist conclusion: aesthetic contemplation offers a temporary release from willing, and the saint's denial of the will offers a permanent one. Nietzsche reversed the valuation. Art, he insisted, is not a quietive but the great stimulant of life—*das große Stimulans zum Leben* (*Götzen-Dämmerung*, "Streifzüge" §24). The opposition between art as sedative and art as tonic is the opposition that structures the corpus's arc. It begins with an opiate and ends with a training of the organism; Schopenhauer's metaphysics of music, Nietzsche's pharmacology of its use.

2.8 Kierkegaard: despair as sickness, anxiety as school

Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) defines despair as the sickness of the self, a misrelation in the self's relating to itself, and insists that the capacity for this sickness is the human being's superiority over the animal. The most dangerous despair is the one that does not know itself. *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844) calls anxiety the dizziness of freedom and closes with a chapter on anxiety as saving through faith: whoever has learned to be anxious in the right way has learned the ultimate. Anxiety, here, is a school. It educates the individual by consuming every finite consolation and leaving him before the infinite. This is the earliest explicit statement of the pedagogy that *Fear Inoculum* will set to music: fear not abolished but made formative.

Fear and Trembling (1843) contributes a figure. Its knight of faith is indistinguishable from a shopkeeper; nothing in his outward life betrays the infinite movement he makes at every instant. The mother of *10,000 Days*, whose silent and immobile faith the songs set against the loud piety of her judges, is a knight of faith in Kierkegaard's exact sense.

2.9 Heidegger: fear, anxiety, and releasement

Being and Time (1927, §§30, 40) draws the distinction the inoculum requires. Fear (*Furcht*) is always fear of some definite entity that threatens; anxiety (*Angst*) has no object, because what it discloses is being-in-the-world as such. "What Is Metaphysics?" (1929) adds that anxiety reveals the nothing. The resolute anticipation of death (§53) individualizes *Dasein* and returns it to its ownmost possibility.

The distinction refines the thesis. *Fear Inoculum* inoculates against *Furcht*—fear as contagion, manufactured and transmitted by those who profit from it—and not against *Angst*, which the album embraces as disclosure in its meditations on mortality, breath and age. An inoculum against fear that also anaesthetized anxiety would be one more opiate. Chapter 11 will show that the album keeps the two apart, and Chapter 15 will return to the distinction when testing the theory's limits.

2.10 Synthesis

The agonistic matrix contributes the ethic of self-overcoming; the diagnosis of ressentiment as indigestion and of forgetting as digestion; the image of the shepherd who bites the serpent in his throat; the doctrine of a great health perpetually spent and reacquired; the dual artistic remedy of the sublime and the comic; the opposition between sedative and stimulant art; the school of anxiety; and the distinction between fear and anxiety on which the final album depends. Its master term, *Einverleibung*, is the concept this dissertation translates into the language of the pharmacy.



CHAPTER 3

The Esoteric Matrix

Number, Hermes, and the Work

THE ESOTERIC MATRIX GIVES the corpus its form: the conviction, Pythagorean in origin and Hermetic in transmission, that number is the structure of the cosmos and that music is number made audible. It also gives the corpus its practices—the Gurdjieffian Work, the alchemical opus, the magician's will—and its emblem, the serpent-twined staff of Hermes. At its center stands the alchemists' Mercurius, who is at once poison and panacea; the esoteric tradition had a god of the pharmakon long before Derrida gave it a philosophy.

3.1 Faivre's criteria and the question of occulture

Antoine Faivre's influential definition of Western esotericism (*Access to Western Esotericism*, 1994) names four intrinsic characteristics and two extrinsic ones. The intrinsic four are *correspondences* between all levels of reality; *living nature*, a cosmos animated and legible; *imagination and mediations*, images and intermediary beings as organs of knowledge; and the *experience of transmutation*, inner change modeled on the alchemical. The extrinsic two are the *praxis of concordance*, which seeks common denominators among traditions, and *transmission* through initiatory lineage.

The corpus satisfies the first five in earnest. Correspondence is the premise of "Lateralus," in which the same ratio governs syllable, meter, body and cosmos; nature lives in the flood of "Ænema" and the ensouled flesh of "Parabola"; mediation is the work of Alex Grey's images, the Enochian title, the Merkaba vehicle; transmutation is named outright in "The Grudge"; concordance is the syncretic method of the whole. The sixth criterion, transmission, is satisfied only as parody. The band's lineage is the Lachrymology dossier, a chain of initiation that leads back to a sage who never lived. The corpus is esoteric in every respect except the one that would make it a sect. This is what distinguishes it from the New Age as Wouter Hanegraaff anatomized it (*New Age Religion and Western Culture*, 1996), and it makes the band

a peculiar node in Christopher Partridge's "occulture": an esotericism that refuses the guru.

3.2 From Pythagoras to Kepler: the harmony of the world

The Pythagorean discovery that consonances correspond to simple ratios—2:1 for the octave, 3:2 for the fifth, 4:3 for the fourth—grounded a cosmology in which *kosmos*, order and ornament, is number heard. In the *Timaeus* (35b–36d) the Demiurge fashions the World Soul by dividing a mixture according to harmonic and arithmetic means: the soul of the world is a scale. Boethius transmitted the doctrine to the Latin Middle Ages in a tripartition (*De institutione musica*, c. 510): *musica mundana*, the harmony of the spheres; *musica humana*, the harmony of body and soul; *musica instrumentalis*, audible music. TOOL's corpus is unusual in addressing all three at once: cosmic geometry in Danny Carey's iconography, the harmony of body and soul in "Parabola" and "Pneuma," and instrumental music of an exacting metric intricacy. Kepler's *Mysterium Cosmographicum* (1596) nested the Platonic solids between the planetary orbits, and his *Harmonices Mundi* (1619) announced the third law of planetary motion inside a treatise on the music the planets sing.

The Pythagorean tradition was also, from the beginning, a pharmacy. Iamblichus reports that Pythagoras prescribed particular melodies as remedies for particular passions (*On the Pythagorean Way of Life*, c. 300 CE). Aristotle, in the eighth book of the *Politics* (1342a), describes those seized by religious frenzy who, after hearing sacred melodies, are restored as though they had received healing and purgation. The esoteric matrix and the pharmacological thesis meet at their common origin: music as medicine for the soul.

3.3 Fibonacci and the golden spiral

Leonardo of Pisa's *Liber Abaci* (1202) posed the problem of breeding rabbits whose solution is the series 1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, 21, in which each term is the sum of its two predecessors and the ratio of successive terms converges on the golden ratio, $\varphi \approx 1.618$—Euclid's division in extreme and mean ratio. Luca Pacioli canonized the proportion as divine in *De Divina Proportione* (1509), with illustrations by Leonardo da Vinci; Kepler noticed the convergence; D'Arcy Wentworth Thompson's *On Growth and Form* (1917) demonstrated the logarithmic spiral in shells, horns and phyllotaxis. Its defining property is gnomonic growth: the spiral enlarges without changing its shape. Jacob Bernoulli, who called it the *spira mirabilis*, asked that it be carved on his tomb in Basel Minster with the motto *Eadem mutata resurgo*—though changed, I rise again the same. The mason carved an Archimedean spiral instead.

"Lateralus" (L.9) is the corpus's most famous esoteric structure. Its verse syllable counts climb and descend the Fibonacci series, and its chorus descends through meters of nine, eight and seven eighths: 987, the sixteenth Fibonacci number. Danny Carey has described the order of discovery. The song was first named for its meters,

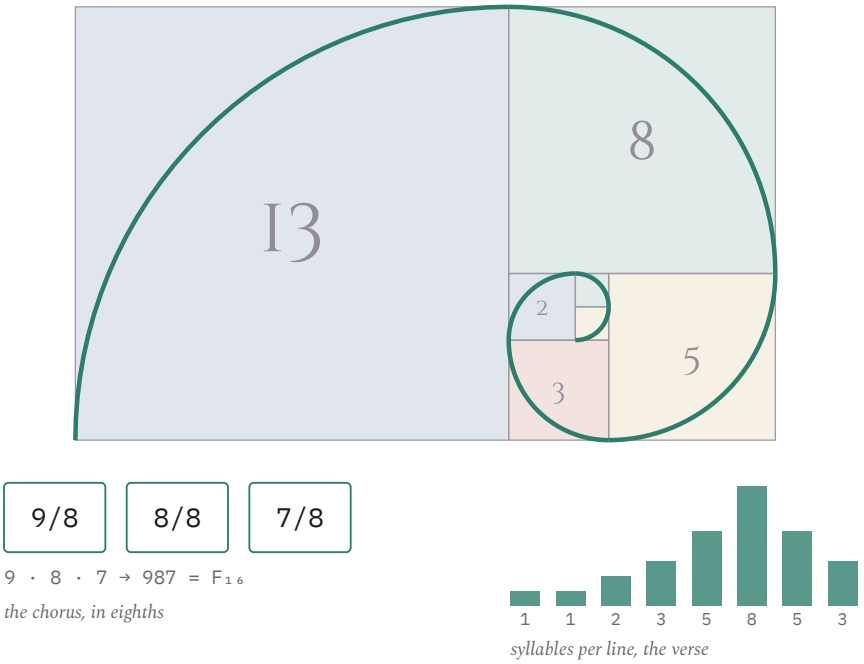


FIG. 3 **The Fibonacci dose.** Squares of the series tile a golden rectangle, and quarter-arcs through them trace the spiral of "Lateralus" (L.9). Below: the chorus's descending meters, whose digits make the sixteenth Fibonacci number, and the verse's syllable counts rising and falling along the series.

and the identity of 987 as a Fibonacci number was noticed afterwards (Loaded Radio). The band found the pattern in its own work and then extended it deliberately into the syllables. The corpus's signature cosmological structure thus began as a recognized accident—a pattern perceived, then adopted, then built upon. Chapter 15 will argue that this sequence is itself a lesson in how to live with pattern. And Bernoulli's motto supplies the spiral's ethic: identity through transformation, the same rising changed, which is the formula of the spiral dose.

3.4 Gurdjieff: the Work, the laws of three and seven, intentional suffering

G. I. Gurdjieff (c. 1866–1949) taught that ordinary human beings are machines asleep, reacting mechanically to external shocks, and that awakening requires self-remembering and work on oneself. P. D. Ouspensky's *In Search of the Miraculous* (1949) records the cosmology: the Law of Three, by which every phenomenon arises from an active, a passive and a neutralizing force; and the Law of Seven, or of octaves, by which every process unfolds in seven steps with two intervals where an additional shock is required or the process deviates. The enneagram unites the two laws in a single figure.

The method's moral core appears in *Beelzebub's Tales to His Grandson* (1950) as "conscious labor and intentional suffering." This is Lachrymology's doctrine without the hoax, and it is sharpened by a distinction that "The Grudge" (L.1) dramatizes. Ouspensky reports Gurdjieff's observation that people will renounce almost any pleasure but will not give up their suffering, which they hoard as identity. Mechanical suffering must be sacrificed; intentional suffering must be undertaken. The difference is the difference between ressentiment and mithridatic gnosis.

The correspondences with the corpus are structural rather than allusive. The suite that closes *Lateralus*—"Disposition," "Reflection," "Triad"—descends from receptivity through the ego's sacrifice to a wordless reconciliation, a triad completed by a third force. *Fear Inoculum*, whose compact disc carries seven tracks and whose centerpiece is titled "7empest," is a heptad. The call to wake and remember in "Pneuma" (FI.2) is a call to self-remembering. And Gurdjieff's sacred Movements, which require independent rhythmic patterns in different limbs in order to compel divided attention, find a secular analogue in Carey's limb independence. The lineage, moreover, is attested. J. G. Bennett, a pupil of Gurdjieff, trained Robert Fripp at Sherborne House in the mid-1970s; Fripp's interlocking polymeters on King Crimson's *Discipline* (1981) brought a Gurdjieffian technology of attention into rock; and TOOL named King Crimson among its tastes (Contemporary Musicians, via Encyclopedia.com) and toured with the group in 2001.

3.5 Hermes, Mercurius, and the vessel

The *Corpus Hermeticum*, Greek treatises of the second and third centuries translated into Latin by Marsilio Ficino in 1471, and the *Emerald Tablet*, known in Arabic from the eighth to tenth centuries and in Latin from the twelfth, attribute the Hermetic art to Hermes Trismegistus, the Greek Hermes fused with the Egyptian Thoth, god of writing, magic and healing. The tablet's correspondence of above and below, and the later alchemical maxim *solve et coagula*, define the opus. The Greek Hermes adds the rest of the profile this corpus requires. He is the psychopomp who guides souls to the underworld; the trickster and thief; the god of boundaries; the slayer of the hundred-eyed watchman Argus; the bearer of the herald's staff, the *kerykeion* or caduceus; and, on the first day of his life, according to the *Homeric Hymn to Hermes*, the inventor of the lyre, made from the shell of a tortoise. The god of the hoax, the descent, the boundary, the Hermetic art and the musical instrument is the god of TOOL, and Keenan has, in naming his winery, already hung his staff over the door.

Alchemy is the Hermetic art in its laboratory form. Jung's *Psychology and Alchemy* (1944) and *Mysterium Coniunctionis* (1955–56) read it as a projection of individuation; Edward Edinger's *Anatomy of the Psyche* (1985) systematized seven operations—*calcinatio*, *solutio*, *coagulatio*, *sublimatio*, *mortificatio*, *separatio*, *coniunctio*—and the older tradition marked the work's progress by colors, from the *nigredo* through the *albedo* and *citrinitas* to the *rubedo*. The work begins with Saturn, the lead of the *prima materia*, and Saturn's melancholy presides over Dürer's *Melencolia I* (1514), with its

magic square and enigmatic polyhedron (Klibansky, Panofsky and Saxl, *Saturn and Melancholy*, 1964). It is fitting that *Lateralus*, the album of the spiral, opens under an ascending Saturn.

Two alchemical conceptions are indispensable to the argument. The first is the *vas hermeticum*, the sealed vessel in which the work proceeds; the expression "hermetically sealed" descends from it. The seal permits the poisonous *prima materia* to be heated, dissolved and transformed without escaping or exploding. The second is Mercurius, whom Jung studied in "The Spirit Mercurius" (1943/1948): the dragon that devours itself, duplex and hermaphroditic, named by the alchemists both as poison and as panacea. Mercurius is the pharmakon personified. Chapter 14 will argue that the band's metric architecture is the *vas*, and the corpus's content is Mercurius sealed within it.

3.6 Crowley, Dee, and the Enochian voice

Aleister Crowley (1875–1947), named among the band's sources in early profiles, defined magick as the science and art of causing change in conformity with will (*Magick in Theory and Practice*, 1929); Danny Carey's engagement with Thelemic and Enochian material is a matter of public record. The Enochian language itself descends from the angelic conversations conducted by John Dee and the scryer Edward Kelley in the 1580s, which culminated in 1587 in an angelic command that the two men share their wives. Kelley's reputation as a forger has never been dispelled. The Enochian corpus is therefore a pharmakon of revelation in the strictest sense: divine speech indistinguishable from imposture.

"Faaip de Oiad" (L.13) takes its title from Enochian, usually glossed as "the voice of God," and sets beneath it a frantic percussion and a notorious 1997 call to Art Bell's overnight radio program, in which a terrified caller, presenting himself as a former employee at Area 51, warns of extra-dimensional beings misrepresenting themselves to humanity. Under the title "voice of God," the corpus places a broadcast of panic about deceivers. The juxtaposition reproduces the Gnostic undecidability of revelation, in which the angel may be an archon, and it inherits that undecidability from the Enochian source itself.

3.7 Sacred geometry and the chariot

The live track "Merkaba" on *Salival* (2000) names Drunvalo Melchizedek's "Mer-Ka-Ba," a light-body vehicle of counter-rotating star tetrahedra, and with it the repertoire of New Age sacred geometry: the Flower of Life, Metatron's Cube. The ancient source is Merkabah mysticism, the visionary tradition founded on the throne-chariot of Ezekiel 1, whose wheels are full of eyes round about (1:18). Its Hekhalot literature describes the adept's ascent through seven heavenly palaces guarded by angels who demand seals and passwords (Gershom Scholem, *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*, 1941). The figure of a heptadic ascent recurs across traditions: Inanna's seven gates, Dante's seven terraces, Gurdjieff's octave, and, in the first treatise of the

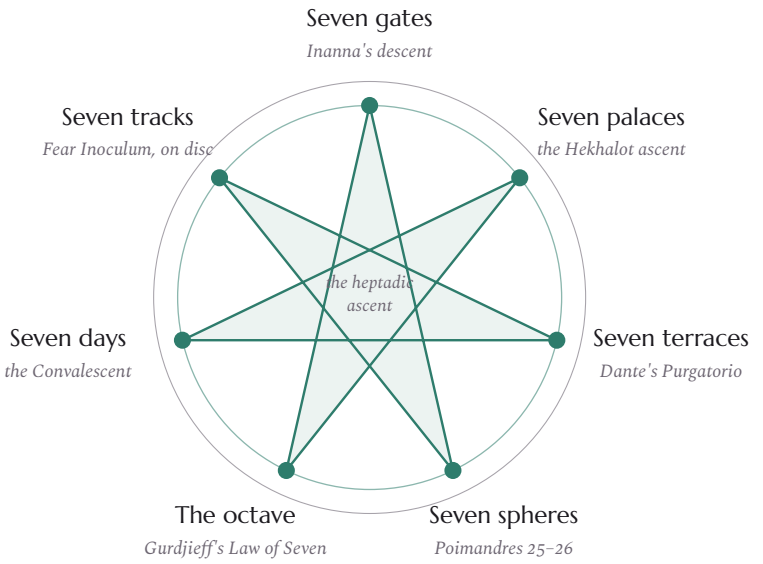


FIG. 4 **The heptadic ascent.** Seven thresholds recur across the traditions. The corpus's own heptad, the seven tracks of the **Fear Inoculum** compact disc and the numeral of "7empest," stands in elective affinity with them.

Corpus Hermeticum (*Poimandres* 25–26), the soul's rise through seven planetary zones, surrendering a vice at each. Ezekiel's chariot unites the wheel and the eye, the spiral and the gaze; it is the scriptural prototype of the iconography this corpus will make its own.

3.8 From Theosophy to Alex Grey: the transparent body

The visual vocabulary of the band's middle period descends from Theosophy. Annie Besant and C. W. Leadbeater's *Thought-Forms* (1901) rendered clairvoyant perceptions of the subtle body as color plates; Leadbeater's *The Chakras* (1927) diagrammed the centers along the spine. Alex Grey, whose collaboration with the band began with *Lateralus*, transposed this tradition into the idiom of anatomical illustration. His *Sacred Mirrors* (1979–1989) present life-size figures in successive layers—skeleton, nervous system, circulation, viscera, subtle energies, a universal lattice, the void—so that the viewer climbs a ladder of transparency; Ken Wilber contributed to the volume that collected them in 1990. Grey's *Net of Being* furnished the cover of *10,000 Days*.

Behind Grey stands the *écorché* tradition of Vesalius's *De humani corporis fabrica* (1543), in which anatomy—*ana-tomē*, a cutting-up—is a mode of revelation. The transparent overlays of the *Lateralus* booklet, lifted one by one, literalize the Greek

apokalypsis, an uncovering. The second track of the album is titled "Eon Blue Apocalypse" (L.2), and it names the operation the booklet performs.

3.9 Synthesis

The esoteric matrix contributes form, practice and emblem. Its form is number: the Pythagorean ratio, the Fibonacci spiral, the octave. Its practice is the Work and the opus: intentional suffering and transmutation within a sealed vessel. Its emblem is Hermes, trickster and psychopomp, maker of the lyre and bearer of the caduceus, whose alchemical double, Mercurius, is both poison and cure. The matrix satisfies every criterion of Western esotericism except transmission, which it parodies. The result is an occulture without an occult hierarchy: a Hermeticism that hands the vessel to the listener and keeps no priest.



CHAPTER 4

The Psychedelic-Gnostic Matrix

Entheogen, Archon, and the Forgotten Message

THE PSYCHEDELIC-GNOSTIC MATRIX SUPPLIES the corpus with its most literal pharmacology—the entheogen, the substance that occasions the divine—and with the Gnostic narrative in which revelation arrives as a message from outside, is forgotten, and must be recovered. Its originators range from Bill Hicks, the corpus's only formally dedicated mentor, to Albert Hofmann, the only one named in a song title. Its danger is the corpus's own: the entheogen can become a new opiate, and gnosis a new paranoia.

4.1 Bill Hicks: the comedian as physician and psychopomp

Hicks (1961–1994) is the most thoroughly documented presence in the corpus. He is thanked in the notes to *Undertow*; he introduced the band at Lollapalooza in August 1993, six months before his death from pancreatic cancer; *Ænima* is dedicated to him; "Third Eye" (Æ.15) is built on his recorded voice; and "Ænema" (Æ.13) takes its eschatology from his routine about Los Angeles sliding into the Pacific, preserved on the posthumous *Arizona Bay* (1997) (Loaded Radio). The inner art of *Ænima* shows him as a doctor attending a patient in a wheelchair who resembles Keenan (Insounder). The comedian is the physician; the singer is the patient. No single image in the band's iconography states the thesis of this dissertation so plainly.

Hicks's thought was a psychedelic humanism delivered as prophetic abuse. Its premises: that the world is a ride we have mistaken for reality, and that every choice reduces to one between fear and love; that consciousness is single and experiences itself through us; that marketing, the war on drugs and televangelism are organized forms of fear. Its method was satirical shock, and its most famous joke on the crowd—as widely recounted, his introduction of the band at Lollapalooza enlisted thousands in a search for a contact lens he had not lost—is a parable of herd suggestibility worthy of the Lachrymology dossier. In Dantean terms, Hicks is the corpus's Virgil: the dead poet who guides through the inferno of the satirical city but cannot enter

paradise. The visionary guidance of *Lateralus* passes to Alex Grey; and in *10,000 Days*, as in the *Commedia*, the last intercessor is a woman who has died.

4.2 Huxley: the reducing valve, soma, and moksha

Aldous Huxley's *The Perennial Philosophy* (1945) argued for a common mystical core beneath the world's religions. *The Doors of Perception* (1954), the record of a mescaline experiment conducted with Humphry Osmond in May 1953, borrowed its title from Blake's *Marriage of Heaven and Hell*: if the doors of perception were cleansed, every thing would appear to man as it is, infinite. Its theory, adapted from Henri Bergson and C. D. Broad, holds that brain and nervous system function as a reducing valve, filtering a "Mind at Large" down to the trickle useful for survival. Ordinary consciousness is itself an attenuated dose of the absolute; the entheogen widens the valve.

Huxley's fiction enacts the corpus's arc a generation early. *Brave New World* (1932) imagines *soma*, a pharmacology of pacification by which a managed society anaesthetizes its members. *Island* (1962) imagines *moksha*-medicine, a sacrament administered within a ritual and pedagogical container, which liberates rather than pacifies. The novelist's trajectory runs from opiate to inoculum. Huxley died on 22 November 1963 after asking his wife for a dose of LSD—a deathbed sacrament from the author who had imagined both kinds of drug.

4.3 Hofmann, Eleusis, and the problem child

Albert Hofmann (1906–2008), a chemist at Sandoz in Basel, synthesized lysergic acid diethylamide from ergot alkaloids in 1938 and discovered its effects in April 1943; he later called it *mein Sorgenkind*, my problem child (1979). With R. Gordon Wasson and Carl A. P. Ruck he argued in *The Road to Eleusis* (1978) that the *kykeon* drunk by initiates of the Eleusinian Mysteries contained ergot alkaloids. Whatever the fate of the hypothesis, its frame is exact for this corpus. The Mysteries of Demeter and Persephone guided their *mystai* through a reenactment of loss and return toward the *epopteia*, the vision granted to the highest grade, under a secrecy kept for nearly two millennia. A fragment of Plutarch compares the experience of the dying soul to that of the initiate, and Pindar called blessed the one who has seen these things before going beneath the earth.

"Lost Keys (Blame Hofmann)" (M.7) placed the chemist's name in a title in 2006, the year he turned one hundred and was honored by a centenary symposium in Basel. It was also the year Roland Griffiths and colleagues at Johns Hopkins reported that psilocybin occasions mystical-type experiences of substantial and lasting personal significance (*Psychopharmacology* 187, 2006), the study that reopened the clinic to the entheogen—a reopening prepared by Walter Pahnke's Good Friday Experiment at Boston's Marsh Chapel in 1962. In the year the sacrament returned to medicine, the corpus set Hofmann's name over a scene in a hospital. The keys of the title belong to

an old iconography: Hecate, guide of Persephone, bore the epithet *kleidouchos*, the key-holder.

4.4 Leary, Wilson, and the reality tunnel

Timothy Leary, Ralph Metzner and Richard Alpert's *The Psychedelic Experience* (1964) recast the Tibetan *Bardo Thödol* as a manual for the psychedelic session, which thereby became a rehearsal of death. Its most durable contribution was the doctrine of set and setting, later formalized by Norman Zinberg (*Drug, Set, and Setting*, 1984): the effect of a dose depends on the mind that receives it and the environment that holds it. Set and setting are the *vas hermeticum* of psychedelic practice.

Leary's eight-circuit model of consciousness (*Exo-Psychology*, 1977) reached a wide readership through Robert Anton Wilson's *Prometheus Rising* (1983), whose central lesson is model agnosticism: every system is a "reality tunnel," a map, and none is the territory. The corpus's syncretism practices this agnosticism. It uses Jung, Gurdjieff and the Gnostics as maps without converting to any of them. Wilson's other gift is a number. The "23 enigma," which William S. Burroughs traced to a Tangier ferry captain in 1960 and Wilson elaborated in *Cosmic Trigger* (1977) and, with Robert Shea, in the Discordian *Illuminatus!* trilogy (1975), is the subject of "Viginti Tres" (M.11). The fourth album ends on a number that is itself a joke about the compulsion to find meaning in numbers.

4.5 McKenna and Strassman: the stoned ape and the spirit molecule

Terence McKenna (1946–2000) proposed in *Food of the Gods* (1992) that psilocybin mushrooms catalyzed the emergence of hominid cognition—the "stoned ape" hypothesis, speculative and unsupported, but mythically potent. *The Archaic Revival* (1991) called for a return to shamanic consciousness against a culture he regarded as an operating system hostile to the individual. The evolutionary eschatology of "Forty Six & 2" and the ecstatic aperture of "Third Eye" stand in elective affinity with this program.

Rick Strassman's *DMT: The Spirit Molecule* appeared in 2001, the year of *Lateralus*. It reported the University of New Mexico studies of the early 1990s and advanced the speculative hypothesis that the pineal gland might produce endogenous DMT at birth and death. The pineal had a long esoteric career before Strassman: Descartes made it the seat of the soul (*Les Passions de l'âme*, 1649, arts. 31–32), and Theosophy identified it with the third eye. Biology adds an irony. In many lizards and in the tuatara, a photoreceptive parietal eye on the crown of the head belongs to the pineal complex. The serpent's lineage really does possess a third eye.

4.6 Gnosticism: pneuma, archon, and the call

The Gnostic systems known from the heresiologists and from the Nag Hammadi codices, discovered in 1945, share a narrative: a divine spark, *pneuma*, has fallen into matter governed by archons and an ignorant demiurge; human beings are asleep,

drunk and forgetful; salvation comes through *gnōsis* carried by a call from outside. Hans Jonas identified the call as the central Gnostic symbol (*The Gnostic Religion*, 1958). The Valentinian school divided humanity into *hylikoi*, bound to matter, *psychikoi*, at the level of soul, and *pneumatikoi*, awakened to spirit.

The corpus bears the marks. "Pneuma" (FI.2) addresses spirit bound in flesh and calls it to wake and remember. "Faaip de Oiad" broadcasts the archons in the idiom of UFO lore. "Right in Two" (M.10) gives voice to angels puzzled that the Father granted free will to beings who use it to divide everything they touch. "Opiate" (O.6) presents its preacher, who demands unquestioning obedience in exchange for salvation, as a petty archon. And the arc from *Ænima* to "Pneuma" is, in Valentinian terms, an ascent from the psychic to the pneumatic, from *anima* to spirit.

The divergence is equally important. Classical Gnosticism despises matter; "Parabola" (L.7) sanctifies the body as the vessel of spirit. The corpus is Gnostic in its narrative of sleep, forgetting and recall, and anti-Gnostic in its anthropology. Its bridge to the classical systems is the Ophite tradition reported by Irenaeus (*Against Heresies* I.30) and Hippolytus (*Refutation* V), which honored the serpent of Eden as the bringer of knowledge against the demiurge. In those sects the serpent is not the tempter but the liberator.

The Gnostic text closest to the corpus is the *Hymn of the Pearl* (*Acts of Thomas* 108–113). A prince is sent into Egypt to retrieve a pearl from the sea, where it lies encircled by a serpent. He eats the food of the Egyptians, forgets his mission and falls asleep. A letter from his parents flies to him as an eagle and becomes speech; he wakes, lulls the serpent by naming his father, takes the pearl, and returns to receive a robe that proves to be his own image. "Rosetta Stoned" (M.8) restages the plot as farce: a messenger, intoxicated, receives a message meant for humanity and forgets it, and no letter arrives to remind him. Chapter 10 will argue that the missing letter is the point.

4.7 Philip K. Dick: anamnesis and the Black Iron Prison

In February and March of 1974 Philip K. Dick experienced what he believed to be a transmission of information by a beam of pink light, including the diagnosis of an undetected inguinal hernia in his infant son, which physicians then confirmed and repaired. He spent the remainder of his life interpreting the event in the thousands of pages posthumously edited as *The Exegesis* (2011). His key term was *anamnesis*, the loss of forgetfulness; his key image was the Black Iron Prison, a Roman empire of control that, he concluded, had never ended. *VALIS* (1981) fictionalized the experience; *A Scanner Darkly* (1977) had already imagined Substance D, a drug that severs the brain's hemispheres, and an undercover agent assigned to surveil himself. The divided self of "H." and "Schism," the surveilling self of "Vicarious," and the comic abductee of "Rosetta Stoned" all have Dickian kin. Dick's beam, notably, arrived as a physician.

4.8 Vallée and the control system

Jacques Vallée's *Passport to Magonia* (1969) argued that modern UFO encounters continue the folklore of fairies, demons and abductions, and *The Invisible College* (1975) proposed that the phenomenon functions as a control system, conditioning human belief by an irregular schedule of reinforcement, like a thermostat. John Keel's *Operation Trojan Horse* (1970) named its agents "ultraterrestrials." The corpus's alien motif—the Art Bell call of L.13, the abduction farce of M.8, Puscifer's *Existential Reckoning* (2020)—participates in this folklore while satirizing it. Read through Gnosticism, Vallée's control system is a modern name for the archons. Read through this dissertation, it is a dosing schedule administered by an unseen *pharmakeus*. The corpus's answer is to become one's own.

4.9 Burroughs: the algebra of need and the word virus

William S. Burroughs's *Naked Lunch* (1959) defines addiction as "the algebra of need," an equation in which the user's need determines every term. His later work (*The Ticket That Exploded*, 1962; *The Electronic Revolution*, 1970) generalizes the model: language itself is a virus, and control operates by its replication. The cut-up, which severs word-lines and reassembles them, is an antiviral procedure. If language is a virus, the artist's task is the making of vaccines. "Stinkfist" (Æ.1) is the algebra of need written in the key of sensation; "Fear Inoculum" (FI.1), Chapter 11 will argue, is a vaccine against the word-virus of fear.

4.10 Synthesis

The psychedelic-Gnostic matrix contributes the entheogen as sacrament; set and setting as its container; the narrative of forgetting and recall; the archon and the control system; the virus of the word; and the comic physician. It also contains the corpus's characteristic peril. An entheogen sought for sensation becomes an opiate, and a gnosis without discipline becomes paranoia. The later albums are built against both outcomes, and the theory of Part IV is in large part an account of how.



CHAPTER 5

The Mythopoetic Matrix

Katabasis, Serpent, and the Self-Made Myth

THE MYTHOPOETIC MATRIX GIVES the corpus its narratives, its master symbol, and its method. Its narratives are those of descent and return—the katabasis of Inanna, Gilgamesh, Orpheus, Persephone and Dante—organized by Joseph Campbell's monomyth and Mircea Eliade's morphology of initiation. Its master symbol is the serpent, the most overdetermined image of the pharmakon in world mythology. Its method is Blake's: to create a system rather than be enslaved by another's. And it supplies the one mythic sequence on which the whole theory rests: in the churning of the ocean, the poison comes first.

5.1 Campbell: the monomyth and creative mythology

Joseph Campbell, named among the band's sources in early profiles, distilled from the world's mythologies a single pattern of separation, initiation and return (*The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 1949): the call, the threshold, the belly of the whale, the road of trials, the meeting with the goddess, atonement with the father, apotheosis, the boon, and the difficult return. The fourth volume of *The Masks of God* (*Creative Mythology*, 1968) drew the consequence for modernity. Where shared myth has dissolved, the individual artist becomes the source of myth, communicating a personal experience in forms others recognize as their own. Keenan's corpus is creative mythology in exactly this sense. A private mythos—the paralyzed mother, the arrested child, the shadow followed into the dark—is offered as public myth.

The corpus fills the monomyth and then disables it. Campbell's pattern centers the hero; the corpus decenters him. "Eulogy" (Æ.2) mocks the self-appointed martyr; "Invincible" (FI.4) shows the hero aged and doubtful; the singer refuses the stage's center. The exemplary figure of this corpus is the patient, not the hero, and Chapter 15 will show that a structural iconoclasm—the Hezekiah principle—forbids the apotheosis the monomyth requires.

5.2 Eliade: initiation, eternal return, dismemberment

Mircea Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) contrasted the archaic ontology, in which ritual repetition of the cosmogony regenerates time, with the linear time of history and the "terror of history" it produces. The spiral is a synthesis of the two: a circle that advances, return without stasis. *Shamanism: Archaic Techniques of Ecstasy* (1951) described the shaman's initiatory sickness, his dismemberment by spirits and his reassembly with new bones and organs, after which his illness becomes his vocation. *Rites and Symbols of Initiation* (1958) generalized the pattern: initiation is symbolic death followed by rebirth. *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957) supplied the *axis mundi*, the pillar joining the cosmic levels.

Each element recurs. The anatomical transparencies of *Lateralus* take the body apart layer by layer; Adam Jones's stop-motion films animate assemblies of found matter, reconstituted bodies given motion; the spine of the kundalini tradition is an *axis mundi* within the body. The shaman's sickness has a Greek prototype that bears directly on the thesis. Chiron, the wise centaur, was wounded by an arrow of Heracles dipped in the blood of the Hydra. Being immortal, he could not die of the venom, and lived in incurable pain. He was the teacher of Asclepius in the art of medicine. The founder of medicine learned it from a poisoned healer.

The Norse tradition supplies the initiatory ordeal in its most self-administered form. In the *Hávamál* (stanzas 138–141), Odin hangs for nine nights on the windswept tree, wounded by a spear and given to himself, without bread or drink, until he takes up the runes and falls; afterwards he is granted a draught of the precious mead. The god administers the ordeal to himself at the axis of the world and returns with a script. In the *Völuspá* (28) he has also pledged an eye at Mímir's well in exchange for wisdom. The two myths together are the prototype of what Chapter 15 calls pavonine vision: an eye surrendered, a wound endured, and a writing won.

5.3 Katabasis: five descents

In the Sumerian *Descent of Inanna*, the queen of heaven goes down to her sister Ereshkigal, ruler of the dead. At each of seven gates she must surrender a garment or emblem of power; naked, she is judged, struck dead, and hung on a hook as a corpse for three days, until emissaries of Enki revive her with the food and water of life. She may return only by supplying a substitute, and the substitute is her husband Dumuzi. Sylvia Brinton Perera's *Descent to the Goddess* (1981) read the myth as an initiation into the shadow-sister. Two of its features will recur: the stripping at seven thresholds, and the requirement of a substitute victim—the pharmakos economy of Chapter 6.

In the eleventh tablet of the Standard Babylonian *Gilgamesh*, the hero, grieving for Enkidu and seeking immortality, dives with stones bound to his feet to the floor of the Apsu to gather a plant whose name promises that the old man becomes young. While he bathes in a pool on the journey home, a serpent smells the plant, carries it

off, and sheds its skin. Gilgamesh sits down and weeps, then returns to Uruk to show the boatman his city's walls. The serpent gains renewal; the human gains the wisdom of finitude and the consolation of work. The floor of "Undertow" and "Bottom" and the aging warrior of "Invincible" stand at the two ends of this tablet.

Orpheus, the archetypal singer, descends to retrieve Eurydice, charms the powers below with music, and loses her by looking back (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X). Rilke's "Orpheus. Eurydike. Hermes." (1904) reimagines the scene from the side of the dead: Eurydice, led by Hermes the psychopomp, has become full of her own death, no longer belongs to Orpheus, and, told that he has turned around, can only ask who. The backward glance is melancholia; Eurydice's indifference is the completion of a mourning Orpheus cannot perform. *10,000 Days*, Chapter 10 will argue, is the Orphic descent inverted.

Persephone, carried to the underworld by Hades, eats pomegranate seeds there and is thereby bound to return each year. The food of the dead is a dose that obligates. And Dante's *Commedia* assembles the whole repertoire: the dark wood, the dead poet as guide, the funnel of the Inferno, the spiral mountain of Purgatory with its seven terraces, the beloved dead woman who intercedes, and, in the seventeenth canto of the *Paradiso*, the charge of the poet's ancestor Cacciaguida that he publish his vision though it taste bitter, for once digested it will leave vital nourishment. Dante's poetics is mithridatic in its letter, and it is the first epigraph of this dissertation for that reason.

5.4 The serpent cycle

No image in world mythology is so densely charged with the pharmakon's ambivalence as the serpent: bearer of venom and of antidote, of death and of renewal by the shedding of its skin, of knowledge and of temptation. The corpus does not cite these myths. It moves through the symbolic field they define, and that field must be mapped.

- **Eden and the Ophites.** The serpent of Genesis 3 offers the knowledge of good and evil; the Ophite and Naassene sects inverted the story and honored it as the liberator from the demiurge.
- **Nehushtan.** In Numbers 21 the people, bitten by fiery serpents, are healed by looking upon a serpent of bronze that Moses sets on a pole. The image of the poison is the cure. Generations later, in 2 Kings 18:4, King Hezekiah breaks it in pieces because the people have begun to burn incense to it, and he calls it Nehushtan, a thing of brass. The remedy that became an idol is destroyed. Chapter 15 names the corpus's structural iconoclasm after him.
- **Asclepius.** The god of medicine carries a staff with a single serpent; his sanctuaries kept harmless snakes, and the sick slept in his precinct awaiting healing dreams.

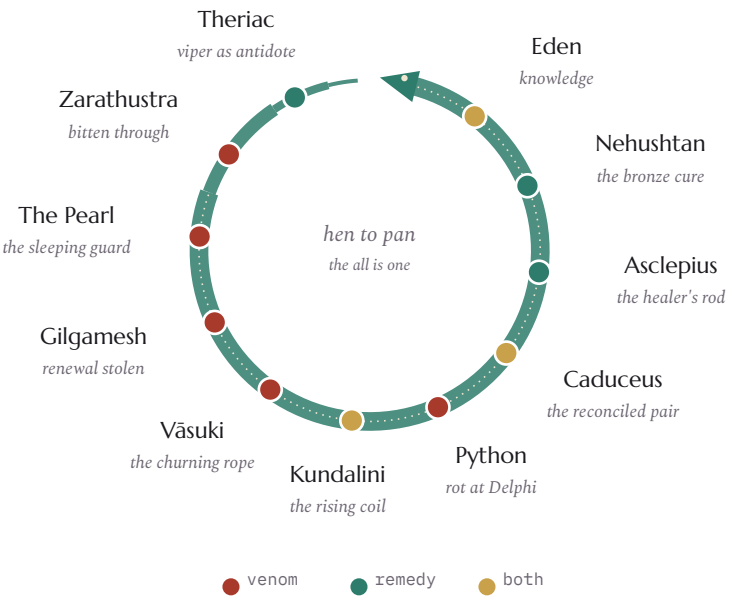


FIG. 5 **The serpent cycle.** No image in world mythology carries the pharmakon's ambivalence so densely. Red marks the serpent as venom, green as remedy, gold as both at once; the ring is the ouroboros, the circle the corpus opens into a spiral.

- **Hermes.** The caduceus bears two serpents, which in one story were fighting until the god thrust his wand between them and they wound about it in peace: a reconciliation of opposites. A long confusion with the Asclepian rod made the caduceus an emblem of medicine. Keenan's winery bears its name.
- **Python.** In the *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* the god kills the serpent at Delphi, and its carcass rots in the sun; the place is called Pytho, from *pythein*, to rot. The oracle is founded on putrefaction—the iconographic charter of *Ænima*.
- **Kundalini.** In Tantric physiology a coiled serpent energy lies at the base of the spine and rises through the centers to the crown (Arthur Avalon [Sir John Woodroffe], *The Serpent Power*, 1919; Jung's seminar of 1932, published as *The Psychology of Kundalini Yoga*, 1996). The spine becomes the *axis mundi*, and the third eye one of its stations.
- **The churning of the ocean.** In the *Bhāgavata Purāṇa* (Book VIII), the *Viṣṇu Purāṇa* and the *Mahābhārata*, the gods and the anti-gods churn the ocean of milk for the nectar of immortality, using Mount Mandara as the churning rod and the serpent Vāsuki as the rope, the two parties pulling back and forth from either end. The first thing the churning yields is not nectar but *halāhala*, a poison that threatens every world. Śiva drinks it; Pārvatī presses his throat so that it goes no further; his throat turns blue, and he is named Nīlakaṇṭha. Only then does the *amṛta* emerge.

- **Gilgamesh's serpent, the pearl's serpent, Zarathustra's serpent.** The thief of renewal; the guardian of the pearl in the *Hymn of the Pearl*; the black snake bitten through in Nietzsche's vision.
- **Ouroboros and theriac.** The self-devouring serpent of the Greek alchemical papyri, inscribed with the formula *hen to pan*, the all is one; and the viper's flesh compounded by Andromachus into the theriac.

The churning of the ocean is the master-myth of this dissertation. It contains the dialectic of opposites pulling against each other through a serpent (the polarity of "H." and "Schism"), the axis around which they turn (the spine, the spiral), the order of the products (poison before nectar, *nigredo* before *rubedo*), and the figure who makes the nectar possible by holding the poison in the throat—the organ of the singer. Chapter 14 will draw out the last of these.

5.5 Blake: contraries and the self-made system

The Marriage of Heaven and Hell (c. 1790–1793) declares that without contraries is no progression, and its Proverbs of Hell supply the corpus's ethic of excess: the road of excess leads to the palace of wisdom; you never know what is enough unless you know what is more than enough. Blake's devils are energy and his angels prudence,

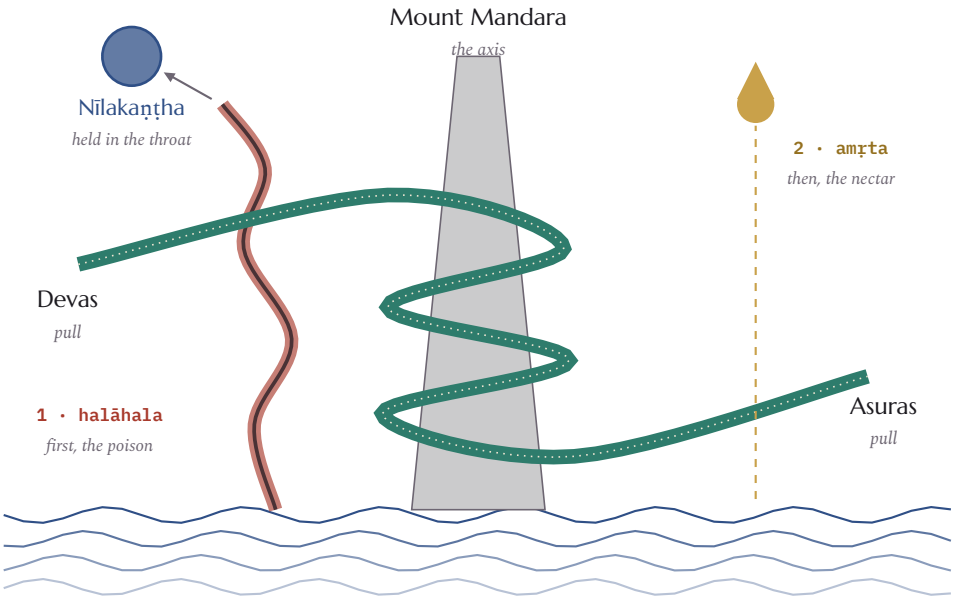


FIG. 6 **The churning of the ocean.** Gods and anti-gods pull the serpent Vāsuki back and forth around Mount Mandara. The first thing the ocean yields is poison, which Śiva holds in his throat; only then does the nectar rise.

and he judged that Milton had been of the devil's party without knowing it. The satanic eggs of Æ.10 belong to this inheritance.

Blake also supplies the corpus's method. In *Jerusalem* (1804–1820), Los declares that he must create a system or be enslaved by another man's, and that his business is not to reason and compare but to create. Blake's illuminated printing fused image, text and design in a single composite art; TOOL distributes the same composite art across a collective of lyricist, musicians, filmmaker and painter. Even Blake's private mythology has its counterparts: Urizen, the reasoning lawgiver, in the authorities of *Opiate* and "Intolerance"; Orc, revolutionary energy, in the fury of *Ænima*; Los, the smith of imagination, in the forging spiral of *Lateralus*. Alex Grey has always claimed Blake as an ancestor.

5.6 The trickster and the antidote

Paul Radin's edition of the Winnebago trickster cycle (1956), with essays by Jung and Karl Kerényi, established the trickster as an archetype; Lewis Hyde's *Trickster Makes This World* (1998) recast him as the boundary-crosser who makes culture by disrupting it—Hermes, Coyote, Raven, Eshu, Loki. The Lachrymology dossier, the German recipe delivered as a rally (Æ.10), the priest multiplied into a praying mantis on the cover of *Opiate*, the invented anecdotes of interviews: these are trickster acts in Hyde's sense, revealing the arbitrariness of the rules they break.

Homer had already made the trickster the bearer of the antidote. In the tenth book of the *Odyssey*, the sorceress Circe turns Odysseus's companions into swine with her drugs. Hermes meets Odysseus on the path and gives him *mōly*, a plant black at the root and white in the flower, hard for mortals to dig, which makes him immune. Homer calls Circe's drugs *kaka pharmaka*, evil drugs, and Hermes's gift a *pharmakon esthlon*, a good one. The ambivalence of the pharmakon is written into the oldest poem of the West, and the god who resolves it is the trickster. The drug that turns human beings into a herd is answered by an inoculation from the god of thresholds. Chapter 11 will find the swine again.

5.7 Synthesis

The mythopoetic matrix contributes the narratives of descent—Inanna's seven gates, Gilgamesh's dive, Orpheus's song, Persephone's seeds, Dante's spiral—the serpent as the pharmacy of myth, Blake's creative mythology, and the trickster who carries the good drug against the evil one. Its decisive lesson is the order of the churning. The poison comes first, and the nectar comes only to the one who can hold the poison without swallowing it.



CHAPTER 6

The Critical-Satirical Matrix

Opiate, Scapegoat, Spectacle, and the Sacred Hoax

THE CRITICAL-SATIRICAL MATRIX GIVES the corpus its diagnosis of the social pharmacy and its second remedy. The diagnosis names the institutions that dose populations: religion as opiate (Marx), the scapegoat as the community's purge (Girard), the spectacle as vicarious consumption (Debord), the abject as what must be expelled to found the self (Kristeva). The remedy is laughter—Nietzsche's comic discharge of the nausea of the absurd—and its signature instrument is the sacred hoax, a pharmakon that carries its own antidote.

6.1 Marx and the opiate

In the introduction to his *Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right* (1844), Marx called religious suffering at once the expression of real suffering and a protest against it: the sigh of the oppressed creature, the heart of a heartless world, the spirit of spiritless conditions. *Sie ist das Opium des Volkes.* The figure is more sympathetic than its reputation. In 1844 opium was the standard analgesic, and Marx's point is that religion is a real medicine for a real pain that leaves the disease untreated; the task is to abolish the conditions that require the illusion. Keenan has said that the title of the band's first commercial release refers to Marx's phrase, and Cam de Leon's cover multiplies a fluorescent priest with joined hands into something like a praying mantis (Insounder). The predator appears in the posture of prayer. "Opiate" (O.6) dramatizes a preacher who promises healing and salvation in return for total, unquestioning obedience, and who uses the believer's surrender to rule him: the narcotic of devotion turned into an instrument of control.

Freud extended the diagnosis. *The Future of an Illusion* (1927) treated religion as wish-fulfillment, and *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) catalogued the palliatives without which life is unbearable, intoxicants first among them, which Freud called *Sorgenbrecher*, breakers of care. The corpus accepts the diagnosis of the ecclesial opiate and refuses its generalization. It is anticlerical without being antireligious:

the same lyricist who indicts the preacher of O.6 will, in M.3–4, honor a mother's faith as the truest thing in his life.

The biographical ground of the distinction is documented. Keenan grew up an only child in a Baptist household and served three years in the U.S. Army before art school (Contemporary Musicians, via Encyclopedia.com). The anticlerical song of 1992 and the devotional elegy of 2006 answer the same upbringing from its two sides: the institution that demands obedience, and the faith that one believer kept.

6.2 Girard: mimesis, scapegoat, pharmakos

René Girard's mimetic theory (*La Violence et le sacré*, 1972; *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde*, 1978; *Le Bouc émissaire*, 1982) traces a sequence: imitative desire breeds rivalry, rivalry dissolves social differences into a crisis of reciprocal violence, and the crisis resolves when the many unite against one and kill or expel him. Girard insists that the founding event is a collective murder; the victim, blamed for the crisis and credited with the peace that follows, is then sacralized. Athens ritualized the mechanism at the Thargelia, when *pharmakoi*—human scapegoats chosen for their ugliness or their crimes—were led through the city by its citizens, beaten (the iambic poet Hipponax describes blows with squill stalks and fig branches), and driven out to purify it. Later sources, among them the Byzantine scholar John Tzetzes, report that the *pharmakos* was burned and his ashes scattered at sea; whether Athenians ever killed one is disputed (Jan Bremmer, "Scapegoat Rituals in Ancient Greece," 1983). Derrida observed that *pharmakos* never appears in Plato's text, yet haunts every use of *pharmakon* ("La pharmacie de Platon," 1968).

"Vicarious" (M.1) is the corpus's treatise on the pharmakos in the age of broadcast. Its speaker confesses the appetite to watch others suffer and die on screen and refuses the alibi of the spectator; the viewer who purges his own violence by consuming the victim's image is a participant in the expulsion. "Eulogy" (Æ.2) diagnoses the counterfeit: a self-appointed martyr who claims to die for others and seeks only attention. The genuine pharmakos is chosen by the crowd; the false one appoints himself. Readings that identify the target with L. Ron Hubbard gain support from the Lachrymology sheet, which set its imaginary prophet against Hubbard's success (Spencer 1994). "Right in Two" (M.10) shows the mimetic crisis inverted into compulsive differentiation—apes dividing the earth and sky—and "Legion Inoculant" (FI.5), Chapter 11 will show, summons the one biblical episode Girard read as the scapegoat mechanism unmasked.

6.3 Debord, Baudrillard, and the vicarious

Guy Debord defined the spectacle not as a collection of images but as a social relation among people mediated by images (*La Société du spectacle*, 1967, thesis 4). Jean Baudrillard pushed the diagnosis to the obscene, the over-visible, in which nothing is hidden and nothing is felt (*Simulacres et simulation*, 1981; "The Ecstasy of Communication," 1983). "Stinkfist" (Æ.1) is the corpus's portrait of this condition:

a sensibility so desensitized that it requires ever more intense stimulation to feel anything at all. Its title names the sexual practice of fisting, and MTV aired the video under the title "Track #1," a censor's euphemism that perfectly enacts the spectacle's logic: the image is permitted, the name is not. "Ænema" (Æ.13) catalogues the spectacle's capital, Los Angeles, as a litany of poseurs and parasites, and wishes it into the sea.

6.4 Abjection and the carnivalesque

Mary Douglas defined dirt as matter out of place and read pollution beliefs as defenses of a classification (*Purity and Danger*, 1966). Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) relocated the problem inside the subject: the abject—excrement, vomit, the corpse, the open wound—is what must be expelled for the self's borders to form, and religion and literature are the two great rites of its purification. "Disgustipated" (U.69) bears disgust in its title; *Ænima* is an abjection rite from its portmanteau to its flood. Georges Bataille had already made base matter sacred: *L'Anus solaire* (1931) sets the sun and the anus in cosmic analogy, and *La Part maudite* (1949) defines the sacred as the expenditure, without return, of a society's surplus. The destruction of the surplus city in Æ.13 is a potlatch.

Mikhail Bakhtin supplied the positive valuation (*Rabelais and His World*, 1965). Carnival laughter degrades in order to regenerate; the lower bodily stratum buries and gives birth at once. Norman O. Brown, in the chapter of *Life Against Death* (1959) on Swift's "excremental vision," showed how far satire can go in this direction. Swift is the master of the corpus's satirical device: a monstrous proposal, that the infants of the Irish poor be sold as food for the tables of the rich, delivered in the measured voice of reason (*A Modest Proposal*, 1729). "Die Eier von Satan" (Æ.10) inverts the device: a harmless content in a monstrous form. Its text is a cookie recipe that calls for a knife-tip of Turkish hashish (Far Out), barked in German by Marko Fox in the militant cadence that listeners immediately hear as Hitler's oratory (Insounder), so that a listener feels the crowd's roar rise in response to the form alone. The satanic eggs are a cannabis edible: the pharmakon is hidden inside the fascist form. Walter Benjamin's epilogue to the artwork essay (1935–36) warned that fascism aestheticizes politics; Susan Sontag's "Fascinating Fascism" (1975) dissected the allure of Leni Riefenstahl's spectacles, above all *Triumph des Willens* (1935), her film of the Nazi Party's 1934 rally at Nuremberg. The track is a microdose of that allure, and it leaves the listener laughing at his own gooseflesh. It is an inoculation against the aestheticization of politics.

6.5 The sacred hoax

Lachrymology belongs to a family of fictions that produce real effects. Greg Hill and Kerry Thornley's *Principia Discordia* (editions from 1963 to 1970) founded a parody religion of Eris that became a practice; Robert Shea and Robert Anton Wilson's *Illuminatus!* (1975) named its method "Operation Mindfuck." Kurt Vonnegut's *Cat's*

Cradle (1963) imagined Bokononism, a religion whose scripture announces in its first lines that all of its truths are lies, and which consoles nonetheless. Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagined a fabricated encyclopedia that colonizes reality. History supplies cases: James Macpherson's *Ossian* (1760–1765), a forgery that helped found European Romanticism, and Carlos Castaneda's don Juan books (from 1968), whose fabrication Richard de Mille documented (*Castaneda's Journey*, 1976).

Lachrymology differs from Ossian and Castaneda in one respect that matters. It was never meant to be believed for long. Its narrative contained its own refutation—a crop-sprayer, a snowplough, a book no one could find—and its satirical frame set the prophet of tears beside the prophet of Dianetics (Spencer 1994). It is a hoax with an expiration date: a self-dissolving myth whose antigen degrades after it has done its work. By founding a church and letting it die, the band immunized its audience against the band becoming a church.

6.6 Satire of the audience

The corpus directs its satire at its own listeners with unusual consistency. "Hooker with a Penis" (Æ.7) answers a fan's accusation that the band had sold out, by pointing out that the accuser buys and sells too, and that purity is a market position. "Ticks & Leeches" (L.8) is a song of rage at being drained by parasites; it is also, since the leech is the instrument of Galenic phlebotomy, a song in which the singer is therapeutically bled. "Useful Idiot" (Æ.4), titled with a phrase traditionally and apocryphally attributed to Lenin, ends on vinyl in a locked groove that the listener must lift by hand (Insounder). The idiot of the loop is freed only by intervention. An organism that attacks its own parasites without destroying the host relation is mounting an immune response, and the band's antagonism toward its audience has that form.

6.7 Adorno, Benjamin, and the re-auratized work

Theodor Adorno's "On Popular Music" (1941) charged the popular song with standardization disguised as individuality, and *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) theorized the culture industry that produces it. TOOL is an anomaly in Adorno's model: fifteen-minute tracks in shifting meters, distributed by a major label at mass scale, the culture industry carrying an anti-standard. Benjamin's artwork essay explains the band's strategy. Technical reproduction destroys aura, transferring the work from cult value to exhibition value. The band has spent three decades re-auratizing: physical editions conceived as reliquaries (lenticular, stereoscopic, screen-embedded); a catalogue withheld from streaming until 2 August 2019 (Loaded Radio); concerts in darkness from which phone cameras are banished. It restores cult value inside exhibition value—the strategy of a mystery cult in the age of reproduction.

6.8 Puscifer and the satyr play

In Athens a tragic trilogy was followed by a satyr play, a comic afterpiece in which Dionysus's goat-men restored the audience after catharsis. Keenan's work forms such

a tetralogy. TOOL is the tragedy. A Perfect Circle is the elegy, from *Mer de Noms* (2000) through *Thirteenth Step* (2003), an album about addiction and recovery named for the predatory "step" of the recovery rooms, to *Eat the Elephant* (2018). Puscifer, from *"V" Is for Vagina* (2007) to *Existential Reckoning* (2020) and *Normal Isn't* (2026), is the satyr play: a burlesque world of personae, conspiracy and alien abduction that lets the tragedian laugh at his own themes. And the vineyard is the god's own sacrament. Wine was the oldest drug of Hippocratic medicine and the blood of Dionysus; Caduceus Cellars puts it under Hermes's staff, and Merkin Vineyards puts it under a satyr's joke. Bakhtin's carnival laughter and Nietzsche's comic remedy are institutionalized in the side projects, so that the main work can remain severe.

6.9 Synthesis

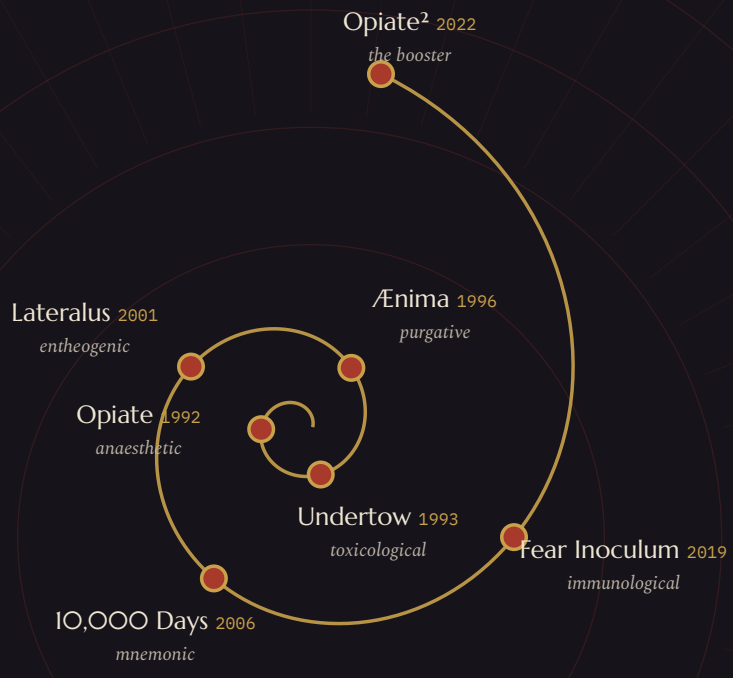
The critical-satirical matrix diagnoses the institutions of the social pharmacy—the opiate of devotion, the scapegoat, the spectacle, the abject, the herd that answers to form—and administers the second remedy, laughter. Its signature act, the sacred hoax, is a pharmakon that contains its own antidote, and it introduces the safeguard that Chapter 15 will name the Hezekiah principle.

PART

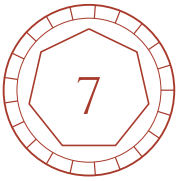
II

Readings

The Corpus as Opus



Part II reads the releases in sequence as stages of a single course of treatment. Each chapter correlates a phase with an immunological analogue, an alchemical operation, a Grofian matrix and a Dantean locus; Appendix A tabulates the correspondences. The correlations are coordinates rather than allegories. They locate what each album does with the poison it contains: transmits it raw, dilutes it in laughter, attenuates it through number, remembers it, or distributes it as an inoculum.



CHAPTER 7

Variolation

Opiate *and* Undertow *(1991–1993)*

THE FIRST PHASE ADMINISTERS the live pathogen. Before vaccination, smallpox was prevented by variolation: matter taken directly from a sufferer's pustules was introduced into a scratch on the skin of a healthy person, who usually developed a mild case and lifelong immunity. Practiced for centuries in China, India and the Ottoman world, the technique reached England when Lady Mary Wortley Montagu had her son variolated in Constantinople in 1718 and her daughter in London in 1721. It was effective and dangerous: a small fraction of the variolated died, and some spread the disease. The early releases operate in the same mode. They transmit the raw matter of abuse, addiction, censorship and rage with minimal attenuation, and their danger is correspondingly high.

7.1 *Opiate*: the anaesthetic diagnosed

The demo *72826* (1991) and the *Opiate* EP (1992) are documents of a band told what to be. Adam Jones has recalled that the label wanted the heaviest material, and the EP was recorded at Sound City with Sylvia Massy and Steve Hansgen; two of its six tracks were captured live on New Year's Eve 1991 (Loaded Radio). The sequence is nonetheless already symptomatic. It opens with "Sweat" (O.1), the body's first exudation; the corpus begins with a sudorific. "Hush" (O.2) is a song of enforced silence whose video presented the band naked, their mouths taped shut (Insounder), a parody of the parental-advisory regime that followed the Senate hearings convened at the urging of the Parents Music Resource Center in 1985. Censorship is anti-mithridatic: it refuses exposure and thereby produces fragility. "Jerk-Off" (O.5) is a fantasy of violent retaliation, the toxin of revenge as yet undigested—the lion's first growl.

"Opiate" (O.6) names the problem the entire corpus will treat. A preacher promises healing and salvation in return for total, unquestioning obedience; devotion is the narcotic, domination its pharmacology. Cam de Leon's cover, a priest multiplied

into a praying mantis, completes the diagnosis: the mantis devours its mate, and the posture of prayer is the posture of the predator. A concealed coda, separated from the title track by silence, inaugurates the corpus's habit of hiding its final word.

7.2 *Undertow*: the sealed water

Undertow (1993) is an album of water. Its title names the current that pulls the swimmer down while the surface looks calm; "Swamp Song" (U.6) sinks into quicksand; "Flood" (U.9) rises over everything. In alchemical terms the dominant operation is *solutio*, the dissolution of the solid in water; in Grof's terms the album is BPM II, a sealed world without exit, in which pressure mounts and nothing opens.

The album opens with an immune reaction. "Intolerance" (U.1) refuses to accept deception any longer, and its title is a pharmacological term: intolerance is the organism's rejection of a substance it can no longer process. The song also has a documented source in Keenan's military schooling. Its language of lying, cheating and stealing comes from the West Point cadet honor code, whose final clause forbids tolerating those who do, and which Keenan encountered at the academy's preparatory school during his Army years (Ultimate Classic Rock). The corpus's first immune reaction is an honor code turned outward.

"Prison Sex" (U.2) is the corpus's gravest document. Its subject is childhood sexual abuse: a child abused by an adult grows into an adult who abuses, and the song moves between the two positions, so that the listener hears the cycle from inside both. It offers no consolation. Its stop-motion video, directed by Jones, was pulled by MTV after a handful of airings. Alice Miller called the system of child-rearing that produces such cycles *poisonous pedagogy* (*Am Anfang war Erziehung*, 1980, adopting Katharina Rutschky's *Schwarze Pädagogik*, 1977): a poison administered as education, which the educated will administer in turn. The eighteenth- and nineteenth-century manuals she examined instructed parents and teachers to beat, shame and humiliate children until their will was broken, and she traced adult violence, Adolf Hitler's among her cases, to such upbringings. The song discharges nothing and redeems nothing. It is the repetition compulsion presented without cure, and its refusal of catharsis is the condition of its honesty.

"Sober" (U.3), the album's breakthrough single, asks why the unaltered world is unbearable. Its speaker craves intoxication as a response to a sobriety experienced as intolerable, and Jones's stop-motion video, indebted to the Brothers Quay, gave the band its first wide audience. The song's deepest gloss is a letter. On 30 January 1961 Jung wrote to Bill Wilson, co-founder of Alcoholics Anonymous, that the craving for alcohol was the equivalent, on a low level, of the spiritual thirst for wholeness, and observed that Latin uses the same word, *spiritus*, for alcohol and for the highest religious experience. His formula was *spiritus contra spiritum*. The corpus travels across the full length of that formula. It begins in 1993 with the craving for spirits and arrives in 2019 at a song titled "Pneuma," spirit.

"Bottom" (U.4) brings Henry Rollins's spoken sermon of self-discipline to the floor of the abyss. The title names the katabatic floor of the twelve-step tradition, the "rock bottom" from which recovery begins, and Dante's Cocytus, the frozen bottom of hell. Keenan would later devote an entire album of A Perfect Circle, *Thirteenth Step* (2003), to addiction and recovery.

The album's packaging met the regime of avoidance that "Hush" had parodied. Walmart and Kmart refused to stock it because of its artwork, and the band shipped an alternate sleeve that was a giant barcode on a white background, with the original art available by mail (Loaded Radio). The barcode is the commodity reduced to its price code. The censored edition made the act of censorship legible on the object itself, and answered retail's refusal of exposure with an image of the market that had demanded it.

7.3 "Disgustipated": the liturgy of eating

The album's final track is indexed sixty-ninth, reached only after a long run of silent index tracks. The listener must cross an empty threshold—Arnold van Gennep's liminal phase made audible—to arrive at a mock sermon. A preacher proclaims the suffering of vegetables torn from the earth and repeats, as a liturgical refrain, that life feeds on life. The track was recorded while Keenan fired a shotgun into a piano and Chris Haskett of the Rollins Band took a sledgehammer to it (Loaded Radio).

The parody conceals a theology. The *Taittirīya Upaniṣad* (3.10) ends with a hymn in which the realized self sings that it is food and the eater of food—*aham annam aham annādaḥ*. Bataille's general economy, in which all life is a circulation of energy through mutual consumption, is its secular version. The first album thus closes by declaring the food chain sacred: to live is to ingest the other. In parody, before any of its theory has been worked out, the corpus states its metabolic premise. Everything eats; the question is how one digests.

7.4 The risk of variolation

Variolation infects as well as immunizes, and the early corpus carried that risk. Its reception included listeners who took the rage as identity rather than as dose, who heard "Jerk-Off" as a program and "Sober" as an endorsement. An art that transmits the pathogen raw depends entirely on the constitution of its recipients. The corpus registered the danger and changed method. Its next phase dilutes the poison in laughter, and its third processes it through number.

7.5 Coordinates

The immunological analogue is variolation: the live pathogen, minimally attenuated. The alchemical operations are the *nigredo*, with *calcinatio* in the fire of "Intolerance" and *solutio* in the waters of the title track. The Grofian matrix is BPM II. The Dantean locus is the Inferno, from the dark wood of *Opiate* to the frozen floor of "Bottom." The Nietzschean figure is the camel, kneeling under the heaviest loads.

The dominant terms of the tetrad are *pharmakeia*, in the clerical narcotic of "Opiate" and the poisonous pedagogy of "Prison Sex," and *pharmakon* in its sense of poison.



CHAPTER 8

The Cowpox of Apocalypse

Ænima (1996)

In May 1796 Edward Jenner introduced matter from a cowpox lesion on a milkmaid's hand into the arm of a boy, James Phipps, and found him afterwards immune to smallpox. The procedure took its name from the cow, *vacca*: protection conferred by a related, milder disease. *Ænima* is the corpus's vaccination. Its apocalypse arrives as satire—a comedian's eschatology, a cookie recipe barked like a rally, a fan's insult returned with interest—and the comic is the cowpox of catastrophe: a related, attenuated infection that confers immunity to the real thing.

8.1 Personnel, producer, dedication

Justin Chancellor, formerly of Peach, replaced Paul D'Amour in 1995, and the album was co-produced with David Bottrill, who had worked with King Crimson and Peter Gabriel (Contemporary Musicians, via Encyclopedia.com). Bill Hicks died in February 1994, and the album is dedicated to him. At seventy-seven minutes it inaugurates the long form that the band would never abandon, and its fifteen tracks alternate full songs with interstitial fragments, so that the listener moves through a city of rooms rather than a sequence of singles.

8.2 The lenticular threshold

The original packaging assembled lenticular images that change as the viewer tilts them—paintings by Cam de Leon, among them *Smoke Box* and *Ocular Orifice*, and a photograph of California before and after an earthquake (Insounder). A lenticular image is a lesson in what Wittgenstein called the dawning of an aspect (*Philosophical Investigations*, Part II, xi, 1953): one object yields incompatible pictures according to the position of its viewer, as the duck becomes the rabbit. Before a note is heard, the album trains a perspectival vision in which nothing is seen correctly from a single place. The listener must move to see.

Among the same lenticular images is a photograph of the contortionist Alana Cain bent double to perform oral sex on herself, while the band sits on a couch beside her, Carey and Keenan nude and Keenan rising to toss her a rose (Insounder). The image is a human ouroboros: a body turned back upon itself, the alchemists' self-devouring serpent rendered in flesh. Beside the eye-and-orifice of de Leon's painting and the before-and-after of the earthquake, it completes the album's iconography of self-incorporation. The ouroboros is the closed circle that Chapter 14 opposes to the spiral, and *Ænima* sets it at the threshold so that the album can open it.

8.3 The sequence

"Stinkfist" (Æ.1) opens the album with a sensibility so dulled that it requires ever deeper penetration to feel; its governing image, named in the title, is the sexual practice of fisting, used as a figure for escalating stimulation. Its subject is tolerance in the pharmacological sense, Burroughs's algebra of need applied to sensation. It also marks the distinction on which the theory of this dissertation depends. Addiction and mithridatism both escalate the dose. In addiction the dose consumes the self, and the escalation serves sensation; in mithridatism the self consumes the dose, and the escalation serves capacity. "Stinkfist" stands at the threshold as the counterfeit of what the album will attempt.

"Eulogy" (Æ.2) mocks the self-appointed martyr, "H." (Æ.3) stages the internal war of opposites, and "Useful Idiot" (Æ.4) locks its groove. Henri Bergson defined the comic as the mechanical encrusted on the living (*Le Rire*, 1900), and the stuck needle is that definition in vinyl. "Forty Six & 2" (Æ.5) follows the shadow toward a karyotypic transcendence. "Message to Harry Manback" (Æ.6) sets a recorded threat over gentle piano, the poison sweetened, the incongruity of tone and content made into its own small terror. "Hooker with a Penis" (Æ.7) returns the purist's accusation.

"Intermission" (Æ.8) announces the melody of "jimmy" (Æ.9) on an organ, as at a fairground or a funeral, and the wound of the arrested child is introduced in the key of carnival. "Die Eier von Satan" (Æ.10) delivers its cookie recipe as a rally. "Pushit" (Æ.11) anatomizes a destructive bond, and its title carries two puns that commentators have long noted: the push of labor, which places the album in Grof's BPM III, and a push of excrement, which returns it to the enema (Insounder).

"Cesaro Summability" (Æ.12) is titled after a technique published by Ernesto Cesàro in 1890 for assigning finite sums to certain divergent series by averaging their partial sums. Grandi's series, which alternates without end between one and zero as its partial sums oscillate, receives the value one half. The title names the arithmetic of containing the infinite in the finite: an oscillation between opposites, like the war of "H.," stabilized by averaging into a middle value. It is the *vas hermeticum* in the idiom of analysis.

8.4 "Ænema": the hydraulic purge

"Ænema" (Æ.13), which won the Grammy for Best Metal Performance in 1998, takes its eschatology from Hicks's routine about Los Angeles sliding into the Pacific and leaving Arizona as a coast. It catalogues the city's types—its fakes, its parasites, its merchants of enlightenment—and prays for the flood that will wash them away. Its rhythmic engine is the hemiola, two against three (Insounder), a meter of doubleness for a song of double meaning.

The mythic precedents are hydraulic purges. Heracles's fifth labor was to clean in a single day the stables of Augeas, unmucked for thirty years, which he did by diverting the rivers Alpheus and Peneus through them: the enema of a kingdom. The deluge of Genesis 6–9 washes a corrupted earth; Plato's Atlantis, in the *Timaeus* (24e–25d) and *Critias*, sinks in a single day and night. But the prayer of Æ.13 is satire, not program. Hicks's Arizona Bay was a joke whose function was to let audiences rehearse catastrophe in laughter. The song's one practical counsel is to learn to swim. It does not ask the listener to stop the water or flee it; it asks for competence within it. That is the mithridatic posture exactly. The joke later became biography: Keenan relocated to Arizona's Verde Valley, the projected shore of the comedian's prophecy.

8.5 "Third Eye": the graduated light

"(-) Ions" (Æ.14) charges the air before the final track, the static of an atmosphere about to break. "Third Eye" (Æ.15), at thirteen minutes and forty-seven seconds, opens on Hicks's recorded voice and builds, by slow accumulation, toward the prying open of the eye. Danny Carey described the album's aim as demonstrating that energy is primary and the appearance of matter secondary (Contemporary Musicians, via Encyclopedia.com), and "Third Eye" is the track in which that metaphysics becomes an experience.

The samples come from two of Hicks's routines, "One Good Drug Story" and "The War on Drugs" (Ultimate Classic Rock). In one, Hicks argues that drugs have done us good, and tells doubters to burn their record collections, since the musicians who made that music were high when they made it. In the other, he imagines the positive drug story the news never reports: a young man on acid who realizes that matter is energy slowed into vibration, that consciousness is one, and that death is a dream. Hicks had also supplied the title's figure, comparing television to black paint sprayed over the third eye. Carey's statement of the album's aim, that energy is primary and matter secondary, is a gloss on Hicks's bulletin. The album's metaphysics enters it as a comedian's argument for drugs, set at the threshold of the eye.

Its form recalls the most famous pedagogy of vision in Western philosophy. In the allegory of the cave (*Republic* 514a–518b) the prisoner released and turned toward the light suffers pain in his eyes and would flee back to the shadows. He must be accustomed by degrees: first shadows, then reflections in water, then the things themselves, then the night sky, and only last the sun (516a–b). Plato calls the

conversion a *periagogē*, a turning-around of the whole soul. The cave is a mithridatic schedule for the eye—light administered in graduated doses until the organ can bear it. "Third Eye" is built on that schedule. The album that began with an anaesthetized body ends with a sensitized eye.

8.6 The cowpox model

Why is satire the cowpox of apocalypse? Because comic eschatology is related to real catastrophe as cowpox is to smallpox: it shares the antigen and lacks the lethality. To laugh at the end of the world is to rehearse it without being destroyed by it. Nietzsche's *Zauberin* had two remedies, and *Ænima* is the album in which the comic one dominates, dissolving the nausea of the absurd that *Undertow* had left untreated. Its comedy is not relief from seriousness but an instrument of it. The album purges the city, the fan, the false prophet and the rally; and when it has finished laughing, it opens the eye.

8.7 Coordinates

The immunological analogue is vaccination by a related, milder agent. The alchemical operations are *putrefactio* and *mortificatio*, the rotting and killing of the old body, with *solutio* in the flood and *separatio* in the lenticular split. Delphi supplies the mythic emblem: Apollo's oracle stands on the ground where the serpent Python rotted. The Grofian matrix is BPM III, with its scatology, its demonic register, its pushing, and its flood of release. The Dantean locus is the Malebolge, whose second ditch plunges flatterers into excrement (*Inferno* XVIII), the satirical circle of fraud. The Nietzschean figure is the lion, who speaks the sacred No. The dominant term of the tetrad is *pharmakos*: the false martyr, the city expelled into the sea, the crowd roaring at a recipe.



CHAPTER 9

Attenuation

Lateralus *and the Fibonacci Dose (2001)*

In 1879 Louis Pasteur found that a culture of chicken cholera left standing for weeks lost its virulence yet still protected the birds inoculated with it; attenuation became the method of his anthrax vaccine (1881) and his rabies vaccine (1885). *Lateralus* is the corpus's attenuation. The toxic content of the earlier albums—ressentiment, division, parasitism, the tyranny of the ego—is not removed but processed through mathematical form until it can be administered safely and repeatedly. Its emblem is the Fibonacci spiral, its sacrament the body, its climax the ego's crucifixion, and its silence the wordless resolution of "Triad."

9.1 Title and threshold

The title fuses two meanings. Lateral thinking, Edward de Bono's term (1967), names a cognition that moves sideways out of the groove of habit. The *vastus lateralis*, largest muscle of the quadriceps, is the engine of the stride, the muscle that keeps a body walking. The album's iconography is Alex Grey's: transparent overlays in the booklet, lifted one by one, reveal the body in successive layers down to its luminous core. The listener enters an anatomy lesson that is also an apocalypse in the Greek sense, an uncovering.

9.2 "The Grudge": Saturn at the threshold

"The Grudge" (L.1) opens the opus where every alchemical opus begins, with Saturn, the lead of the *prima materia*. Chapter 2 read it as a treatise on ressentiment as indigestion; here its position matters. The album begins by addressing the weight retained from all that came before, and asks that it be released and transmuted rather than held down. The long scream near its end is the discharge of what has been carried too long. *Lateralus* therefore does not begin in light. It begins at the *nigredo* of the earlier albums, and proceeds to work on it.

9.3 "Eon Blue Apocalypse": the animal psychopomp

The brief second track is widely reported to commemorate Adam Jones's Great Dane, Eon. The detail is apt. In many mythologies the dog is the guide of the dead: Anubis, the jackal-headed god who weighs the heart; Cerberus at the gate; in Mexica belief, Xolotl and the hairless dogs that carried souls across the river of Mictlan. The album's underworld is entered under the guidance of a mourned animal, and its "apocalypse" is colored blue, the color of the throat that held poison.

9.4 "The Patient": the one who undergoes

"The Patient" (L.3) is a song of endurance: an exhausted speaker resolves to wait out what he cannot yet change. The Latin *patiens* derives from *pati*, to suffer or undergo, the root of passion. The patient is the one who undergoes; he is also, in the clinic, the one under treatment. A cluster of figures surrounds the song. Dante's Belacqua sits in Ante-Purgatory (*Purgatorio* IV), condemned for his indolence to wait as long as he lived before he may climb, and he became Samuel Beckett's favorite Dantean figure, the ancestor of *En attendant Godot* (1953). Simone Weil made waiting the core of the spiritual life (*Attente de Dieu*, 1950): attention, she wrote, is the rarest and purest form of generosity. Kafka's man from the country waits a lifetime before a door that was meant only for him ("Vor dem Gesetz," 1915).

The corpus's patient differs from Kafka's. His waiting is not deferral before a closed door but endurance in the course of a treatment. He is the listener's double: the one who has consented to the dose and must wait for it to work.

9.5 "Mantra": the sacred is a matter of speed

"Mantra" (L.4) is reportedly a radically decelerated recording of a cat. The sacred syllable of the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*, in which all of time is compressed, is here produced from an animal's distress, slowed until it becomes a drone. The joke is serious. It shows that the sacred is a matter of the speed at which one listens, and it practices in miniature the iconoclasm Chapter 15 will call the Hezekiah principle: the mantra, examined, is a cat.

9.6 "Schism": the illness of relation

"Schism" (L.5), which won the Grammy for Best Metal Performance in 2002, narrates a breakdown of communication between two who once fit, and insists that the pieces still fit. Its metric volatility enacts the misfit; its resolution enacts the refit. The remedy is not new parts but renewed communication. A schism is an illness of relation rather than of substance, as the Great Schism of 1054 divided a church whose doctrines differed far less than its communications had failed. In alchemical terms the song passes from *separatio* to *coniunctio*.

9.7 "Parabol" and "Parabola": the body as vessel

The album's center is a diptych. "Parabol" (L.6), a brief and nearly static meditation, gives way to "Parabola" (L.7), which takes up the same material at full scale: a spiral dose in miniature. The song celebrates the body as a holy vessel of spirit, urges the listener to embrace the moment, and declares, at its climax, that existence is eternal and pain an illusion.

The title carries two Greek meanings. A *parabolē* is a conic section: the path of a body thrown under gravity, rising and falling, and the shape of a mirror that gathers parallel rays to a single point. The body, so figured, is both a projectile and a receiver, an arc through time and a dish that focuses light. A *parabolē* is also a parable, a "throwing-beside," a comparison that teaches.

The declaration that pain is illusory seems to contradict the doctrine of the corpus, which has insisted since Lachrymology that pain is real and productive. The contradiction dissolves under Nāgārjuna's doctrine of two truths (*Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* 24.8–10). At the level of conventional truth, *saṃvṛti*, pain is real and must be undergone; *Undertow* lives there. At the level of ultimate truth, *paramārtha*, what has been fully metabolized is seen as empty of independent substance; "Parabola" speaks from there. Nāgārjuna adds that the ultimate cannot be taught without relying on the conventional. The spiral passes from one truth to the other without denying either, and the claim that pain is illusion is earned only by the albums that took it as real. The song is also the corpus's most explicitly anti-Gnostic statement. Where the Gnostic despises the flesh as prison, "Parabola" honors it as the vessel of the sacred.

9.8 "Ticks & Leeches": phlebotomy

"Ticks & Leeches" (L.8) returns abruptly to rage. Its speaker turns on the parasites who drain him, and the vocal extremity of the performance makes the song itself a bleeding. The leech is the instrument of Galenic phlebotomy, which relieved a body of corrupted blood; medicinal leeches have returned to modern microsurgery, where they relieve venous congestion in reattached tissue. The parasite is medical. Placed immediately after "Parabola," the song prevents the album's illumination from hardening into serenity. The vessel has been sanctified; now it is bled.

9.9 "Lateralus": the spiral

The title track (L.9) is the album's formal center. Its verse syllable counts follow the Fibonacci series, climbing and descending; its chorus descends through meters of nine, eight and seven, the sixteenth Fibonacci number. Carey's account of the song's history, cited in Chapter 3, establishes that the meters came first and the Fibonacci identity was noticed afterwards; the syllabic structure was then built deliberately upon the found pattern (Loaded Radio). The song's lyric is a hymn of desire to exceed the limits of perception, figured as a spiral ascent, and it closes on an injunction to continue outward.

The practice of numbering syllables has a cosmological precedent. The *Sefer Yetzirah* (between the second and sixth centuries) describes the creation of the world through thirty-two paths: the ten *sefirot* and the twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet, combined and permuted. Creation, in that text, is the numerical arrangement of letters, and "Lateralus" is a small cosmogony of the same kind. Its direction matters as much as its number. A spiral may turn inward, toward a vortex that swallows, or outward, toward a helix that grows. The song specifies the outward turn, and in doing so supplies the criterion, developed in Chapter 14, that distinguishes the healing spiral from the pathological one.

9.10 "Disposition," "Reflection," "Triad": the law of three

The closing suite descends through three stations. "Disposition" (L.10) is receptivity: a meditation on weather, on watching the climate of the self change. "Reflection" (L.11) is the crisis: the recognition of the ego as the author of its suffering, the lunar figure of borrowed light, the acceptance of the ego's crucifixion. "Triad" (L.12) has no words. It is the third force of Gurdjieff's law, the reconciling term that completes what affirmation and denial began, and in Abhinavagupta's Kashmir Śaivism, whose school bears the name *Trika*, the triad, it would be the resolution of Śiva, Śakti and the individual into one.

That the suite culminates in an instrumental is a theological statement. Pseudo-Dionysius's *Mystical Theology* (c. 500) describes the ascent of the soul beyond names and concepts into the divine darkness, where speech falls silent. "Triad" renders the *via negativa* as music. The corpus's most important lyric, the ego's surrender in "Reflection," is followed by the abandonment of lyric altogether.

9.11 "Faaip de Oiad": the warning after the vision

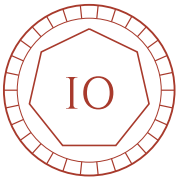
The album does not end in silence. "Faaip de Oiad" (L.13), discussed in Chapter 3, sets the voice of God under a broadcast of panic about deceptive beings. At the moment of illumination, the corpus introduces the Gnostic suspicion that the light may be an archon's. The gnosis is administered with its own warning label.

9.12 The Holy Gift: the listener completes the circle

Within months of the album's release, listeners proposed a re-sequencing—soon called the "Holy Gift"—that converts the linear tracklist into a continuous loop with seamless transitions. Whatever the band intended, the practice is significant. The audience reconstructed the ouroboros from the album's parts, completing what Eco called an open work (*Opera aperta*, 1962). It was the first mass exercise of the apophenic pedagogy described in Chapter 15, and its object was the shape of the album itself.

9.13 Coordinates

The immunological analogue is attenuation: the pathogen weakened by processing until it can be safely administered. The alchemical operations are *sublimatio*, the ascent of the spiral, and *coagulatio*, the sanctified body; the color is the *albedo* turning toward *citrinitas*. The Grofian matrix is BPM IV, death and rebirth, opening onto the oceanic unity of BPM I in "Parabola." The Dantean locus is the Purgatorio, a spiral mountain of seven terraces where Belacqua waits. Plato's *periagogē* and Plotinus's *epistrophē*, the soul's return to its source, are the philosophical correlates. The Nietzschean figure is the child, the self-propelled wheel opened into a spiral. The dominant term of the tetrad is *pharmakon* in its sense of remedy.



CHAPTER 10

Immunological Memory

10,000 Days *and the Work of Mourning (2006)*

Adaptive immunity remembers. After a first exposure, memory lymphocytes persist for years or decades, so that a second encounter provokes a faster and stronger response; the body keeps a record of what has harmed it. *10,000 Days* is the corpus's immunological memory. It is an album of mourning, in which the wound first sung in "jimmy" returns fully metabolized, and an album about memory itself: lost keys, a forgotten message, an undeciphered stone, a sky that weeps. Its central achievement is to replace revelation with remembrance.

10.1 Title, cycle, and stereopsis

Keenan has glossed the title twice. It refers to the Saturn return, the completion of the planet's orbit in the late twenties of a life, which he described as an opportunity to transform; and it refers to his mother, Judith Marie, who lived roughly ten thousand days, about twenty-seven years, between the aneurysm that paralyzed her and her death (Loaded Radio). The two glosses converge. Saturn's sidereal period is a little under thirty years, and the planet that rose at the opening of *Lateralus* now completes its circuit as the measure of a life. In alchemical terms, the lead with which the previous opus began returns as the full cycle of time.

The packaging, which won the Grammy for Best Recording Package, contained built-in stereoscopic lenses for viewing Alex Grey's paintings (Loaded Radio). Stereopsis, demonstrated by Charles Wheatstone in 1838, fuses two flat images taken from slightly different positions into a single image with depth. The device teaches the album's operation before a note is heard. Two images—the mother's suffering and her faith, the son's doubt and his love—are fused into depth. The lenticular split of *Ænima* trained the listener to see incompatible aspects; the stereoscope of *10,000 Days* trains him to unite them.

10.2 "Vicarious" and "Jambi": two economies of desire

The album opens with "Vicarious" (M.1), the spectator's confession discussed in Chapter 6. Its placement matters. It sets the vicarious consumption of strangers' suffering against the album's center, in which the suffering of one beloved person was witnessed not vicariously but intimately, day after day, for twenty-seven years. The difference between spectatorship and witness is the difference between the pharmakos economy and the work of mourning.

"Jambi" (M.2) takes its name from the genie of a children's television program and its theme from the oldest of wish stories. Its speaker refuses every bargain that would trade his present blessing for something greater, and resolves to protect what he has. Jones's solo is played through a talk box, which routes the guitar's sound through the player's mouth (Loaded Radio): the instrument is given a throat. The precedents are cautionary. Goethe's Faust wagers that he will never say to the passing moment that it should stay, because it is beautiful; W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw" (1902) shows the granted wish as poison; Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979), after the Strugatskys' *Roadside Picnic* (1972), imagines a Room that grants not the wish one states but the one one harbors. "Jambi" answers them all with *amor fati*: the safest wish is to want what one has.

10.3 "Wings for Marie" and "10,000 Days": the son as psychopomp

The diptych at the album's heart (M.3–4) runs to some seventeen minutes and ends in the sound of a storm. Its son confesses that he is not as faithful as his mother; sets her silent, immobile faith against the loud righteousness of those who judged others in God's name; and imagines her release, calling on the heavens to receive her as one who has earned her place. Four readings converge.

The first is Dantean. Beatrice, the beloved dead woman, intercedes in heaven for the poet's salvation. Here the order is reversed: the living son intercedes for the dead mother. The second is Orphic. Orpheus descends to bring the dead back and loses her by looking back. The son of "10,000 Days" ascends with the dead in order to give her away, and does not look back. Rilke's Eurydice, full of her own death and no longer belonging to the singer, is the figure the song honors. In Freud's terms, the song performs mourning, the labor of letting the lost object go, and refuses melancholia, the ego's identification with it.

The third reading is Kierkegaardian and Pauline. The mother is a knight of faith, her infinite movement invisible from outside. Her paralysis invites Paul's language of suffering that completes what is lacking in Christ's afflictions (Colossians 1:24), and the son does not claim that her suffering was good. He claims only that her faith was real. His stance is what Jürgen Habermas called post-secular ("Glauben und Wissen," 2001): he honors a belief he does not share and finds in it a truth his own doubt cannot refute.

The fourth reading closes a circle opened in 1993. The album's storm is weeping on a cosmic scale. Lachrymology, the hoax of a philosophy of tears, is fulfilled here as rite. And "jimmy" (Æ.9), which in 1996 froze a child at the moment of catastrophe, finds its working-through ten years later. The same wound returns at a larger radius, now metabolized. In alchemical terms this is the *rubedo* and the *coniunctio*: the son reconciled with the mother, the dead united with what she believed.

10.4 "The Pot" and "Lipan Conjuring"

"The Pot" (M.5) indicts hypocrisy, the accuser who partakes of what he condemns. Its title plays on the proverb of the pot that calls the kettle black and on cannabis, and a third sense is available: the pot is a cooking vessel, an alchemist's vessel accusing another vessel of blackness, the *nigredo* denied in oneself and projected onto another. "Lipan Conjuring" (M.6) is a chant invoking the Lipan Apache. It raises a question the corpus does not resolve: the ethics of borrowing Indigenous sacred forms for a project of private transformation.

10.5 "Lost Keys" and "Rosetta Stoned": the pharmakon of memory

The diptych at the album's second center is a farce built on the oldest text about the pharmakon. In "Lost Keys (Blame Hofmann)" (M.7), a physician and a nurse confer in a hospital over a patient brought in unresponsive, who begins to speak. In "Rosetta Stoned" (M.8), the patient tells his story. Intoxicated, he witnessed an encounter with extraterrestrials and was given an urgent message for humanity; he insists that he was chosen; and he cannot remember the message, having had nothing with which to write it down.

The monologue ends on a scatological punchline: the chosen one has soiled himself (Ultimate Classic Rock). Revelation terminates in an involuntary evacuation. The enema of *Ænima* returns without its vessel, and catharsis becomes incontinence. The joke is the comic proof of Proposition IV: a dose taken without a container does not transmute; it simply passes through.

The Rosetta Stone, a decree of 196 BCE inscribed in hieroglyphic, Demotic and Greek, was found in 1799, and its three scripts allowed Jean-François Champollion to decipher the hieroglyphs in 1822. It is the key to the script of Thoth. In Plato's *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), Thoth—Theuth—presents writing to King Thamus as a *pharmakon* for memory. Thamus replies that it will produce forgetfulness, a remedy not for memory but for reminding. Derrida built "La pharmacie de Platon" on this scene. "Rosetta Stoned" restages it as farce, inverted. The messenger has no writing, and so he forgets; the absence of the pharmakon of writing produces the very forgetfulness Thamus attributed to its presence. A second pharmakon, the intoxicant, both opens the channel to revelation and erases it. Revelation in late modernity arrives unwritten, intoxicated and suspect, and cannot become scripture.

Two Platonic and Gnostic texts sharpen the point. In the Myth of Er (*Republic* X, 614b–621d), a soldier slain in battle returns after twelve days to report the afterlife,

having been forbidden to drink from the river of forgetfulness; the souls choosing new lives drink and forget. The narrator of "Rosetta Stoned" is the anti-Er: he drank, and forgot. The Orphic gold tablets from Hipponion and Petelia instruct the dead initiate to avoid one spring and drink from the lake of Mnemosyne, declaring to its guardians that he is a child of Earth and starry Heaven. *10,000 Days* is an album about which spring one drinks from. And in the *Hymn of the Pearl*, a letter arrives to wake the prince who has forgotten his mission. In "Rosetta Stoned" no letter comes.

The missing letter is the point. Within the album's architecture, the message that matters is not the one the abductee received from the sky and lost. It is the one the son carries in "Wings," earned by twenty-seven years of witness and kept in memory. Revelation from outside fails; remembrance from within succeeds. The year of the album, as Chapter 4 noted, was the year Hofmann turned one hundred and the year psilocybin returned to the clinic. The corpus placed the chemist's name over a hospital scene and made the patient the prophet, and then made the prophecy a joke. Its clinical sacrament is memory.

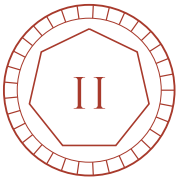
10.6 "Intension" and "Right in Two"

"Intension" (M.9) puns on intention and on tension. Heraclitus observed that what is at variance agrees with itself, in a back-stretched harmony like that of the bow and the lyre (DK B51). The bow is Apollo's weapon and the lyre Hermes's invention, and both work only under tension; the harmony of opposites is not their resolution but their right tension.

"Right in Two" (M.10) gives voice to angels who watch human beings divide everything they can claim—land, sky, each other—and puzzle over why the Father gave such creatures free will. The apes of "Forty Six & 2" reappear, now quarrelling over territory. The angels share the suspicion of Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880, Book V, chapter 5), who argues that freedom is too heavy a gift and that human beings prefer bread, miracle, mystery and authority. The song does not answer the angels. It leaves free will as the Father's pharmakon: the condition of every atrocity and of every act of faith, including the mother's.

10.7 "Viginti Tres" and the coordinates

The album closes on "Viginti Tres" (M.11), twenty-three, a drone carrying the most famous number of the Discordian tradition: an apophenic lure planted at the exit. The immunological analogue of the album is memory, the body's record of what harmed it, and the philosophical analogue is anamnesis, in Plato's sense and in Philip K. Dick's. The alchemical stage is the *rubedo* and the operation the *coniunctio*; the Saturnine cycle closes. The Grofian position is the biographical mother behind the perinatal matrix. The Dantean locus is the Paradiso, with its intercession by the dead. The Nietzschean figure is the child grown old. The dominant terms of the tetrad are *pharmakeus*—the physician and the nurse, the chemist named in a title, the son who heals by remembering—and *pharmakos*, in the spectacle with which the album opens.



CHAPTER 11

The Inoculum

Fear Inoculum *(2019) and the Spiral Return of* Opiate^2 *(2022)*

THIRTEEN YEARS AFTER *10,000 Days*, the corpus named its operation. *Fear Inoculum* is an album about immunity to a contagion of fear, sung by a man in his mid-fifties about breath, age, gravity, paranoia and rage. Its interludes borrow the title of a litany against fear from Frank Herbert's *Dune* and summon the demons of Gerasa; its compact disc is a heptad. Three years later, *Opiate*^{2} returned to the first dose and re-administered it at a higher power. In immunological terms, the corpus closes with an inoculum and a booster.

11.1 Thirteen years

The interval between the fourth and fifth albums—thirteen years, a Fibonacci number, as listeners did not fail to notice—was filled by litigation, injuries and disagreements over method (Loaded Radio). The band released its catalogue to streaming services on 2 August 2019, four weeks before the album appeared. *Fear Inoculum* reached the top of the *Billboard* 200; its title track, at ten minutes and twenty-one seconds, became the longest song yet to enter the Hot 100, displacing David Bowie's "Blackstar"; and "7empest" won the Grammy for Best Metal Performance in 2020. The compact disc carries seven tracks across seventy-nine minutes; the digital edition adds three interludes and runs to eighty-six (Loaded Radio).

The title's etymology, introduced in the Introduction and developed in Chapter 15, governs the reading. *Inoculum* is the material used to inoculate; *inoculare*, before it named the implantation of disease, meant to graft a bud—an "eye"—into another plant. The "Third Eye" of 1996 was a bud. The inoculum of 2019 is the graft taken.

11.2 "Fear Inoculum": immunity to a contagion

The title track (FI.1) describes fear as an infection spread by a deceiver who profits from it, and its speaker resolves to expel the deceiver and the fear together, an exhalation that is also an act of immunity. The song draws together a long lineage.

Seneca counseled the rehearsal of misfortunes so that none could arrive as a surprise (*Epistulae morales* 24, 91), and Cicero transmitted the doctrine as the *praemeditatio futurorum malorum* (*Tusculan Disputations* III.29–31). In 1961 the social psychologist William McGuire, with Demetrios Papageorgis, proposed an inoculation theory of persuasion, by explicit biological analogy: attitudes can be made resistant by exposure to weakened counterarguments together with their refutation. Jon Roozenbeek and Sander van der Linden showed in 2019 that a game exposing players to the techniques of misinformation conferred resistance to it, and van der Linden's *Foolproof* (2023) generalized the program as "prebunking." Donald Meichenbaum's stress inoculation training (1985) applied the same logic to anxiety. And Burroughs had defined the enemy: language as a virus, which only a vaccine can answer.

The Heideggerian distinction of Chapter 2 is respected. The album's fear is *Furcht*, fear transmitted and manufactured, and the inoculum is directed against it; the album's *Angst*—before mortality, age and the descent of the world—is not anaesthetized but embraced. One further resonance is retrospective. The album appeared six months before the COVID-19 pandemic made the vocabulary of inoculation universal and politically contested. The coincidence colors later listening; it implies no position on that debate, and none is taken here.

11.3 "Pneuma": the breath

"Pneuma" (FI.2) addresses spirit bound to flesh and calls it to wake and remember. The Stoics, after Chrysippus, made *pneuma* the fiery breath that pervades the cosmos and holds bodies together; the Hebrew *ruach* is breath and spirit at once; the Valentinians made the *pneumatikoi* the awakened. Jung's formula reaches its far term here: the corpus that began with the craving for spirits in "Sober" arrives at spirit. Grof's breathwork, the Gurdjieffian call to self-remembering, and the Tibetan practice of *tonglen*, in which suffering is breathed in and relief breathed out, converge on the breath as the organ of the inoculum. The word *anima*, which named the album of 1996, originally meant breath as well. The corpus moves from the psychic to the pneumatic, from soul to spirit, without leaving the lungs.

11.4 "Litanie contre la Peur": the Bene Gesserit ordeal

The first interlude (FI.3) borrows the title of the Bene Gesserit litany from *Dune* (1965), in which the speaker resolves to face fear, let it pass over and through, and remain when it has gone. The track is instrumental: the litany is cited by title alone, an apophatic quotation. Herbert's novel supplies two ordeals that bear on the theory. In the test of the gom jabbar, a young man must keep his hand in a box that produces the sensation of burning, under threat of a poisoned needle, to prove that he is human: an animal would gnaw off its leg to escape a trap, a human endures. And in the ceremony of the Water of Life, a woman drinks a lethal poison and transmutes it within her own body, so that what she passes on becomes a sacrament the community

can share. Chapter 12 will argue that this is the paradigmatic image of mithridatic gnosis in modern fiction.

11.5 "Invincible": the aging warrior

"Invincible" (FI.4) is sung by a warrior once unbeaten who now contends with age, obsolescence and the question of his own relevance, and who keeps fighting while accepting limits. It is the fourth metamorphosis Nietzsche omitted, the *senex* of Hillman's archetypal psychology. Hillman's late book *The Force of Character and the Lasting Life* (1999) argued that aging reveals character rather than eroding it. Tennyson's "Ulysses" (1842) is the poem's ancestor, the old king who will not rust: *Though much is taken, much abides*. Yeats's "Sailing to Byzantium" (1928) is its other ancestor: "An aged man is but a paltry thing, / A tattered coat upon a stick, unless / Soul clap its hands and sing." Inanna, stripped of a power at each of seven gates, and Gilgamesh, returning to his walls after the serpent has taken his rejuvenation, are its mythic types. The song refuses both the fantasy of perpetual youth and the surrender of the aged. Its invincibility is not the absence of defeat but the persistence of the practice.

11.6 "Legion Inoculant": the demons of Gerasa

The second interlude (FI.5) names the most extraordinary exorcism of the Gospels. In Mark 5:1–20, a man possessed among the tombs answers Jesus's question with the words *My name is Legion: for we are many*. The demons beg to enter a herd of some two thousand swine, which rush down the bank into the sea and drown. Girard devoted a chapter of *Le Bouc émissaire* (1982) to the episode, reading it as the scapegoat mechanism exposed: here the many, not the one, are driven out. The swine recall Circe's herd in the *Odyssey*, men turned into animals by evil drugs. An inoculant against Legion is an inoculant against the crowd—the crowd outside, and the crowd of voices within, which the album addresses next.

11.7 "Descending" and "Culling Voices"

"Descending" (FI.6) is a song of gravity: the fall of bodies, the slow descent of a world, the waves. The parabola of 2001 here completes its downward arc. Simone Weil's *La Pesanteur et la grâce* (1947) holds that everything falls except grace, and that grace enters precisely where a soul consents to descend. The katabasis of youth was a dive to the floor; the katabasis of age is the consent to fall.

"Culling Voices" (FI.7) turns inward to the voices that accuse without evidence and the paranoia that convicts by suspicion. Its historical analogue is the witch-hunt. The *Malleus Maleficarum* (1486), written by the Dominican inquisitor Heinrich Kramer, was a manual for prosecuting witches that endorsed torture and execution, and at Salem in 1692 a colonial court hanged nineteen people and pressed one man, Giles Corey, to death on the testimony of accusing neighbors. Both persecuted imagined poisoners; Galatians 5:20 lists *pharmakeia* among the works of the flesh,

rendered "witchcraft" in the King James Version. Its contemplative analogue is the *Antirrhētikos* of Evagrius Ponticus (fourth century), a manual of scriptural answers to be spoken against each of the eight tempting thoughts—the desert's own litany against fear. The song warns against the overdose of the apophenic faculty that Chapter 15 will describe.

11.8 "Chocolate Chip Trip" and "7empest"

"Chocolate Chip Trip" (FI.8) is Danny Carey's solo with modular synthesis, and its title returns, twenty-three years later, to the cookies of "Die Eier von Satan," whose recipe calls for hashish: the confection was always a dose, and the trip was always its destination. The drum is the shaman's horse in Siberian traditions, and the anthropologist Michael Harner described its sonic driving as a vehicle of trance (*The Way of the Shaman*, 1980).

"7empest" (FI.9), at fifteen minutes and forty-four seconds, is a storm of rage against a deceiver who is never named, carried by Adam Jones's longest guitar statement on record. Its numeral places it in the heptadic lineage of Chapter 3—the octave's seventh step, Inanna's gates, Dante's terraces, the *Poimandres*'s spheres. Its literary precedent is Shakespeare's *The Tempest* (1611). Prospero, the aged magus, raises a storm against those who wronged him, forgives them, breaks his staff, drowns his book, and steps forward in the epilogue to ask the audience to set him free. The mage renounces his magic at the height of its power; the release of the performer is delegated to those who watched.

11.9 "Mockingbeat" and the seal of mimicry

The album ends with "Mockingbeat" (FI.10), a collage of mimicking birdsong. The mockingbird is the mimetic bird, and Girard's theory begins with mimesis. The album seals its inoculum with a warning: what has been administered must not be copied as a style. An imitated inoculum is only another fashion.

11.10 *Opiate*^{2}: the booster

On 1 March 2022 the band released *Opiate*^{2}, a reimagined and extended version of the title track of its first commercial release, with a short film co-directed by Adam Jones and Dominic Hailstone and marketed as the band's first new video in fifteen years (Kerrang!). The first dose returns after thirty years, re-administered by an organism that has been inoculated. In immunology a booster is a later re-exposure to the original antigen that strengthens the memory of it. The opiate that opened the corpus is not repeated; it is raised to a power. Bernoulli's motto describes the operation exactly: the same, changed, rising again. The ouroboros of the self-devouring circle is opened into a helix, its end returning to its beginning at a larger radius.

11.11 Coordinates

The immunological analogues are the inoculum, the herd immunity it aims at, and the booster that consolidates it. The alchemical operations are *multiplicatio* and *projectio*: the philosopher's stone, once achieved, multiplies its power and is projected onto base matter to transmute it—the elixir distributed. The Grofian register is the transpersonal. The Dantean locus is the return to earth, under Cacciaguida's charge to publish the bitter vision. The Nietzschean figures are the convalescent and the old man. All four terms of the tetrad are present and reintegrated: the deceiver as *pharmakeus* of fear, the crowd and the swine as *pharmakoi*, *pharmakeia* in the witch-hunt, and the inoculum as the counter-*pharmakon*.

PART

III

Comparative Constellations



Part III sets the corpus among works that administer the same pharmakon by other means: speculative fictions that imagine drugs, ordeals, counterfeit religions and fatal patterns, and the wisdom traditions and sciences that have theorized toxic benefit. The comparisons are not genealogical. They sharpen the theory by locating its prototypes, its counterfeits, its overdoses and its limits.



CHAPTER 12

TOOL Among the Speculative Fictions

SPECULATIVE FICTION IS THE modern literature of the pharmakon. Its drugs, ordeals, false religions and lethal patterns allow a typology that locates mithridatic gnosis precisely: among prototypes that realize it, counterfeits that imitate it without freedom, overdoses that exceed it, ordeals that reveal its ethical limit, an anti-type that denies its possibility, and transcendences that leave the human behind. The table at the end of the chapter summarizes the typology.

12.1 Prototypes: *Dune* and *Island*

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965), the corpus's one documented speculative source, contains the most exact fictional image of the theory. Its ordeals form a graded series. The gom jabbar tests whether a young man can keep his hand in a box of induced pain under threat of a poisoned needle; the human endures where the trapped animal would gnaw off its limb. The Litany Against Fear, borrowed as a title by FI.3, is a technique for letting fear pass through without being carried by it. The spice melange is prescience and addiction at once, the opiate and the inoculum in a single substance. And the Water of Life is the paradigm. A woman drinks a poison that would kill an untrained body, transmutes it within herself, and passes on what she has changed, so that the community may drink it as a sacrament. The adept metabolizes the toxin; the people share the transmuted substance. That is the structure of the theriac work, in which the artist digests the poison and distributes the antidote.

Herbert added the safeguard. *Dune Messiah* (1969) and his later commentary turned the saga against its hero, warning against the charismatic leader whose followers make him a god. The prophet who survives the Water of Life becomes the center of a holy war. The corpus's refusal of the messianic role (Chapter 15) is Herbert's warning practiced by the artist rather than narrated about a character.

Aldous Huxley's *Island* (1962) supplies the second prototype: *moksha*-medicine administered within a ritual and pedagogical container on the utopian island of Pala. The sacrament liberates because the community surrounding it is designed to hold what it reveals.

12.2 Counterfeits: freedom removed

Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962) imagines the Ludovico technique. The young delinquent Alex is drugged and made to watch films of violence until violence itself produces nausea, and with it the music of Beethoven that accompanied the films. The prison chaplain objects that a goodness which is not chosen is not goodness. The technique is a counterfeit inoculum: exposure imposed by the state in order to abolish choice. The corpus's inoculum differs on the decisive point. It is self-administered, and it increases rather than abolishes the freedom that "Right in Two" treats as the Father's ambivalent gift.

Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) is the opiate as social technology, *soma* as pacification. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971) gives the counterfeit a physician: George Orr's dreams alter reality, and the psychiatrist William Haber, administering drugs and machines, uses them to remake the world in his own image. The *pharmakeus* becomes a tyrant. William Gibson, named in early profiles of the band, imagined in *Neuromancer* (1984) a hacker whose nervous system has been poisoned by his employers and is later repaired, with sacs of toxin implanted in his arteries as leverage. The poison held inside the body as an instrument of another's control is the exact inverse of mithridatic gnosis.

12.3 Overdoses: the lethal pattern

Umberto Eco's *Foucault's Pendulum* (1988) is the definitive fiction of apophenic overdose. Three Milanese editors, bored by occult manuscripts, invent "the Plan," a conspiracy linking every esoteric tradition in history. Believers take it literally, and one of the inventors is killed. Eco's theoretical work (*Interpretation and Overinterpretation*, 1992) diagnoses the mechanism the novel dramatizes, a hermetic semiosis in which every sign refers to another without end. Borges's "La muerte y la brújula" (1942) gives the overdose its purest form: a detective deduces a kabbalistic pattern in a series of murders and walks into the trap his own pattern-finding has made predictable. Thomas Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966) suspends its heroine between three hypotheses—a real conspiracy, a hoax planted for her, a private fantasy—and refuses to choose. Shea and Wilson's *Illuminatus!* (1975) is the vaccine version: conspiracy satire that inoculates by excess.

12.4 Ordeals at their limit

Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919) is the dark mirror of Lachrymology. An apparatus inscribes the sentence on the body of the condemned over twelve hours; the officer who serves it claims that around the sixth hour the sufferer's face shows

understanding. The visiting explorer is unmoved. The officer places himself in the machine, which breaks apart and kills him without the promised illumination. Suffering administered by an apparatus for the sake of enlightenment is torture, and its enlightenment is the torturer's fantasy. The story fixes the limit of the theory: the dose must be self-administered, graduated, contained and revocable.

Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) fixes the other limit. A city's happiness depends on the continuous misery of one child, and some citizens, having seen the child, walk away. The pharmakos economy is refused rather than refined. "Vicarious" stands with those who leave.

12.5 The anti-type: Lovecraft

H. P. Lovecraft's "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) opens: "The most merciful thing in the world, I think, is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents." Correlated knowledge, the story goes on, would drive us mad. Lovecraftian gnosis is unmetabolizable: knowledge destroys the knower, and the narrator's only defense is to close his eyes. The corpus is the anti-Lovecraft. "Third Eye" opens where Lovecraft's narrators shut theirs, and the difference lies in the dose and the vessel, not in the nature of what is seen.

12.6 Transcendences

Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) ends with humanity's children dissolving into a cosmic Overmind under the supervision of beings who look like devils; Kubrick and Clarke's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) makes a monolith the catalyst of evolution and ends with a Star Child. Both imagine transcendence as the end of the human. The corpus, whose evolutionary song arrives numerically at the karyotype of the great apes (Chapter 1), imagines transcendence as the human re-incorporating its animal.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) imagines an ocean that materializes its visitors' guilt: Kelvin's dead wife returns, and he cannot mourn her because she will not stay dead. It is the melancholic counterpart of *10,000 Days*. Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972), filmed by Tarkovsky as *Stalker* (1979), imagines a Zone at whose center a Room grants one's innermost wish rather than one's stated wish; the guide called Porcupine wished for his brother's return, received wealth, and hanged himself. "Jambi" knows the Room. Hermann Hesse's *Steppenwolf* (1927) sends its divided hero into a Magic Theater for madmen only, where a saxophonist dispenses drugs and the Immortals teach laughter; *The Glass Bead Game* (1943) imagines Castalia, an order that has fused music and mathematics into a spiritual discipline and grown sterile for lack of a body. The corpus has Castalia's number and "Parabola"'s flesh. Borges's "El Aleph" (1945) shows a point in which all points are seen, and records the narrator's grief as forgetting begins.

Two works in the comics tradition come nearest the corpus's ambitions. Alan Moore's *Promethea* (1999–2005) is an initiatory treatise on Hermetic Kabbalah and the

Tarot that ends in an apocalypse understood as a transformation of consciousness, the closest speculative analogue to "Ænema"; Moore has long held that art and magic are the same practice. Grant Morrison's *The Invisibles* (1994–2000) introduced the "hypersigil," a long work designed as a magical operation on its author's life. The corpus is better described as a hyper-theriac: a long work designed as an antidote for its listeners.

Finally, the fictions that became religions. Robert Heinlein's *Stranger in a Strange Land* (1961), with its rite of water-sharing, inspired the Church of All Worlds; Discordianism outgrew its parody; and Vonnegut's *Cat's Cradle* (1963) contains, in one novel, both of the corpus's poles. Bokononism, the self-declared lie that consoles, is Lachrymology's twin. Ice-nine, a seed crystal that converts all water it touches into ice, is the anti-inoculum: an infectious template of total conversion, which ends the world when it reaches the sea. Fear, in the corpus's account, is ice-nine.

12.7 Typology

The corpus belongs with the prototypes, and its distinctive contribution is to have absorbed the warnings of the other five types into its own practice: Herbert's anti-messianism, Burgess's insistence on choice, Eco's fear of the Plan, Kafka's refusal of redemptive torture, Le Guin's refusal of the scapegoat, and Lovecraft's respect for what cannot be digested.

TYPE
Prototype

EXEMPLARS
Dune; Island

PHARMAKON
Water of Life; *moksha*-medicine

ADMINISTERED BY
the adept, within a rite

OUTCOME
transmutation shared with a community

RELATION TO MITHRIDATIC GNOSIS
realized

TYPE
Counterfeit

EXEMPLARS
A Clockwork Orange; Brave New World; The Lathe of Heaven; Neuromancer

PHARMAKON
Ludovico serum; *soma*; drugged dreams; implanted toxin

ADMINISTERED BY
the state or a controlling physician

OUTCOME
conditioning, pacification, control

RELATION TO MITHRIDATIC GNOSIS
imitated without freedom

TYPE
Overdose

EXEMPLARS
Foucault's Pendulum; "Death and the Compass"; *The Crying of Lot 49*

PHARMAKON
pattern

ADMINISTERED BY
the self, without limit

OUTCOME
death or paranoia

RELATION TO MITHRIDATIC GNOSIS
exceeded

TYPE
Ordeal at its limit

EXEMPLARS
"In the Penal Colony"; "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas"

PHARMAKON
inscribed pain; another's misery

ADMINISTERED BY
an apparatus; a city

OUTCOME
torture; complicity

RELATION TO MITHRIDATIC GNOSIS
refused

TYPE
Anti-type

EXEMPLARS
"The Call of Cthulhu"

PHARMAKON
forbidden knowledge

ADMINISTERED BY
the cosmos

OUTCOME
madness

RELATION TO MITHRIDATIC GNOSIS
denied

TYPE
Transcendence

EXEMPLARS
Childhood's End; Solaris; Stalker; Steppenwolf; Promethea

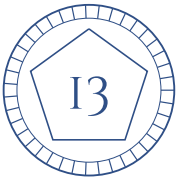
PHARMAKON
metamorphosis; wish; theater; apocalypse

ADMINISTERED BY
aliens; a Zone; a magic theater

OUTCOME
departure from or return to the human

RELATION TO MITHRIDATIC GNOSIS
partial

FIG. 7 **A typology of fictional pharmacies.** Prototype, counterfeit, overdose, ordeal, anti-type, transcendence.



CHAPTER 13

TOOL Among the Wisdom Traditions and the Nonfiction of Toxic Benefit

THE DOCTRINE THAT POISON can be transmuted into medicine is among the most widely distributed ideas in the world's contemplative traditions, and in the last century it has acquired an experimental literature. This chapter sets the corpus among both, to show that mithridatic gnosis is not the idiosyncrasy of a rock band but a point of convergence—and to show what the corpus does differently.

13.1 Buddhist traditions: poison into medicine

The *Mahāprajñāpāramitāśāstra*, attributed to Nāgārjuna and translated into Chinese by Kumārajīva between 402 and 406, compares the Buddha's teaching to a great physician who can change poison into medicine. Nichiren made the phrase a doctrine in thirteenth-century Japan: *hendoku iyaku*, transforming poison into medicine. Śāntideva's *Bodhicaryāvatāra* (eighth century) taught the exchange of self and other, and the Tibetan mind-training tradition (*lojong*), transmitted from Atiśa and codified in Geshe Chekawa's *Seven-Point Mind Training* (twelfth century), built on it the practice of *tonglen*: breathing in the suffering of others as dark smoke and breathing out relief as light. The breath is the vehicle of the exchange, as it is in "Pneuma."

The tenth-century teacher Dharmarakṣita wrote two poems for this tradition, *The Wheel of Sharp Weapons* and *The Peacock's Neutralizing of Poison*. The peacock thrives on poisonous plants, which brighten its plumage; the bodhisattva consumes the poisons of affliction and transforms them. The image will return in Chapter 15. Vajrayāna systematized the transformation: the five poisons—ignorance, attachment, aversion, pride and envy—are not abandoned but transmuted into the five wisdoms of the five Buddha families. The corpus's affective palette is a register of exactly these

five: the ignorance of "Useful Idiot," the craving of "Stinkfist" and "Sober," the rage of "The Grudge" and "7empest," the pride of "Eulogy," the rivalry of "Right in Two." And Nāgārjuna's two truths, as Chapter 9 showed, resolve the apparent contradiction between Lachrymology's real pain and "Parabola"'s illusory one.

13.2 Śaiva aesthetics: Nīlakaṇṭha and *rasa*

The myth of the churning (Chapter 5) places the transmutation of poison in the god's throat. Later Tantric physiology associates the throat center, *viśuddha*, "purification," with voice and with the conversion of poison into nectar. The organ of the singer is the organ of the transmutation.

The aesthetic theory of the same tradition is the most sophisticated precedent for the corpus's procedure. Abhinavagupta (c. 950–1016), the master of Kashmir Śaivism —a school called *Trika*, "the triad"—commented on Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* (*Abhinavabhāratī*) and on Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka* (*Locana*), and developed the theory of *rasa*. *Rasa* means juice, flavor, taste. A represented emotion, freed by the conditions of art from personal interest (*sādhāraṇīkaraṇa*, generalization), becomes something the audience can savor, and this holds even for fear, disgust and fury. Abhinavagupta argued for a ninth *rasa*, *śānta*, peace, as the ground into which all the others resolve. The corpus covers the full *navarasa*.

One further fact makes the comparison more than analogy. In Sanskrit, *rasa* is also the name of mercury in the medieval alchemical science called *rasaśāstra*, and *rasāyana* is the branch of Āyurveda devoted to rejuvenating elixirs. Aesthetic savor, alchemical mercury—the metal of Hermes—and the rejuvenating elixir share a single word. The corpus reconstitutes in English, from Jung, Paracelsus and the Hermetic tradition, a unity that Sanskrit never separated.

13.3 Abrahamic traditions

The bronze serpent of Numbers 21 and its destruction by Hezekiah frame the theory's ethics (Chapters 5 and 15); the Gospel of John (3:14) made the serpent lifted on the pole a type of the crucified Christ. Paul's thorn in the flesh, which God refused to remove because strength is made perfect in weakness (2 Corinthians 12:7–9), and his claim to complete in his own flesh what is lacking in Christ's afflictions (Colossians 1:24), are the Christian doctrine of suffering transfigured.

The desert tradition supplied the technique. Evagrius Ponticus (345–399) mapped eight tempting thoughts—gluttony, lust, avarice, sadness, anger, *acedia*, vainglory and pride, the ancestor of the seven deadly sins—and in the *Antirrhētikos* compiled scriptural replies to be spoken against each. It is a litany against fear in the most practical sense, an art of answering the voices. Simone Weil (1909–1943) made affliction, *malheur*, the place where God's absence becomes a kind of presence, and attention the soul's most necessary work. Jakob Böhme (*Aurora*, 1612; *Mysterium Magnum*, 1623) taught that the divine wrath-fire and love-fire are one fire, and that darkness is fire not yet transmuted into light.

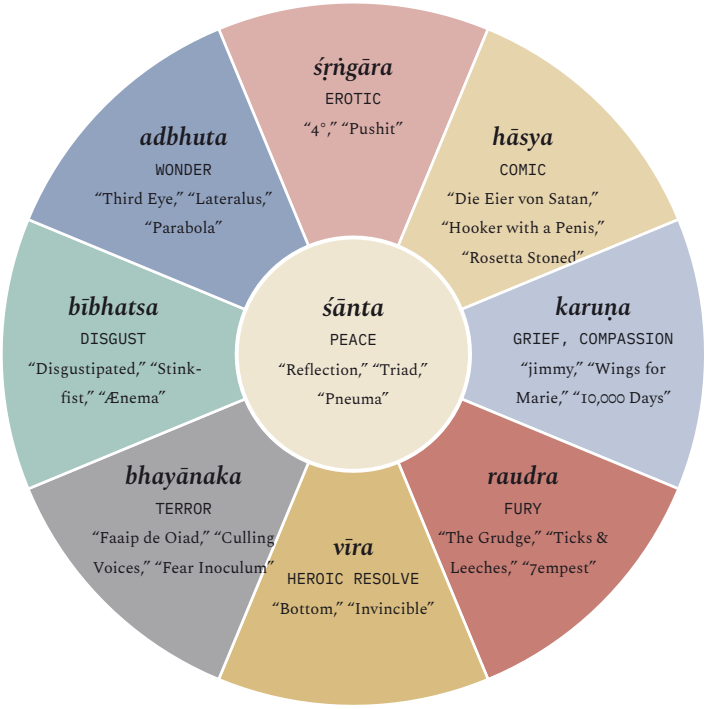


FIG. 8 **The nine rasas of the corpus.** Abhinavagupta's aesthetic flavors with exemplary tracks. **Śānta**, peace, sits at the center as the ground into which the others resolve.

Isaac Luria's sixteenth-century Kabbalah supplies the cosmological version and its warning. In the beginning, the vessels meant to hold the divine light shattered because they could not contain it—the *shevirat ha-kelim*—and sparks of light fell into husks of impurity, the *kelippot*. Human work, *tikkun*, raises the sparks. The breaking of the vessels is the cosmic form of an overdose: light in excess of its container. The doctrine had a catastrophe. The followers of Sabbatai Zevi, and later Jacob Frank, concluded that the sparks must be redeemed by entering impurity deliberately, through transgression; Gershom Scholem named this "redemption through sin" (1937). It marks the theological limit of the doctrine of toxic benefit: without a vessel, the descent into the poison becomes the poison.

In the Islamic tradition, al-Ghazālī's *al-Munqidh min al-ḍalāl* (c. 1100) narrates a crisis in which his tongue was locked so that he could not lecture, and physicians declared the cause to lie in the heart rather than the body. His cure was the Sufi path. The theologian's crisis was a seizure of the throat, and the Sufis called their masters physicians of hearts. Rumi's poem of the guest house, which counsels welcoming every arrival, sorrow included, as a guide sent from beyond, belongs in the same family as Keats's vale of soul-making.

13.4 Hellenistic therapy

Epicurus's doctrine survives, in Philodemus's summary, as the *tetrapharmakos*, the fourfold drug: god is not to be feared; death is not to be worried over; the good is easy to obtain; the terrible is easy to endure. The Stoics practiced the *praemeditatio malorum* (Seneca, *Epistulae* 24 and 91; Cicero, *Tusculan Disputations* III, citing Anaxagoras's response to news of his son's death that he had always known his son was mortal). Martha Nussbaum's *The Therapy of Desire* (1994) reconstructed the medical analogy at the heart of Hellenistic ethics; Pierre Hadot's *Exercices spirituels et philosophie antique* (1981) recovered ancient philosophy as a way of life; Michel Foucault's lectures of 1981–82 (*L'Herméneutique du sujet*, 2001) traced the care of the self. Peter Sloterdijk's *Du mußt dein Leben ändern* (2009), whose title is the last line of Rilke's "Archaïscher Torso Apollos" (1908), reads all religions as misunderstood training systems and the human being as the practicing animal.

The corpus belongs to this lineage of philosophy as therapy, with one difference that Nietzsche anticipated. The Hellenistic schools aimed at tranquility—*ataraxia*, *apatheia*—and their remedies quiet the passions. The corpus keeps the passions and makes them bearable. Its goal is not the absence of disturbance but the capacity to carry it. In the terms of 13.2, it seeks *rasa*, not *ataraxia*.

13.5 The sciences of toxic benefit

Paracelsus formulated the founding principle in 1538: only the dose makes the poison (*Septem Defensiones*). Hugo Schulz observed in 1888 that low doses of disinfectants stimulated the yeast that high doses killed; the phenomenon, later called hormesis, was dismissed for most of the twentieth century and rehabilitated by Edward Calabrese and Linda Baldwin ("Toxicology rethinks its central belief," *Nature* 421, 2003). Nassim Nicholas Taleb's *Antifragile* (2012) generalized hormesis and mithridatization into a theory of systems that gain from disorder.

Psychology arrived at the same principle by several routes. McGuire's inoculation theory of persuasion (1961; 1964) and its contemporary development in prebunking (Roozenbeek and van der Linden, 2019; van der Linden, *Foolproof*, 2023) treat belief as an immune system. Meichenbaum's stress inoculation training (1985) treats anxiety the same way. Exposure therapy, from Joseph Wolpe's systematic desensitization (*Psychotherapy by Reciprocal Inhibition*, 1958) to Edna Foa and Michael Kozak's theory of emotional processing (*Psychological Bulletin* 99, 1986), supplies the most precise clinical statement: exposure heals only when it activates the fear structure and introduces information incompatible with it. The dose must reach the fear and remain contained enough for learning to occur. That is the mithridatic principle in clinical form.

Richard Tedeschi and Lawrence Calhoun's Posttraumatic Growth Inventory (*Journal of Traumatic Stress* 9, 1996) measured the growth some survivors report in relationships, sense of possibility, personal strength, spiritual life and appreciation

of life. It is Lachrymology's empirical analogue, with the caveats its own literature insists upon: growth coexists with distress rather than replacing it, and self-reported growth may sometimes be a coping illusion. And psychedelic science has supplied a neuroscience of Huxley's reducing valve. Robin Carhart-Harris and Karl Friston's "REBUS and the Anarchic Brain" (*Pharmacological Reviews* 71, 2019) proposes that psychedelics relax the brain's high-level priors, permitting entrenched beliefs to be revised. The clinic of "Lost Keys" has been built.

13.6 Synthesis

From Nāgārjuna to Foa and Kozak, one principle recurs: harm, dosed and contained, becomes capacity. The corpus's distinctiveness lies not in the principle but in three features of its practice. Its medium is a mass aesthetic rather than a monastery, a clinic or a school. It refuses a doctrinal container, so that no one can be expelled from it for heresy. And it insists on keeping the passions alive, seeking *rasa* rather than quietude. These three features are what Part IV must explain.

PART

IV

The Original Synthesis

A Theory of Mithridatic Gnosis



Part IV states the theory in eight propositions. Chapter 14 sets out its structure: a grammar (the pharmakological tetrad), a morphology (the spiral dose), an agent (the Nīlakaṇṭha function of the voice) and a vessel (number as *vas hermeticum*). Chapter 15 sets out its safeguards and outcomes—iconoclasm, pedagogy, vision, community—and tests the whole against its strongest objections.



CHAPTER 14

Toward a Theory of Mithridatic Gnosis I

Grammar, Morphology, Agent, Vessel

FOUR PROPOSITIONS DEFINE THE structure of the corpus's operation. The first says what the corpus manipulates; the second, in what temporal shape; the third, through which organ; the fourth, within what container. Together they explain how a body of work built from poison can function as an antidote, and why its antidote does not become a new opiate.

Proposition I The pharmakological tetrad

> *The corpus is generated by four terms of a single Greek family, each of which implies the others: pharmakon, pharmakos, pharmakeus, pharmakeia.*

Pharmakon is the drug: remedy and poison, charm and, in some uses, dye or pigment. *Pharmakos* is the human scapegoat expelled from the city at the Thargelia. *Pharmakeus* is the one who prepares drugs: physician, poisoner, sorcerer. Diotima, in Plato's *Symposium* (203d), calls Eros himself a formidable *goēs kai pharmakeus kai sophistēs*, a wizard, sorcerer and sophist. *Pharmakeia* is the practice of drugging and enchantment; Paul lists it among the works of the flesh (Galatians 5:20), and the Apocalypse charges Babylon with deceiving all nations by it (Revelation 18:23). Homer had already split the pharmakon into Circe's *kaka pharmaka* and Hermes's *pharmakon esthlon* (*Odyssey* X).

Each phase of the corpus foregrounds one term. *Opiate* and *Undertow* foreground *pharmakeia*, the clerical narcotic and the poisonous pedagogy of the household, and *pharmakon* as poison. *Ænima* foregrounds the *pharmakos*: the false martyr, the city flushed into the sea, the crowd roaring at a recipe. *Lateralus* foregrounds the *pharmakon* as remedy: the spiral, the sanctified body. *10,000 Days* foregrounds the

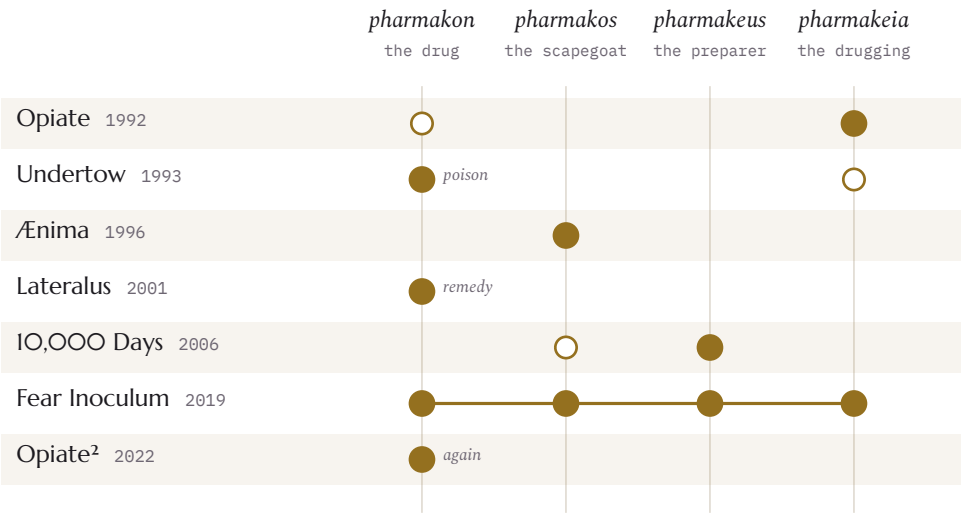


FIG. 9 **The tetrad across the releases.** Each phase foregrounds one term of the pharmak- family, and the last reintegrates all four. Filled marks a dominant term, open a secondary one.

pharmakeus: the physician and the nurse, the chemist named in a title, the son who heals by remembering, the hypocrite who poses as healer in "The Pot." *Fear Inoculum* reintegrates all four: the deceiver as *pharmakeus* of fear, the swine of Gerasa as *pharmakoi*, the witch-hunt as *pharmakeia*, the inoculum as counter-*pharmakon*.

The grammar has one rule. No term is permitted to stand alone. A remedy always remembers its poison: the illusory pain of "Parabola" is earned by the real pain of *Undertow*. A scapegoat always accuses its expellers: "Vicarious" names the viewer. A healer is always also a patient: the prophet of "Rosetta Stoned" lies in a hospital bed. A mass drugging always has its antidote: the contagion of fear is met by an inoculum. The rule distinguishes the corpus from moralism, which separates remedy and poison absolutely, and from nihilism, which collapses them into indifference.

It also corrects the most influential modern theory of the pharmakon. For Derrida, the *pharmakon* is *undecidable*, neither remedy nor poison and both at once, and his reading of the *Phaedrus* makes that undecidability the condition of writing itself. The corpus agrees in principle and disagrees in practice. What decides is the dose, the vessel and the agent. Undecidable in the abstract, the pharmakon becomes decidable in use. The corpus sets Paracelsus against Derrida: the pharmakon's identity is not a property of the substance but a function of its administration. I call this property *dosability*.

A Galenic corollary. The tetrad has a physiological correlate. Classical medicine, from the Hippocratic writings through Galen, treated disease largely as a corruption or excess of the humors and cured it by evacuation through the body's emunctories, its organs of discharge: sudorifics opened the skin, clysters and purgatives the bowel, phlebotomy the veins, expectorants the lungs. The corpus traverses every route. It

opens with "Sweat" (O.1); its founding fiction is a philosophy of tears; *Ænima* names the clyster; "Ticks & Leeches" (L.8) bleeds the singer; "Pneuma" (FI.2) ends in exhalation. Read in sequence, the routes rise from the skin through the gut and the blood to the breath, from the grossest discharge to the subtlest, which is also the Valentinian ascent from matter to spirit. The organ that in this medicine metabolizes rather than expels is the liver, and myth supplies it: Prometheus, chained for the theft of fire, has his liver eaten each day by an eagle, and each night it grows back. He is the patient of a daily dose that does not kill him. The corpus's movement from evacuation to metabolism is a movement from the emunctories to his organ.

Proposition II The spiral dose

> *The corpus administers its material in a morphology of recurrence-with-increment: the same toxic content returns at a larger radius, each time with more of it metabolized.*

The spiral dose is defined against two alternatives. The first is the circle of compulsion: Freud's *Wiederholungszwang*, the locked groove of "Useful Idiot," the dwarf's closed ring in *Zarathustra*. The second is the line of progress, a dialectic read teleologically, in which each stage cancels its predecessor and the past is left behind. The spiral neither repeats nor abandons. It returns to the same center at a greater distance, and its defining property is the one Bernoulli inscribed on his tomb: the same, changed, rising again. In D'Arcy Thompson's terms, its growth is gnomonic—scale increases while shape is preserved.

The corpus's evidence for the spiral is formal and thematic. Formally, it pairs and reprises: "Parabol" and "Parabola"; the two "Message to Harry Manback" recordings on *Ænima* and *Salival*; "Intermission" and "jimmy"; the two parts of "Wings"; *Opiate* and *Opiate*^{2}. Thematically, it returns: the mother from "jimmy" (1996) to "Wings" (2006); the cookies from "Die Eier von Satan" (1996) to "Chocolate Chip Trip" (2019); the water from "Flood" through "Ænema" and the storm of "10,000 Days" to the waves of "Descending"; spirits in "Sober" and spirit in "Pneuma"; Saturn ascending in "The Grudge" and Saturn returning in "10,000 Days"; the eye from "Third Eye" to the *Inoculum*. And the spiral is figured in the form itself, in the Fibonacci architecture of "Lateralus."

The Fibonacci recurrence offers a heuristic model of the dose. If each re-administration combines the present dose with the one before it, successive doses grow by a ratio that converges on φ:

$$D_{n+1} = D_n + D_{n-1}, \quad \lim_{n\to\infty} \frac{D_{n+1}}{D_n} = \varphi = \frac{1+\sqrt{5}}{2}$$

The model is a figure, not a measurement. Its point is that the growth it describes is gnomonic: each turn is larger and the same shape. A second condition, borrowed from Foa and Kozak's account of exposure, defines the therapeutic window within which each dose must fall. It must exceed the threshold at which the fear structure is activated, or nothing is learned; and it must remain below the capacity of the vessel, or the vessel breaks:

$$\theta_{\text{activation}} < D_n < \kappa_{\text{vessel}}$$

The spiral has a direction, and the direction is the criterion that distinguishes the healing spiral from its counterfeit. A spiral that turns inward is a vortex: addiction's descending spiral, paranoia's tightening circle, the escalation of "Stinkfist" in which the radius grows while the center remains undigested. A spiral that turns outward is a helix. "Lateralus" specifies the outward turn. Escalation without metabolism is a vortex; escalation with metabolism is the spiral dose.

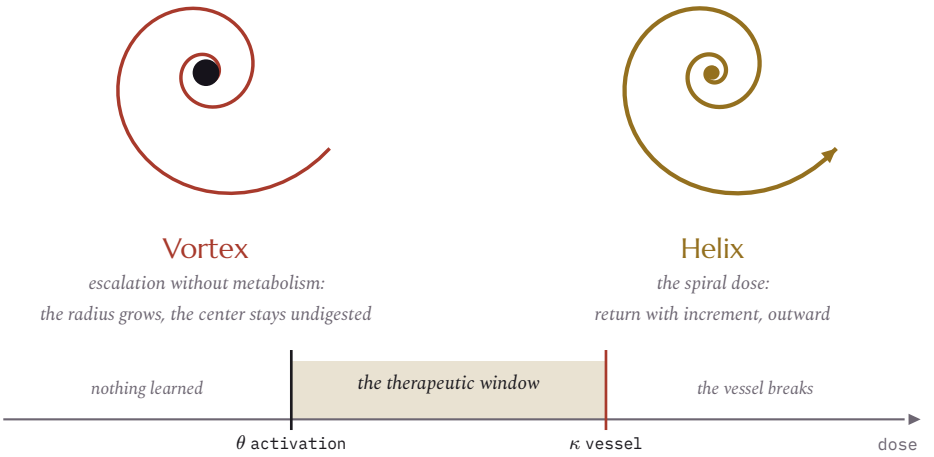


FIG. 10 **Vortex and helix; the therapeutic window.** Escalation without metabolism tightens inward; the spiral dose turns outward, each return larger and the same shape. Below, the window in which a dose teaches: above activation, below the vessel's capacity.

Proposition III The Nīlakaṇṭha function

> *The voice is the agent of transmutation: the singer holds the poison in the throat, neither swallowing it nor spitting it out, until it becomes tone.*

In the churning of the ocean, Śiva drinks the *halāhala* to save the worlds. Had he swallowed it, the cosmos within him would have perished; had he spat it out, it would have poisoned the cosmos without. He holds it in his throat, which turns blue. The throat is the site of suspension, and in Tantric physiology the throat center, *viśuddha*, is the center both of voice and of the conversion of poison into nectar. Nietzsche's shepherd, choking on a black snake lodged in his throat, completes the image from the West: he neither swallows nor spits but bites, and rises laughing. Al-Ghazālī's crisis seized his tongue. The talk box of "Jambi" routes the guitar through a human mouth.

The singer's function, so understood, is neither expression, which spits the affect out, nor repression, which swallows it. It is suspension and transmutation: affect held in the throat long enough to become tone, which is exactly what Abhinavagupta's *rasa* theory describes as the conversion of private emotion into savorable form. Keenan's vocal practice embodies the function in three ways. It moves between whisper and scream rather than residing in either, so that the throat's full range is the instrument of modulation. It sustains: the long-held notes and the long scream of "The Grudge" are the poison held in the throat until it changes. And it is self-effacing: the voice is often set within the ensemble rather than above it, and the singer stands at the back of the stage. The throat is an alembic, not a pulpit.

The function is distributed to the listener. A listener who sings along takes the transmuted affect into his own throat, which becomes a secondary alembic; the inoculum is administered through the listener's voice as well as his ear. And the function is sacrificial without being self-destructive. Śiva does not die, because Pārvatī's hand at his throat stops the poison's descent. The poison-holder requires another's hand. In the corpus, that hand is the collective—the band that surrounds the voice, the audience that receives it. The Nīlakaṇṭha function is a solitary act that cannot be performed alone.

Proposition IV Number as *vas hermeticum*

> *The corpus's metric and structural architecture is a sealed vessel, which allows toxic content to be heated without explosion, and produces what this dissertation calls the inoculative sublime.*

The alchemist's vessel permits the *prima materia* to be dissolved, putrefied and transformed without escaping or bursting. The corpus's numbers function the same way: the polymeters and odd meters, the Fibonacci and heptadic schemes, the long

durations of gradual accumulation. They contain in three distinct ways. First, they render complexity predictable. A listener can count, entrain and anticipate even an irregular meter, and the demand for active counting compels the kind of divided attention Gurdjieff's Movements were designed to produce. Second, they titrate. The slow builds of "Third Eye," "Reflection" and "7empest" administer intensity in increments, as Plato's cave administers light. Third, they prevent anaesthesia. A regular beat can be heard absent-mindedly; an irregular one cannot. The odd meter answers Adorno's complaint against standardization at the level of the pulse.

The effect is a kind of sublime. Edmund Burke argued that terror is the source of the sublime, but that danger pressing too nearly is simply terrible, whereas "at certain distances, and with certain modifications," it is delightful (*A Philosophical Enquiry*, 1757, I.vii). Kant's dynamical sublime (*Kritik der Urteilskraft*, 1790, §28) requires that we contemplate nature's might from a position of safety. Both theories locate the safety in distance: the spectator on the shore watches the storm. The corpus relocates it. The listener stands inside the storm, and the safety is supplied not by distance but by form. I call this the *inoculative sublime*: a sublime in which the modification that makes terror bearable is formal rather than spatial, in which the subject is participant rather than spectator, and whose effect is not momentary delight but lasting capacity. Burke's sublime is a view; Kant's, an elevation; the inoculative sublime is a training.

The vessel can fail in two ways. It can break, when the dose exceeds its capacity. The Lurianic breaking of the vessels is the cosmic image, and the overdose fictions of Chapter 12 are its human ones. It can also be empty, when number replaces the dose instead of containing it. Hesse's Castalia, where music and mathematics have become a self-sufficient game, is a vessel without content. The corpus avoids the second failure by binding its numbers to a body—the syllables of "Lateralus" are sung by a breathing throat about the desire of the flesh—and the first by the safeguard described in the next chapter.

Synthesis

The four propositions describe one operation. The tetrad names what is manipulated: a pharmakon whose terms never separate. The spiral dose names its temporal form: return with increment, outward. The Nīlakaṇṭha function names its agent: a throat that holds what it cannot swallow or spit, supported by others. And number as vessel names its container, which makes the terrible sublime by training rather than by distance. What remains to be explained is how such an operation protects itself from becoming what it treats.



CHAPTER 15

Toward a Theory of Mithridatic Gnosis II

Safeguard, Pedagogy, Vision, Community, and Limits

FOUR FURTHER PROPOSITIONS DESCRIBE how the operation protects itself and what it produces: an iconoclasm that functions as an immune response, a pedagogy of pattern administered in microdoses, a mode of vision that has metabolized its poison, and a community constituted by shared exposure rather than by expulsion or exemption. The chapter then tests the theory against the seven strongest objections to it.

Proposition V The Hezekiah principle

> *The corpus breaks its own idols before veneration can harden them, and this self-iconoclasm functions as a salutary autoimmunity.*

The bronze serpent of Numbers 21 healed those who looked upon it. Generations later the people burned incense to it, and Hezekiah broke it in pieces and called it a thing of brass (2 Kings 18:4). A remedy that becomes an object of worship has become an opiate, and the only cure is to break the remedy. The corpus does this systematically. It founded a religion, Lachrymology, and let it die. Its lyricist has declined for three decades to explain his lyrics, so that no authorized meaning can become dogma. He stands at the back of the stage, beside the drummer and often in shadow, while projected images occupy the center. The band prohibits phone recording, so that no image of the singer circulates as a relic. Its own songs mock its sacred sounds and its purists: "Mantra" is a cat, "Faaip de Oiad" sets the voice of God under a broadcast of panic, "Hooker with a Penis" turns on the fan who would keep the band pure. Puscifer satirizes the whole apparatus.

Derrida's late concept of autoimmunity ("Foi et savoir," 1996; *Voyous*, 2003) names the process by which a living system attacks its own protections. He regarded it chiefly as a catastrophe, but also as an opening: the self-wounding that exposes a system to what is other and to come. The Hezekiah principle is autoimmunity in its salutary form. The corpus attacks its own immunities—its mystique, its authority, its aura—so that the remedy cannot become a narcotic. Two precedents frame it. Wagner darkened the auditorium at Bayreuth in 1876 to concentrate attention, a cult value the band revives; but Wagner made himself the idol, and Nietzsche's break with him (*Nietzsche contra Wagner*, 1889) is the archetypal refusal of a remedy turned idol. Prospero breaks his staff and drowns his book at the height of his power. The corpus reproduces Bayreuth's darkness and Prospero's renunciation together.

Proposition VI Apophenic pedagogy

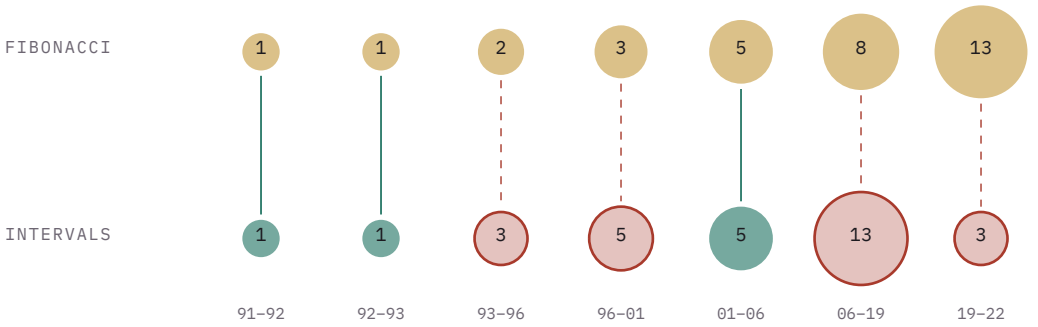
> *The corpus seeds patterns that almost cohere, training two capacities at once: the perception of pattern, without which meaning is impossible, and its suspension, without which pattern becomes paranoia.*

Klaus Conrad coined *Apophänie* in 1958 (*Die beginnende Schizophrenie*) for the unmotivated perception of meaningful connection in the onset of psychosis. In its social overdose, apophenia is conspiracism. Its absence is meaninglessness. The corpus administers it in microdoses, and its specimens are many.

The first is the band's own. Danny Carey's account of "Lateralus" records that the meters of nine, eight and seven came first and that their identity as the sixteenth Fibonacci number was noticed afterwards (Loaded Radio). The band perceived a pattern in its own work and then built deliberately upon it. That is apophenia converted into design, and it models the use of pattern the corpus teaches: find, test, adopt, and keep the record of how it was found.

The second is chronological. The intervals between releases—from *72826* (1991) to *Opiate* (1992), to *Undertow* (1993), to *Ænima* (1996), to *Lateralus* (2001), to *10,000 Days* (2006), to *Fear Inoculum* (2019), to *Opiate*^{2} (2022)—run one, one, three, five, five, thirteen, three. The sequence is almost Fibonacci and is not: it lacks two and eight and repeats five. A listener can complete it only by hallucinating the missing terms or by accepting the remainder. The third is the distance from the *anima* of 17 September 1996 to the "Pneuma" of 30 August 2019: twenty-three years less eighteen days, almost exactly the number of the album that ends on "Viginti Tres." The fourth is the spiral on Bernoulli's tomb in Basel, carved as the wrong spiral by a mason, in the city where Hofmann discovered LSD. The fifth is the "Holy Gift," the audience's reconstruction of *Lateralus* as a loop.

This dissertation records these coincidences as specimens, not proofs. They demonstrate how the corpus works on its listeners. It invites pattern-seeking, rewards it partially, and withholds closure. Keats defined the capacity this trains in



*and from **Ænima** to "Pneuma": twenty-three years less eighteen days*

FIG. 11 **The near-miss.** Release intervals set against the Fibonacci series, position by position. Three agree and the rest almost do; to complete the pattern one must invent the missing terms or accept the remainder.

his letter of December 1817: "Negative Capability, that is when man is capable of being in uncertainties, Mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact & reason." Robert Anton Wilson called it model agnosticism, and Eco defended it as the limit of interpretation. McGuire's inoculation theory supplies the mechanism. Weakened forms of an argument, met and resisted, confer resistance to its full form. The corpus's near-patterns are weakened conspiracy theories. Its songs supply the refutations: "Culling Voices" diagnoses the paranoid overdose, "Rosetta Stoned" mocks the chosen one, and "Viginti Tres" ends an album on a joke about numerology. The fan cultures that have grown around the band, with their forums of decipherment, are the training ground. A mass audience has been practicing, for thirty years, how to seek pattern without being consumed by it.

Proposition VII Pavonine vision

> *The corpus opposes two orders of vision—the panoptic, which watches in order to control, and the pavonine, which has transmuted poison into sight—and its central word, inoculum, names the passage from one to the other.*

In Ovid's telling (*Metamorphoses* I.583–750), Hera set the hundred-eyed Argus Panoptes to guard Io. Hermes lulled him to sleep with the music of the reed pipe and a story, and then killed him; Hera set his eyes in the tail of the peacock. Music closed the watchman's eyes, and the eyes became ornament.

The panoptic order runs from Argus through Jeremy Bentham's Panopticon (1791) to Michel Foucault's analysis of disciplinary visibility (*Surveiller et punir*, 1975), and the corpus registers it repeatedly: in the spectator of "Vicarious," in the self-surveilling agent of Dick's *A Scanner Darkly*, in the forest of raised phones at any

concert. The band's prohibition of phone recording is Hermes's lullaby. Music closes the hundred eyes so that vision can occur otherwise.

The pavonine order runs from the peacock of Dharmarakṣita's poem, which eats poison and grows brighter, through Ezekiel's wheels full of eyes and Alex Grey's multiplied eyes, to the torso in Rilke's sonnet, in which there is no place that does not see you, and which commands not obedience but change. Odin gave one eye to Mímir's well in exchange for wisdom (*Völuspá* 28): an eye surrendered for vision.

The etymology seals the proposition. The Latin *inoculare* meant to graft a bud—an *oculus*, an eye—into the stock of another plant. The medical sense entered English after 1714, when Emanuel Timonius reported to the Royal Society the Ottoman practice of procuring smallpox "by incision, or inoculation." To inoculate is to engraft an eye. The corpus's visionary thread, from "Third Eye" in 1996, and its pharmacological thread, from *Opiate* in 1992, converge in a single word in 2019. *Fear Inoculum* is the graft of an eye into fear: fear made to see rather than to blind, or to watch others. Pavonine vision is perception that has metabolized its poison into sight.

Proposition VIII *Communitas inoculata*

> *The corpus constitutes a community by shared, graduated exposure—neither by the expulsion of a scapegoat nor by the exemption of immunity, but by co-ingestion.*

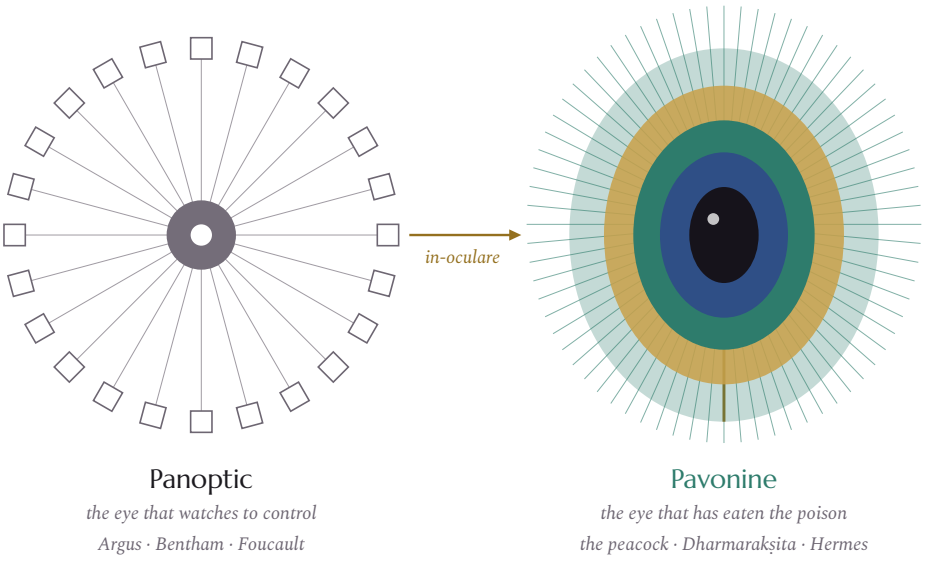


FIG. 12 **Panoptic and pavonine.** Argus's hundred eyes watch in order to control; Hermes's music closes them, and they pass into the peacock's tail. To inoculate, in its first sense, is to engraft an eye.

Roberto Esposito's trilogy (*Communitas*, 1998; *Immunitas*, 2002; *Bíos*, 2004) derives both words from *munus*, a gift that obliges. Community is the sharing of the obligation; immunity is exemption from it. Modern politics, Esposito argues, is organized by an immunitary paradigm that protects life by incorporating the negative in small doses, and that tends, at its extreme, toward autoimmune catastrophe. In the last volume of the trilogy that catastrophe has a name: the Nazi state, which presented its murder of six million European Jews, together with Roma, disabled people and others it classed as threats, as the immunization of the German people's body against infection. Against it he sought an affirmative biopolitics. Sloterdijk proposed a global co-immunism (*Du mußt dein Leben ändern*, 2009). Victor Turner described *communitas* as the bond formed among those who share a liminal passage (*The Ritual Process*, 1969).

The corpus's community is of a fourth kind. Its concerts are liminal enclosures: darkness, the absence of cameras, forms too long to be consumed as fragments. Its listeners undergo the same dose together, and its exegetical labor—the shared work of decipherment—is a *munus* in the strict sense, an obligation accepted as a gift. The inoculum does not exempt its recipients from the community, as Esposito's immunity does. It binds them to it, because each carries a share of the poison so that none must carry it all. This is the Nīlakaṇṭha function distributed: a community of throats. It is the opposite of Girard's community, founded on the expulsion of one, and of Le Guin's Omelas, founded on the misery of one. I call it *communitas inoculata*. Epidemiology supplies its image: herd immunity, in which the inoculated protect even those who are not. A culture with enough members trained to hold fear without transmitting it is less hospitable to fear's contagion.

15.9 Objections and limits

1. The romanticization of suffering. Emmanuel Levinas argued that suffering is in itself useless, "for nothing," and that the justification of another's suffering is the source of all immorality ("La souffrance inutile," 1982). This is the gravest objection, and the theory concedes its core. Mithridatic gnosis is defensible only as a first-person practice: I may metabolize my own suffering; I may not prescribe yours. The corpus largely honors this limit. "Prison Sex" and "Vicarious" refuse to redeem the suffering of victims, and "10,000 Days" does not claim that the mother's paralysis was good, only that her faith was real. But Lachrymology's slogan of pain turned to profit flirts with the economy Levinas condemns, and the theory must exclude all imposed suffering explicitly: Kafka's apparatus, Burgess's Ludovico technique, Le Guin's Omelas.

2. Survivorship. Nietzsche's maxim is spoken by those whom the ordeal did not kill. Post-traumatic growth coexists with lasting harm, and some suffering only diminishes. Carey's own gloss on the Lachrymology hoax acknowledged that many who cannot master the art die by suicide (Contemporary Musicians, via Encyclopedia.com); the doctrine knows its casualties. Mithridates himself could not

die by poison and had to be killed by a sword. Immunity has costs, and an honest theory names them.

3. Masculinist agonism. The warrior ethos of "Invincible," Castaneda, Rollins and Nietzsche, which has a biographical root in Keenan's three years of Army service, risks valuing endurance over care, and the corpus's women are few: the mother, the anima. The theory's own structure answers in part. "10,000 Days" relocates heroism in a paralyzed woman's faith, and the Nīlakaṇṭha function requires Pārvatī's hand at the throat. The concession stands nonetheless: the corpus's gender imaginary is narrow.

4. Commodification. The rage of "Ticks & Leeches" coexists with deluxe editions, premium tickets and merchandise; occulture is also a market, the "spiritual supermarket" of religious-studies critique, and Adorno would recognize pseudo-individualization in deluxe esotericism. The Hezekiah principle can itself be sold as mystique; the anti-idol can become an idol. The corpus's defense is partial: its demands—length, difficulty, the absence of explanation—resist easy consumption.

5. Overinterpretation. This dissertation is itself an instance of the apophenia it describes. Its claims are therefore graded (documented, attested-milieu, elective), and its numerical coincidences are offered as specimens. The decisive test is whether the central claim survives without the numerology. It does. The titles alone—*Opiate*, *Ænima*, "Lost Keys (Blame Hofmann)," *Fear Inoculum*, *Opiate*^{2}—carry the arc from anaesthesia to immunity.

6. Entheogenic romance and appropriation. The corpus's psychedelic matrix risks romanticizing substances with real dangers and contraindications, and "Lipan Conjuring" raises the question of borrowing Indigenous sacred forms. The corpus resolves neither problem; the theory records both.

7. The doctrine in the wrong hands. The language of inoculation can justify exposing others to harm for their own good, and Alice Miller's poisonous pedagogy is precisely such a justification. The theory's first ethical axiom answers it: the dose is never administered to another without consent. Art offers what pedagogy of poison imposes. The listener can always stop the record.

CONCLUSION

The Patient

THE CORPUS OF TOOL, read as a whole, is a post-secular theriac: an antidote compounded from the flesh of the serpent, administered in a spiral of doses, through a throat that holds what it cannot swallow, within a vessel of number, by a work that breaks its own idols, to a community that shares the poison so that no one must carry all of it. Its arc runs from an opiate to an inoculum, from a drug that removes pain by removing the person to a dose that keeps the person by teaching them to hold pain. And its exemplary figure, as the Introduction proposed, is neither the hero, nor the prophet, nor the initiate, but the patient.

The word has three senses, and the corpus distributes them across its course. The patient is the one who suffers: the drowning world of *Undertow*, the violated child, the craving that cannot bear sobriety. The patient is the one who waits: the exhausted endurance of "The Patient," the son's twenty-seven years beside a paralyzed mother, the thirteen years before the inoculum. And the patient is the one who is treated: the man in the hospital bed of "Lost Keys," the listener who has consented to the dose. The hero acts; the prophet transmits; the initiate ascends. The patient undergoes, and in undergoing is changed. Campbell's monomyth, Herbert's messiah and the Gnostic elect are all rejected in favor of this figure, and the rejection is the corpus's deepest ethical decision. It is also the corpus's answer to Socrates.

Socrates, executed by the Athenian court with the hemlock that Plato calls simply *to pharmakon*, died asking that a rooster be offered to Asclepius, the payment owed for a cure, and Nietzsche read the request as a verdict that life is a long illness and death its remedy. The state's poison, on that reading, became the philosopher's medicine. The corpus does not pay that debt. It does not treat death as cure. It offers the healing god something else: not the rooster of the dying philosopher but the voice of the living patient, the throat that has held its poison long enough to sing. In place of Socrates's last words it sets the son's farewell in "10,000 Days," which gives the dead mother to the sky without asking death to heal the living, and the old warrior of "Invincible," who keeps practicing without pretending he cannot fall.

The three epigraphs can now be read as a single sentence. Dante's ancestor tells him that his voice will taste bitter and leave nourishment once digested. That is the corpus's poetics: the bitter dose, the vital digestion. The Lord tells Moses to raise a serpent on a pole, so that whoever is bitten and looks upon it will live. That is

the corpus's iconography: the image of the poison as the cure, the eye that heals by looking. And Housman's last line notes that Mithridates died old. That is the corpus's promise and its warning together. The king who trained himself on poison lived long, and could not die by poison when he wished to; immunity is a gift and a sentence.

What the corpus adds to these three is the fourth term without which the serpent would become an idol: Hezekiah's hammer. The bronze serpent healed until it was worshipped, and then it had to be broken. Every remedy that succeeds will be venerated, and every venerated remedy becomes an opiate. A work that wishes to remain a remedy must therefore carry within it the means of its own iconoclasm, and must hand its listeners not a creed but a practice. TOOL's corpus has done this with a consistency rare in any art, let alone in one that has topped the charts. It founded a church in order to let it die; it built mathematical cathedrals and filled them with a cat's cry slowed down; it gave the voice of God to a frightened caller on late-night radio; it named an album for a vaccine and ended it with a mockingbird.

The dissertation began with the pharmacy at the end of the century and ends in the clinic, among patients. Their condition is not cured; it is held. The poison is still in the throat, and the throat is singing. That, in the end, is what this corpus means by gnosis: not the knowledge that delivers us from the serpent, but the knowledge of how to carry it—outward, along the spiral, in company, without worship, until the bite becomes a voice.

APPENDIX A

Concordance of Phases

THE TABLE COLLECTS THE coordinates assigned to each release in Part II, in the order of the course of treatment.

1992 · ANAESTHETIC
Opiate

IMMUNOLOGICAL ANALOGUE
The narcotic diagnosed

ALCHEMICAL OPERATION
Calcinatio; onset of *nigredo*

GROFIAN MATRIX
Threshold of BPM II

DANTEAN LOCUS
The dark wood

NIETZSCHEAN FIGURE
The herd before the camel

SERPENT
Eden's serpent as clerical seducer

DOMINANT TETRAD TERM
Pharmakeia

1993 · TOXICOLOGICAL
Undertow

IMMUNOLOGICAL ANALOGUE
Variolation

ALCHEMICAL OPERATION
Solutio; *nigredo*

GROFIAN MATRIX
BPM II

DANTEAN LOCUS
Inferno, down to Cocytus

NIETZSCHEAN FIGURE
Camel

SERPENT
Halāhala rising from the churned ocean

DOMINANT TETRAD TERM
Pharmakon as poison

1996 · PURGATIVE

Ænima

IMMUNOLOGICAL ANALOGUE
Vaccination by a milder relative

ALCHEMICAL OPERATION
Putrefactio, *mortificatio*

GROFIAN MATRIX
BPM III

DANTEAN LOCUS
Malebolge

NIETZSCHEAN FIGURE
Lion

SERPENT
Python rotting at Delphi

DOMINANT TETRAD TERM
Pharmakos

2001 · ENTHEOGENIC

Lateralus

IMMUNOLOGICAL ANALOGUE
Attenuation

ALCHEMICAL OPERATION
Sublimatio, *coagulatio*; *albedo*

GROFIAN MATRIX
BPM IV opening onto BPM I

DANTEAN LOCUS
Purgatorio

NIETZSCHEAN FIGURE
Child

SERPENT
Kundalini

DOMINANT TETRAD TERM
Pharmakon as remedy

2006 · MNEMONIC

10,000 Days

IMMUNOLOGICAL ANALOGUE
Immunological memory

ALCHEMICAL OPERATION
Coniunctio; *rubedo*

GROFIAN MATRIX
The biographical mother behind the matrix

DANTEAN LOCUS
Paradiso

NIETZSCHEAN FIGURE
The child grown old

SERPENT
Asclepius's rod

DOMINANT TETRAD TERM
Pharmakeus

2019 · IMMUNOLOGICAL

Fear Inoculum

IMMUNOLOGICAL ANALOGUE
Inoculum; herd immunity

ALCHEMICAL OPERATION
Multiplicatio, *projectio*

GROFIAN MATRIX
Transpersonal

DANTEAN LOCUS
The return to earth

NIETZSCHEAN FIGURE
Convalescent; *senex*

SERPENT
Vāsuki and Nīlakaṇṭha; the caduceus

DOMINANT TETRAD TERM
All four reintegrated

2022 · RECURSIVE

Opiate²

IMMUNOLOGICAL ANALOGUE

Booster

ALCHEMICAL OPERATION

Iteratio, the work repeated at a higher degree

GROFIAN MATRIX

BPM II revisited from outside

DANTEAN LOCUS

The dark wood revisited

NIETZSCHEAN FIGURE

Recurrence as spiral

SERPENT

The ouroboros opened into a helix

DOMINANT TETRAD TERM

Pharmakon re-administered

APPENDIX B

Glossary of Terms Introduced

Apophenic pedagogy. The corpus's practice of seeding near-patterns that reward partial recognition and withhold closure, training both the perception of pattern and its suspension (Chapter 15, Proposition VI).

Booster. The re-administration of the corpus's first dose at a higher power in *Opiate²* (2022), which consolidates rather than repeats (Chapter 11).

***Communitas inoculata*.** A community constituted by shared, graduated exposure to a poison, distinct from Girard's community founded on expulsion and Esposito's immunity founded on exemption (Chapter 15, Proposition VIII).

Dosability. The property by which a pharmakon, undecidable in the abstract, becomes decidable in use through dose, vessel and agent; the corpus's correction of Derrida (Chapter 14, Proposition I).

Elective affinity. A structural relation between the corpus and a source that makes no claim about intention; tier E of the grading scheme (Note on Method).

Helix and vortex. The outward-turning, healing form of the spiral dose and its inward-turning, pathological counterfeit (Chapter 14, Proposition II).

Hezekiah principle. The corpus's systematic breaking of its own idols before veneration can harden them; a salutary autoimmunity (Chapter 15, Proposition V).

Inoculative sublime. A sublime in which the modification that makes terror bearable is formal rather than spatial, the subject participant rather than spectator, and the effect lasting capacity rather than momentary delight (Chapter 14, Proposition IV).

Lateral paratexts. Keenan's parallel projects and viticulture, read as commentaries on the main corpus (Note on Method; Chapter 6).

Mithridatic gnosis. Liberation through the graduated, form-contained ingestion of what harms, metabolized into capacity; distinguished from flight, evacuation and anaesthesia (Introduction).

Nīlakaṇṭha function. The voice's role as the site where poison is held, neither swallowed nor spat, until it becomes tone; it requires another's hand at the throat (Chapter 14, Proposition III).

Pavonine vision. Perception that has metabolized its poison into sight, opposed to panoptic vision, which watches in order to control; sealed by the etymology of *inoculare*, to engraft an eye (Chapter 15, Proposition VII).

Pharmakological tetrad. *Pharmakon*, *pharmakos*, *pharmakeus*, *pharmakeia*: the four interdependent terms that generate the corpus (Chapter 14, Proposition I).

Sacred hoax. A fiction offered as doctrine whose falsity is legible and whose effect outlasts belief; a self-dissolving myth, as in Lachrymology (Chapter 6).

Spiral dose. Recurrence with increment, in which the same toxic content returns at a larger radius with more of it metabolized each time (Chapter 14, Proposition II).

Theriac work. The artwork as an antidote compounded from the poison it treats, after Andromachus's theriac of viper flesh (Introduction; Conclusion).

Therapeutic window. The range within which each dose must fall: above the threshold that activates the fear structure, below the capacity of the vessel (Chapter 14, Proposition II).

***Vas hermeticum*.** The corpus's metric and structural architecture understood as a sealed vessel that contains toxic content during its transformation (Chapter 3; Chapter 14, Proposition IV).

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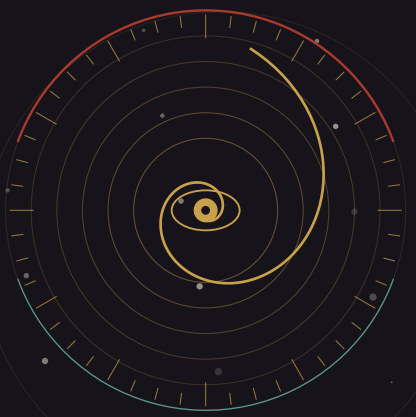
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KEYWORDS

TOOL ◆ MAYNARD JAMES KEENAN ◆ MITHRIDATIC GNOSIS ◆ PHARMAKON ◆ PHARMAKOS ◆ PHARMAKOLOGICAL TETRAD ◆ THERIAC ◆ INOCULATION ◆ IMMUNITAS AND COMMUNITAS ◆ CATHARSIS ◆ LACHRYMOLOGY ◆ SACRED HOAX ◆ JUNGIAN SHADOW ◆ INDIVIDUATION ◆ ANIMA ◆ NIETZSCHE ◆ ETERNAL RECURRENCE ◆ RESSENTIMENT ◆ SELF-OVERCOMING ◆ GURDJIEFF ◆ THE FOURTH WAY ◆ HERMETICISM ◆ ALCHEMY ◆ VAS HERMETICUM ◆ FIBONACCI SEQUENCE ◆ GOLDEN SPIRAL ◆ SACRED GEOMETRY ◆ PYTHAGOREAN HARMONY ◆ ENOCHIAN ◆ GNOSTICISM ◆ PNEUMA ◆ ENTHEOGENS ◆ ALBERT HOFMANN ◆ ELEUSINIAN MYSTERIES ◆ BILL HICKS ◆ STANISLAV GROF ◆ PERINATAL MATRICES ◆ KATABASIS ◆ SERPENT SYMBOLISM ◆ NĪLAKAṆṬHA ◆ RASA AESTHETICS ◆ THE SUBLIME ◆ INOCULATIVE SUBLIME ◆ APOPHENIA ◆ NEGATIVE CAPABILITY ◆ HEZEKIAH PRINCIPLE ◆ AUTOIMMUNITY ◆ PAVONINE VISION ◆ PANOPTICISM ◆ ROBERTO ESPOSITO ◆ RENÉ GIRARD ◆ SCAPEGOAT MECHANISM ◆ JACQUES DERRIDA ◆ OCCULTURE ◆ POST-SECULAR ◆ PROGRESSIVE METAL ◆ ALEX GREY ◆ FRANK HERBERT'S *DUNE* ◆ SPECULATIVE FICTION ◆ HORMESIS ◆ STRESS INOCULATION ◆ PREBUNKING ◆ POST-TRAUMATIC GROWTH ◆ PSYCHEDELIC-ASSISTED THERAPY



Mithridates, he died old.